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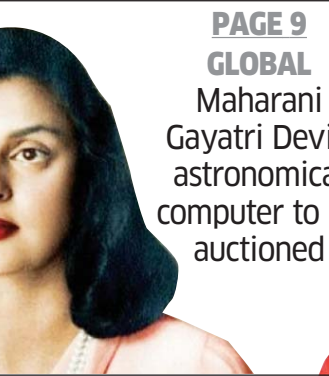
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Bhullar stays
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despite tough
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AGENDA



Centre overhauls NITI Aayog leadership team

Ashok Kumar Lahiri appointed as vice chairman with 4 new full-time members to drive strategic innovation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Centre on Saturday reconstituted the Niti Aayog, appointing former chief economic advisor Ashok Kumar Lahiri as vice chairman and five full-time members, including economist KV Raju, Director of AIIMS M Srinivas and Abhay Karandikar, Secretary, Department of Science and Technology. Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who is Chairman of the Niti Aayog, announced the appointments through his social media platform and wished the new body a productive and impactful tenure. "The Government has reconstituted the NITI Aayog. My best wishes to Ashok Kumar Lahiri on becoming the Vice Chairman. My best wishes also to Shri Rajiv Gauba ji, Prof KV Raju ji, Prof Gobardhan Das ji, Prof Abhay

Karandikar Ji and Dr M Srinivas Ji on becoming full-time members of NITI Aayog. Wishing all of them a productive and impactful tenure ahead," Modi said in a social media post. The new appointments come in the middle of the West Bengal Assembly elections as the second phase is due on April 29, and the ruling party, BJP at the Centre, is looking for a good prospect in the State to wrest power from the TMC after the first phase on April 23 witnessed a record polling. Lahiri is a sitting BJP MLA in the outgoing West Bengal Assembly and is being looked after as a much respected political and social figure in the State. While Das is a Dalit and had allegedly faced attacks from TMC cadre that followed in the 2021 Assembly polls. BJP strategist sources also



Prime Minister Narendra Modi, left, exchanges a handshake with newly-appointed Vice Chairman Ashok Lahiri PTI

Finance, Commerce & Industries Minister of the TMC Government. Lahiri called on the PM and thanked him for his appointment. Lahiri takes the place of Suman K Bery, who has been the vice chairman of Niti Aayog since May 2022. Vijay Kumar Saraswat, Ramesh Chand, Vinod Kumar Paul, Arvind Virmani and Gauba were the members. The PM said that the Niti Aayog has emerged as a vital pillar in India's policy-making architecture, fostering cooperative federalism, furthering reforms and boosting 'Ease of Living'. "It serves as a dynamic platform for innovation and Technology Education and Research, long-term strategic thinking across sectors," he said. Lahiri is amongst India's most experienced and senior economists with a career spanning over four decades. Currently a BJP MLA in West Bengal, he is a former chief economic advisor to the Government of India and a member of the 15th Finance Commission. He is not contesting the ongoing Assembly election in the State. While Raju is a member of the Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister. He also serves as the economic advisor to the chief minister of Uttar Pradesh. Karandikar is currently Secretary, Department of Science and Technology (DST). Before joining DST in October 2023, he served as the Director of IIT-Kanpur. Das is the director of the Indian Institute of Science Education and Research, Bhopal. Before assuming this position, he was working as a professor and chair of the Special Centre for Molecular Medicine at Jawaharlal Nehru University, New Delhi.

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Washington

President Donald Trump said on Saturday that US negotiators Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner will no longer be going to Pakistan for talks with Iran, contending that Washington held all the cards on the matter. Trump told Fox News that it's not worth the US delegation making the 18-hour flight to Pakistan when the US holds all the cards in the conflict with Iran. He added that the Iranians can call the US at any time they want. "I've told my people a little while ago they were getting ready to leave, and I said, 'nope, you're not making an 18 hour flight to go there. We have all the cards. They can call us anytime they want, but you're not going to be making any more 18 hour flights to sit around talking about nothing," Trump told Fox News.



Trump's comments come after Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi on Saturday left Islamabad after meeting Pakistan's top leadership. His departure has ended the possibility of a second round of talks between the US and the Iranian delegations in Islamabad this week. Araghchi, who met PM Shehbaz Sharif, Army Chief Field Marshal Asim Munir and other senior officials, is now headed to Oman on the second leg of his three-nation tour.

GREAT OFFERS!



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KEJRIWAL IS A REAL TRAITOR: MALIWAL

A day after joining the BJP, in a massive setback to Arvind Kejriwal-led AAP, its Rajya Sabha MP Swati Maliwal on Saturday blasted the former Delhi Chief Minister and called him "anti-women" who is involved in corruption and *gundagardi* (hooliganism)", adding that Prime Minister Narendra Modi, on the other hand, makes historic decisions. Countering AAP's "traitor" jibe at Maliwal and six other AAP MPs in Rajya Sabha who quit the party and merged with the BJP on Friday, she said that Kejriwal is the real traitor. Maliwal said that when the former Delhi CM began his anti-corruption movement in 2011, he would wear torn pants, use an ₹2 pen and drive around in a completely dilapidated car. However, after coming to power, she alleged, he built a house worth ₹100 crore, in a reference to the 'Sheesh Mahal' controversy. Taking a broader swipe at AAP's functioning, she said the party now stood for "lies, corruption and hooliganism."

FULL REPORT ON P3

PM Modi to open Ganga Expressway on April 29

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Lucknow

The Ganga Expressway project, being considered a major infrastructure transformation in Uttar Pradesh, is all set to be opened to the public by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on April 29. Sources said a few more projects, including that of railways and flagging of trains from Ayodhya and Varanasi, are also on the cards as the State prepares in advance for the next year's crucial Assembly polls.

With an estimated cost of around ₹37,000 crore, the Ganga Expressway project was divided into four major packages (groups) to ensure rapid progress. This "multi-package" model proved to be the project's biggest strength, playing a crucial role in delivering such a massive project within the stipulated timeline, the UP Government said in a statement on Saturday.

The Ganga Expressway project, which stretches approximately 594 kilometres, was implemented by dividing it into four major packages, each handled by different agencies. This approach allowed key developers and EPC contractors to work simultaneously, significantly accelerating construction.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Mumbai drug lord Salim Dola arrested in Istanbul

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

Mumbai's notorious Drug Lord, Salim Ismail Dola, who was on the run, has been arrested by the Turkish Intelligence in Istanbul. Indian agencies, including the Mumbai Police and the CBI, which secured a Red Corner Notice (RCN) against Dola, have confirmed his arrest. Dola is currently in Turkish custody and expected to be moved to a deportation centre pending legal formalities. India is seeking Dola's extradition through Interpol channels. Despite India and Turkey not

having an extradition treaty, officials expect swift progress via international cooperation. It may be noted that the Enforcement Directorate (ED) and Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB) had offered rewards for Dola's arrest.

Top sources said, Salim Ismail Dola, the Mumbai-based kingpin of a major transnational synthetic drug empire, was arrested in a joint operation in the Beylikdüzü district. Dola, a 60-year-old fugitive linked to the UNSC, banned global mafia Dawood Ibrahim's D-Company, was living under an assumed identity of a citizen of the UAE. Mumbai Police's Anti-Narcotics

(L-R) Dawood Ibrahim and Salim Ismail Dola

Cell played a pivotal role in unravelling Dola's web of drug smuggling syndicate. A February 2024 raid in the city on four suspects with 4 kg of Mephedrone led

investigators to a massive seizure of drugs from a Sangli factory. Mumbai Police sleuths detected the trail to Surat, the UAE and finally Dola's presence in Turkey. By late 2025, over a dozen arrests had crippled parts of the network, but Dola remained elusive until the Turkish operation.

The April 2026 arrest in Beylikdüzü, a bustling western Istanbul suburb popular with middle-class residents and immigrants, underscores growing India-Turkey security cooperation against cross-border threats. Turkish media, including outlets like Milliyet and Hürriyet, report-

ed the suspect's location via surveillance, leading to his detention in a safe house. He was living discreetly under the alias tied to UAE documents, a tactic common among fugitives evading RCN.

Dola's journey into the underworld began in Mumbai's working-class Cotton Green neighbourhood. By the 1980s, he had shifted to Dongri, the notorious stronghold of the D-Company, where he allegedly carved out a place for himself in narcotics, eventually assuming a role akin to the late Iqbal Mirchi in overseeing drug operations for the syndicate.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

₹95 crore flow: ED probes Evangelical mission TTI

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH <
■ New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has launched an investigation into The Timothy Initiative (TTI), a global evangelical Christian mission, over the alleged use of foreign debit cards to channel nearly ₹95 crores into India, with significant cash withdrawals in Maoist-affected, sensitive regions of Chhattisgarh.

"The probe, registered under the Foreign Exchange Management Act (FEMA), highlights serious concerns over bypassing foreign funding regulations and the emergence of a parallel cash economy in Left Wing Extremism (LWE) zones," well-placed sources in the probe agency said. Notably, the ED officials conducted extensive searches at six locations across multiple States

on April 18-19, 2026. They seized 25 foreign debit cards linked to Trust Bank in the United States, ₹40 lakhs in cash and incriminating digital devices and documents. An online billing and accounting platform purportedly controlled from outside India, used to record cash withdrawals and their utilisation for

TTI activities, was also uncovered during the probe.

ED sources revealed that foreign debit cards were smuggled into India and used for repeated high-value ATM withdrawals nationwide. Approximately ₹95 crores were channelled between November 2025 and April 2026.

At a time when Indian security forces have succeeded in ending the Naxal menace from the face of the country, the 'unusual and suspicious withdrawals' totalling about ₹6.5 crore over the past few years in Naxal violence-hit areas, including Dhamtari district and the Bastar region of Chhattisgarh, are concerning.

Investigations have revealed that the withdrawn cash funded TTI's operations in India. ED suspects an organised network was behind these questionable transactions to evade regulatory scrutiny.

A breakthrough came when Bureau of Immigration officers, acting on an ED Look-out Circular (LOC), intercepted foreign national Micah Mark at Bengaluru International Airport. He was carrying 24 foreign debit cards.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

IMD RELEASES HEATWAVE GUIDELINES

With temperatures rising across several regions, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) released detailed heatwave guidelines and advised people to avoid prolonged exposure to direct sunlight, especially during peak afternoon hours, stay adequately hydrated, wear light and breathable clothing, and avoid strenuous outdoor activities during high-temperature periods. As per the latest assessment, maximum temperatures in many parts of northwest, central and peninsular India are currently ranging between 40°C to 44°C, with the highest temperature of 44.5°C recorded at Sri Ganganagar (Rajasthan). The IMD advised special care for vulnerable groups such as children, the elderly, and individuals with pre-existing health conditions. The IMD has made comprehensive heatwave guidance.

Kejriwal's Sheesh Mahal sequel to haunt AAP in Punjab!

RAJESH KUMAR ■ New Delhi

AAP supremo Arvind Kejriwal's "Sheesh Mahal" controversy is back again to haunt the former Delhi Chief Minister. This time it involves a new Type-VII bungalow in Delhi's Lodhi Garden, and a tag that has long been associated with him: "Sheesh Mahal" (Glass Palace).

While the first Sheesh Mahal is considered to be one of the major reasons the AAP lost Delhi reins last year, and now the second Sheesh Mahal is likely to be projected as Kejriwal's lavish style, contrary to his claims of being simple, ahead of the Punjab assembly elections next year, where the BJP is attempting to make inroads.

In a sharp attack on Kejriwal after he shifted to his new bungalow — 95, Lodhi Estate — on Friday,

Images of Arvind Kejriwal's purported bungalow released by the BJP

the BJP on Saturday described him as the "Rahman Dakait of Delhi" and released fresh images of what it called "Sheesh Mahal 2", linking it to earlier allegations regarding Kejriwal's former residence at 6 Flagstaff Road, Delhi Public Works

Department Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh Verma, in a press conference, accused Kejriwal of living lavishly despite earlier claims of simplicity and released an apparent layout and images of the new accommodation, alleging that "private money" was used for the

superior-quality amenities in the house. He said, "...Delhi's Rahman Dakait, just as a sequel to the movie *Dhurandhar* came out, similarly, we are going to reveal 'Sheesh Mahal 2' today.

He displayed some photos and claimed these were from the Type-

VII bungalow given to Kejriwal in his capacity as the party's chief. Verma said that the CPWD does not spend such money on bungalows, and claimed that "private money" was spent to create some amenities.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Kavitha unveils new political outfit TRS

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Hyderabad

Telangana Jagruthi president and former CM K Chandrasekhar Rao's daughter, K Kavitha, on Saturday launched a political outfit, named 'Telangana Rashtira Sena' (TRS).

Kavitha, who announced her party's name and agenda at an event, sharply attacked the ruling Congress, BJP and BRS, describing her father as a "changed man" who has become "soulless". The Bharat Rashtira Samiti (BRS), headed by her father, was originally named Telangana Rashtira Samiti (TRS). However, it was renamed as BRS in 2022 following KCR's ambitious plan to expand the party nationwide.

Alleging that the BRS, Congress and BJP are now riddled with corruption, "family rule" and favouritism, she announced 'Panchajanya', a set of five promises, including free education and health.

Launching an attack on Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy, she described him as "Hitler" and a heartless person. She cited the demolitions of houses at Velugumatla in Khammam district, alleged deaths of students in social welfare residential schools and also a Dalit youth in police custody.

Training her guns on the BJP, Kavitha alleged that the party did not favour the formation of Telangana and opposed the concept of social justice.

In a veiled reference to PM Narendra Modi's alleged comments in the past, she said the party's top leadership had stated that the mother (Andhra) was killed to give birth to a child (Telangana), which is insulting to Telangana.

Govt approves holistic study for MAMC campus redevelopment

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has approved a comprehensive and holistic study for the redevelopment of the Maulana Azad Medical College (MAMC) campus.

Announcing this, the Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the MAMC is spread across approximately 137 acres of land, and its campus includes key institutions like Lok Nayak Hospital, GB Pant Hospital, Guru Nanak Eye Centre, and the Maulana Azad Institute of Dental Sciences.

She noted that the entire campus functions as an inter-connected healthcare and academic ecosystem and therefore, the need for its planned, integrated and long-term redevelopment has been felt for a long time.

Keeping this in view, the Delhi Government has approved a consultancy assignment to undertake a comprehensive assessment of the campus and to prepare a long-term redevelopment strategy. The work will be carried out in three phases.

According to the Chief Minister the first phase will involve the preparation of a detailed master plan for the entire campus, ensuring full compliance with local body regulations, norms of the Delhi Development Authority (DDA), and all applicable statutory provisions.

The master plan will be designed with a vision for the next 30 years, taking into account future requirements and expansion possibilities.

In the second phase, a structural audit and technical evaluation of the existing buildings will be conducted. Based on this, modern designs, layouts, and redevelopment proposals for new infrastructure will be prepared. In the third phase, all tender-related documents will be prepared and technical support will be provided throughout the tendering process to ensure timely and efficient execution of the proposed works.

The comprehensive project will include planning and design of hospital and academic buildings, along with the development of multi-storey residential complexes, hostels, nursing facilities, a fire station, sanitation systems, internal roads and connectivity, advanced security arrangements, cafeterias, parking areas, and multi-level parking facilities.

All supporting infrastructure will also be integrated to transform the campus into a fully modern, well-organised, and efficient unit. The consultant will prepare digital ground surveys, detailed engineering drawings, technical documents, and a Detailed Project Report (DPR).

The chief minister said that the MAMC campus is a crucial pillar of Delhi's healthcare system, where medical services and education operate simultaneously. The objective is to develop the entire campus into a modern, well-structured, and future-ready 'Integrated Healthcare and Education Hub'.

The Chief Minister further stated that the government aims to develop a model campus in full compliance with all statutory standards, capable of meeting the needs of Delhi's residents for decades to come.

Dyal Singh College principal seeks DU VC's direction on staff council meeting

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Two days after the Staff Association of Delhi University's Dyal Singh Evening College called for a protest to oppose the renaming of the institute, its principal has written to the university vice-chancellor to convene a staff council meeting, it is learnt.

The letter was sent on Friday "seeking directions to convene a Staff Council meeting on the issue of the name change of the college."

In December 2025, Delhi University Vice-Chancellor Yogesh Singh announced that the evening college will be renamed after Sikh warrior Banda Singh Bahadur. It is currently named after Sardar Dyal Singh Majithia, a 19th-century philanthropist, educationist, and social reformer.

Undersigned by principal Bhawna Pandey and Staff Council secretary Jnanendra Narayan Singh, the letter mentioned, "The Staff Association of Dyal Singh Evening College has repeatedly given representations for convening the Staff Council meeting to discuss the resolution of the governing body on the issue of name change of the college."

Referring to the Staff Association's one-day dharna on Thursday, the letter highlighted that the protest has received support from members of the Academic Council, Executive Council and Delhi University Teachers' Association.

"In view of the aforesaid, I request that directions may be issued on whether the Staff Council meeting can be convened as per the ordinance of the University of Delhi to discuss the issue of the proposed name change," the letter concluded.

Staff Association president Mithilesh Kumar Singh said that during the dharna, the principal had promised to call a meeting on April 28, one day before the Executive Council meeting. "But, as of now, the meeting has not been called. The principal has now written to the vice-chancellor on the issue," he said.

The dharna was called in anticipation that the name change proposal might be tabled at the upcoming Executive Council meeting.



MCD begins assessment to restore historic Delhi Gate in Najafgarh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Taking note of the deteriorating condition of the historic Delhi Gate in Najafgarh, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) has started assessing the extent of restoration required.

The development follows a letter by Najafgarh ward councillor Amit Kharkhari, who had flagged the condition of the notified heritage structure and sought urgent repair and conservation measures, an official said.

"An archaeologist has visited the site. The scope of the work will be finalised after a detailed assessment," a Heritage Cell official said.

In his letter dated April 23, the councillor had said the Delhi Gate, which holds historical and cultural significance, showed visible signs of structural damage and deterioration during earlier inspections conducted with civic officials and the Heritage Cell team in 2023-24.

with a new name: Vaid Kishori Lal Dwar. However, like the city's other landmarks that have been renamed, the older name has stuck.

The late Mughal-period red brick structure with pointed arches also has a plaque that says it was witness to the Battle of Najafgarh. Today, without any protection from the Archaeological Survey of India, it shares its walls with the Municipal Corporation office next door and faces chaotic traffic, a marketplace and an animal hospital. One thing, however, hasn't changed: from the time of Najaf Khan to now, it is the centre of the neighbourhood.

Officials indicated that further technical evaluation will guide the conservation plan, as the civic body is evaluating the measures needed to stabilise and restore the heritage site. The gate, which has a plaque to commemorate the martyrs of World War I, is covered with tiles now.

Urging authorities to immediately repair the structure to prevent it from further decay and preserve its legacy, the councillor called for time-bound execution of the work.

Standing before the Delhi Gate in the crowded market in Najafgarh in West Delhi, it is hard to imagine that this was where a decisive battle was fought between the sepoys and the British on August 25, 1857.

The gate, built in 1770 as a part of the bastion of Najaf Khan, a powerful minister living in Delhi during the decline of Mughal rule, has been partially renovated



Police bust cyber fraud facilitation network

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police has busted a cyber fraud facilitation network involving mule bank accounts and shell companies, and arrested two dummy directors after detecting a fund flow of over Rs 16 crore within eight days, an official said on Saturday.

The accused, identified as Sonu Kumar and Aminder Singh, were acting as dummy directors of a private limited firm, which was found to be at the centre of the laundering network, he said.

The case was registered following analysis of suspicious mule accounts flagged on the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal and inputs received via the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre's Samanvaya portal.

During the investigation, a bank account linked to the company at a Bawana branch came under scrutiny after it was found connected to 336 cyber fraud complaints across multiple States.

The account showed abnormal activity and was used at various layers of the money trail, police said.

Detailed financial analysis revealed that over Rs 16 crore was routed through the account within a span of eight days, indicating large-scale laundering. The probe further uncovered links to more than 35 suspected shell companies and a wider multi-layered network handling funds across several accounts and banks.

"Vulnerable people were lured with job offers or commissions and made dummy directors, while control of bank accounts remained with handlers operating remotely, including from outside Delhi," a senior police officer said.

The accounts were used to receive cheated money, layer transactions, and transfer funds to obscure the trail.

I.K. GUJRAL PUNJAB TECHNICAL UNIVERSITY JALANDHAR
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Ph.D. Admission Notice 2026-27 (Summer)
Applications are invited for admission to full-time/part-time Ph.D. program for various Disciplines for the **session 2026-27 (summer)** in the University through entrance test and test exempted categories for Ph.D. admission in the following discipline:
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● The online application form for Entrance test candidates shall be available from **29.04.2026 to 11.05.2026 (5:00 PM)**.
● The Ph.D. Entrance Test is scheduled on **17.05.2026** at **IKGPTU, Main Campus, Kapurthala**.
● For any queries, email to **ptuphdadmissions@ptu.ac.in** or contact **01822-282558**
* The link of online application, instructions, minimum eligibility for admissions, number of vacant seats, exempted categories along with other conditions are given at **https://phd.ptu.ac.in** & **https://ptu.ac.in/phd/admission**

Advt No. 2026/05/01**REGISTRAR**

PUBLIC NOTICE
I, Mr. Rafiq Ahmed S/o Shri Gheyas Uddin R/o G-103, Sarawati Apartments, Plot No.97, I.P. Extension, Patparganj, Delhi-110092 after the death of my wife Smt. Farhat Jahan (Expired on 24.04.2021) out of my own free will and consent do hereby disown and debar my real son, Daughter-in-law along with Grand Children namely Mr. Meral Ahmed (son), Mrs. Nigar Ahmed (D/L) along with Mr. Faraz Ahmed and Mr. Farhan Ahmed (Grand Children) all residing at D-303, Mayfair Apartments, Plot No.96, I.P. Extension, Patparganj, Delhi-110092 from all my moveable and immovable assets and have severed all my relations with him as my son is very disobedient, disrespectful, beyond my control and supervision. Anyone Dealing with him will do so at their own risk and cost, I will not be responsible for their any acts or deeds as I have no relation with them
Rafiq Ahmed

PUBLIC NOTICE
My client Mr. **Vijay Mangla** is the registered owner of Property bearing Shop No. 56, New Grain Market, measuring 250-83sq. Yards, Palwal, Shiv Colony, Palwal, Haryana, by virtue of Trade Deed dated 03.04.2026, registered as document number 119, which was executed by his father, Shri Vijay Kumar Mangla and Shri Vijay Kumar Mangla inherited the said property from his mother, Smt. Kiran Devi vide registered Will dated 29.11.2012, and except Mr. Vijay Mangla, there are no other claimants of the referred property who is mortgaging the said property. If anybody, including Bank, Financial Institutions, persons, or relatives, has any claim, right, interest whatsoever in the said property, they shall inform within 07 days to the undersigned with documentary evidence, in the event of no response to this notice, then my client shall presume that the title of the said property is unencumbered and clear.
Karnail Singh, (Advocate) K-8, Basement, Jungpura Extension New Delhi. Contact No. 981163363 & 9953683363.

NORTHERN RAILWAY
E-TENDER NOTICE No. ELS-SRE-26-27-T-1 dtd. 25.04.2026
Open tender through E-tendering are invited by Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer/ TRS, Electric Loco Shed, Khananpura Yard, Northern Railway, Saharanpur (Ambala Division) for and on behalf of the President of India from the registered tenderer on website **www.irops.gov.in** for the following work upto 11:00 hrs. on the date of closing shown against the work and will be opened thereafter:-
Open Tender No. : ELS-SRE-26-27-T-1
Name of work : Annual calibration of Gauges and Measuring & Testing equipments of ELS/SRE for a period of Two years.
Date of Closing/Opening : 20.05.2026
Approx. Cost : Rs. 1,14,024.50
Earnest Money : Rs. 2,300/-
Completion period : Twenty (24) Months
Validity period : 60 days
Cost of tender form : Free of cost for downloading from IREPS & Rs. 1,000/- for obtaining from Sr.DEE/TRS/SRE office.
1. Tenderer(s) should have Class-III Digital Signature Certificate to participate in E-Tendering of Works Tenders. 2. Tenderer are required to upload self-attested scanned copies of all related eligibility documents as per conditions. 3. Taxes & Charges will be applicable as per extant rule. 4. For details, please log on IREPS website **www.irops.gov.in**
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POSSESSION NOTICE (For immovable property)
Whereas the undersigned being the Authorized Officer of the HINDUJA HOUSING FINANCE LIMITED under Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (No. 3 of 2002) and in exercise of powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued a demand notice was issued on the dates mentioned against each account and stated hereinafter calling upon the borrower (hereinafter the borrower and guarantors are collectively referred to as the "Borrowers") to repay the amount within 60 days from the date of receipt of said notice. The borrowers having failed to comply with the notice is hereby given to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred under sub-section 4 of section 13a of Act read with rule 8 of the Security Interest Enforcement Rules, 2002 on this dates mentioned against each account. The borrower / guarantor in particular and the public in general is hereby notified that the property is subject to the charge of the HINDUJA HOUSING FINANCE LIMITED for an amount and future interest at the contractual rate on the aforesaid amount together with incidental expenses, costs, charges, etc. thereon. The borrower's attention is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets.

Account Number, Name of the Borrowers & Address	Date of Possession
DL/DEL/DL/HU/A000004226. 1. Mr. Imran Khan S/o Mr. Yameen Khan Mrs. Aysha W/o Mr. Imran Khan Mrs. Anisha W/o Mr. Yameen. House No. 1055/1, Gali No. 1, New Tilpat Colony, Amarnagar, Faridabad, Haryana-121001	25-Apr-26 07-02-2026 & Total Outstanding: Rs. 7,85,620/- As on 07/02/2026
2. Arajai Khewat No.69, Khatori No.82, Mu.No.42, Kila No.8/1(2-7), 13/1(0-16), Kila No.21(8-0) Out Of 1 Kanai 7 Marla, In Total 9 Kanai 8 Marla, Wasika No. 3262 Dated 30/12/2020, Situated At Waka Mauja Badkhal, Tehsil Badkhal, District Faridabad, Haryana-121001. Boundaries: East: Other's Property. West: other's Property. North: Rasta 18ft. South: Other's Property	25-Apr-26 07-02-2026 & Total Outstanding: Rs. 7,85,620/- As on 07/02/2026
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PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gurugram

The national bird, a peacock, died after allegedly being hit by an unidentified car in the Sushant Lok area. Based on a complaint of Gurugram Wildlife Inspector Charan Singh, an FIR has been registered against the unidentified driver.

The incident occurred at around 10 am on Friday. Upon receiving information, he reached the spot with

wildlife ranger Rajnesh and a police team from Sushant Lok police station, the complainant said.

The police and veterinarian Rajesh Godara inspected the scene, and a post-mortem was also conducted on the bird, the officials said.

Following the complaint, an FIR was registered against the driver of the car under Section 281 of the BNS, Sections 9, 39, and 51 of the Wildlife (Protection) Act, 1972, at Sushant Lok police

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

station, they said.

"FIR has been registered and efforts are being made to identify the car that struck the peacock by examining footage from CCTV cameras installed around the scene," a senior police officer said.

Peacocks, which are the national bird of India, are protected under Schedule 1 of the Wildlife (Protection) Act, 1972. Their killing and capturing are a punishable offence under Section 9 of the Act.

Gupta urges students to lead Viksit Bharat vision



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Assembly Speaker Viijender Gupta urged students to lead the vision of Viksit Bharat by 2047, stressing that "education shows the path, but character gives the strength to remain on it."

The Speaker said while addressing the Annual Prize Distribution Ceremony at PGDAV College (Morning), University of Delhi, as chief guest on Saturday. The programme was held at the New Auditorium, PGDAV College (Morning), Nehru Nagar.

Addressing students and faculty, Gupta said that PGDAV College is not merely an institution but a living embodiment of the legacy of Maharshi Dayanand Saraswati, whose call to return to foundational values continues to guide generations.

The Pioneer Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Divya Yadav, C/O Ambrish Kumar , R/O at Flat No. 1002, 10th Floor, Tower CB-1, Capetown Supertech, Sector-74, Noida, Gautam Buddha Nagar, Uttar Pradesh -201301, have changed my name from Divya Manchanda to Divya Yadav for all future purposes.

PD(954)C

I, VIJAY KUMAR MALHOTRA S/O GANESH DASS MALHOTRA R/O 906/UG-5, SHALIMAR GARDEN EXTENSION-1, SAHIBABAD, PO: SAHIBABAD, GHAZIABAD, UTTAR PRADESH-201005 declare that name of mine has been wrongly written as V.K. MALHOTRA in my wife's PPO No. 217210000294. The actual name of mine is VIJAY KUMAR MALHOTRA, which may be amended accordingly.

PD(955)C

I, A Valasala, Mother of No.8037336P Nk Pramod V V, R/o- Vill- Veeranakavu, Post-Panniyode, Teh- Kattakada, Dist- Trivandrum, Kerala- 695575, have changed my name from A Valasala to Valsala A, vide affidavit dated 25/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(956)C

PD(960)C

NORTHERN RAILWAY
CORRIGENDUM#4
Tender Notice No. 86)
1. In reference to T.No. 07235090A due on 27.04.2026, it is informed that Due date has been extended up to **12.05.2026**.
2. The all-other Terms & Conditions of the subject tender will remain unchanged. The corrigendum has been published on website **www.irops.gov.in**.
1374/2026
SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

Office of the Superintending Engineer
3rd Circle, Public Works Department, Pithoragarh
Email: **sepwdpth@rediffmail.com**
Letter No. : 1454/58C(Yata-B)-03/2026
National Competitive E-Tender Notice
The Superintending Engineer, 3rd Circle, Public Works Department, Pithoragarh on behalf of "Hon'ble Governor of Uttarakhand" invites tender for consultancy Services for the following work. The RFP/TOR document will be available online from **date 27-04-2026 at 05.00 PM** onward on website **http://www.uktenders.gov.in**.

Sl. No.	Name of Work	Earnest Money (₹ in Lac)	Cost of Tender (₹)	Validity of Tender	Period of Completion	Contractor's Category of Registration
1	Upgradation of Class-A loading bridges in place of previously constructed Class-B loading bridges at Km. 126, 127, 132, 147 and Km. 158 of Bering Askot Motor Road (SH-03) of Almora in Didihat Constituency of Pithoragarh District under State Sector.	0.50	2000.00 + 18% GST	90 Days	06 Month	Experience of Bridges consultancy work in any State Govt. Govt. of India/Govt Undertaking

HINDUJA HOUSING FINANCE LIMITED
Registered Office: No. 167-169, 2nd Floor, Anand Singh, Connaught Place, New Delhi-110009
ALM - Parmod Chand, Mob- 99903 38759, CLM - Himmansh Singh, Mob- 99584 43500
PUBLIC NOTICE OF PHYSICAL POSSESSION OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTY
To, 1. Mr. Yogesh Kataria...borrower 2. Mrs. Saroj Bala...co-borrower. House No. 24, J-block, Ashok Vihar Phase-2, Gurugram, Haryana-122001 & House No.3g/70, N.I.T. Faridabad, Haryana-121001. LAM No. DL BDP/BDP/A000000993 Whereas vide Order dated 19/02/2025 passed by District Magistrate, Faridabad, the physical possession of the property being All that piece and parcel of 'Independent / Entire First Floor, Without Roof Rights, Having Covered Area 780 Sq. Ft., Constructed Upon The Front Portion Of House No.3g/70, N.I.T. Faridabad, Area Measuring 90 Sq. Yards With All Rights Of First Floor, Tehsil Badkhal, District Faridabad, Haryana-121001" has been taken over by M/s Hinduja Housing Finance Ltd. on 24/04/2026. The borrowers in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealings with the Property will be subject to the charge of M/s Hinduja Housing Finance Ltd.
Date : 26/04/2026 Place: Haryana
Authorised Officer- HINDUJA HOUSING FINANCE LIMITED

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given on behalf of Shri Kamalapati Srivastava to inform the public at large that Smt. Radha Srivastava is purchasing the Residential Plot measuring 50 Sq. Yds, Kharsa No.626 & 624 Mi. situated at Mahuddinpur Kanawani, Pargana Loni, Tehsil & District Ghaziabad from Shri Nawal Kishore Giri, who claims ownership vide Regd. GPA dated 22.09.2021 (Doc No. 3045). The property will be financed & mortgaged by Motilal Oswal Home Finance Limited, Ghaziabad. Initially, the property was owned by Late Smt. Babita Bansal (expired 29.05.2021), whose legal heirs are Smt. Priyanka Bansal, Smt. Pallavi Bansal (daughters), Shri Naresh Bansal (husband), and Shri Manshu (son). Shri Naresh Kumar Bansal, Smt. Priyanka Bansal & Smt. Pallavi Bansal executed General Power of Attorney in favour of Shri Nawal Kishore Giri vide Regd. GPA dated 22.09.2021 (Doc No. 3045). To comply with BANK/NBFC requirements, any person having any claim/right/lien/interest/mortgage over the said property may inform in writing at the address below within 14 days, failing which it shall be presumed that the property is free from all encumbrances, liens, etc. Lucem Legal LLP B-93B, Second Floor, Opp. SBI Bank Sector 2 Noida, UP-201301>Contact#0120-4269379

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given on behalf of Mr. Gaurav Gupta to inform the public at large that Mr. Gaurav Gupta is purchasing the First Floor (without roof rights) of Property No. 263, measuring 50 Sq. Yards, part of Rect. No. 12 Min, Killa No. 21, situated at New Loyal Pur Colony, Village Khureli Khars, Illaga Shahdara, Delhi - 110051, from Mrs. Urmila who became the owner through Sale Deed dated 19.04.2025 (Document No. 2025/413871). The said property will be financed and mortgaged by Aditya Birla Housing Finance Ltd., Noida. It is stated that in the property chain, (1) Death Certificate of Late Mr. Ram Chander Sainik and (2) Surrender Member Certificate of Late Mrs. Premwati Sainik are not available. Therefore, to comply with the requirements of the BANK/NBFC, this public notice is issued. If any person has any type of claim, right, title, interest, or has created any mortgage over the said property, they are requested to inform in writing, along with their objections, at the address mentioned below within 15 days from today. Failing which, it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all types of encumbrances, liens, etc. Lucem Legal LLP B-93B, Second Floor, Opp. SBI Bank Sector 2 Noida, UP-201301>Contact#0120-4269379

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given on behalf of M/s. Sukhman Buildcon Private Limited who are owned of Property area measuring 565 sq. yds., out of Khawat No. 109 Min, Khata No. 113 Min, Mustali and Killa No. 58/199(1-1), 200(1-1) situated at Waka Mauja Phalpradpur, Tehsil Kharkhoda, District Sonapat having acquired the same vide Sale Deed dated 24.11.2023 duly registered in the office of Sr. Kharkhoda as registration No. 3222, Adat. Book No. 1, Page Nos. 140/25/100-103, Volume No. 143/2637, Dated 24.11.2023 now M/s Sukhman Buildcon Private Limited intend to mortgage the subject property for the financial assistance from Protium Finance Ltd. That Original Original Sale Deed dated 09.02.2023 Document no.3720 executed by Mr. Ajay S/o Ram Karan and others in favour of Mrs. Manisha (26.542 share) and Mrs. Manju (12.542 share), for property measuring 1 Kanal 19 Marla, Khawat No. 109 Min, Khata No. 113 Min, Mustali and Killa No. 58/199(1-1), 200(1-1), G.P.A.TS and Will executed by Mrs. Manisha in favour of Suresh, Mrs. Manju, and Mr. Sudhir Kumar Dahiya and Title documents in the name of Mr. Sudhir Kumar Dahiya for land comprised in Mustali and Plot No. 88/199(1-1), 200(1-1) has been lost/stolen/ misplaced/not available. FIR already lodged vide LR No. 13227092072600051 dated 03/04/2026 To comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any person having any type of claim/right/lien/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about all objections within 07 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. Lucem Legal LLP N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre New Delhi-110049 Contact # 011-40046316 & 41667372

YouTuber Salim Wastik held in 31-year-old murder case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Popular YouTuber Salim Wastik — known for his public identification as an 'ex-Muslim' — who was stabbed last month at his home in Ghaziabad, has been arrested in connection with the murder of a Delhi businessman's 13-year-old son nearly 31 years ago.

Salim Wastik, who had been living under a false identity, was found in Ghaziabad's Loni area following a tip-off and subsequent verification through old records, fingerprints, and photographs, officials said.

He has been sentenced to life imprisonment at the Tihar jail on charges of kidnapping, extortion, and murder.

The development has added a strange twist in the YouTuber's saga as Wastik was provided security by the Uttar Pradesh Police in February after he was allegedly stabbed by two men at his office in Loni. The two alleged attackers were later killed in an encounter by the Uttar Pradesh Police.

Salim Wastik, whose original name is Salim Khan alias Salim Ahmed, had managed to evade arrest by assuming a new identity and moving to different locations over the years. He was apprehended from Loni in Uttar Pradesh by a team of the crime branch.

According to police, Khan was convicted in 1997 along with his associate Anil for the kidnapping and murder of the 13-year-old son of a

cement businessman in north-east Delhi and sentenced to rigorous imprisonment for life by a sessions court in Delhi. At the time of the incident, Salim was working as a martial arts instructor at the victim's school. The convict had been evading arrest for over two decades after jumping interim bail granted in 2000 during the pendency of his appeal, police said.

"The boy was abducted in January 1995 while on his way to school, and a ransom of ₹30,000 was demanded for his release," a senior police officer said.

The officer further said the victim's father had received a phone call from the kidnappers, who instructed him to deliver the ransom amount at a bus stand near the Loni



flyover. The caller also warned him against informing the police. However, during the investigation, suspicion fell on Salim Khan.

A police team questioned him and, based on his dislo-

sure, recovered the boy's body from a drain near Mustafabad in Delhi, according to the officer. The co-accused Anil was later identified and eventually surrendered before a court in February 1995.

SALIM WASTIK, WHO HAD BEEN LIVING UNDER A FALSE IDENTITY, WAS FOUND IN GHAZIABAD'S LONI AREA

Following trial proceedings, both accused were convicted and sentenced to life imprisonment by a sessions court in Delhi. They later challenged the verdict in the Delhi High Court. During the pendency of the appeal, Salim Khan was granted interim bail in November 2000 but failed to surrender thereafter. His conviction was upheld by the high court in 2011.

"After jumping bail, Salim Khan managed to evade law

enforcement by frequently changing locations across Haryana and Uttar Pradesh. He reportedly worked as an almirah maker in places such as Karnal and Ambala before settling permanently in Loni around 2010," the officer said.

To avoid arrest, he allegedly declared himself dead in official records and assumed a new identity as Salim Wastik or Salim Ahmed. Under this identity, he ran a shop dealing in women's garments and accessories and also became active on social media platforms, projecting himself as a social activist and YouTuber.

Police said the breakthrough came after a crime branch team received a tip-off, which they then used to verify his identity using old photographs and fingerprint

records. A team, with assistance from local police in Loni, carried out the operation and arrested him.

They said after completing legal formalities, the accused has been brought to Delhi and lodged in Tihar Jail.

According to officials, earlier, after the attack on Wastik at his office, an FIR was registered on a complaint lodged by his son Usman against seven named individuals — two of whom were killed in the encounter.

Police had formed multiple teams to trace the attackers and were examining angles, including personal enmity and ideological differences.

He was treated at the Guru Teg Bahadur Hospital and later shifted to a private hospital in Saket.

Maliwal calls Kejriwal anti-women

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A day after joining the BJP, in a massive setback to the Arvind Kejriwal-led AAP, its Rajya Sabha MP Swati Maliwal on Saturday blasted the former Delhi Chief Minister and called him "anti-women" who is involved in corruption and "gundagardi (hooliganism)", adding that Prime Minister Narendra Modi, on the other hand, makes historic decisions.



Rajya Sabha MP Swati Maliwal speaking during interview in New Delhi PTI

Countering AAP's "traitor" jibe at Maliwal and six other AAP MPs in Rajya Sabha who quit the party and merged with the BJP on Friday, she said that Kejriwal is the real traitor.

Maliwal said that when the former Delhi CM began his anti-corruption movement in 2011, he would wear torn pants, use a 2-rupee pen and drive around in a completely dilapidated car.

However, after coming to power, she alleged, he built a house worth ₹100 crore, in reference to the 'Sheesh Mahal' controversy. Taking a corporate swipe at AAP's functioning, she said the party now stood for "lies, corruption and hooliganism."

Maliwal said she had joined the BJP after careful consideration, not out of

compulsion. She praised the "decisive and strong leadership" of Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

Her remarks come days after more than two-thirds of AAP's Rajya Sabha MPs resigned from the party and joined the BJP, with Raghav Chadha leading the split.

Maliwal recalled the alleged assault on her two years ago as she spoke publicly on the issue after joining the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). Maliwal claimed that she was 'intimidated and threatened' when she tried to file an FIR against the incident.

Providing details of the incident, Maliwal alleged that she was assaulted by a close aide of Kejriwal at the chief minister's resi-

dence in 2024 and faced sustained pressure to withdraw her complaint.

"I left my home, lived in 'juggis' for seven years, quit my job and supported every movement. But when I tried to file an FIR after being assaulted, I was threatened and intimidated. For the past two years, I have been under constant pressure to take the case back, but I did not bow down," she said.

She further added that her resistance led to her being sidelined within the party. "Because of this, I was not given even a minute by the party in the last two years to present my views in Parliament. This is very shameful. I believe Arvind Kejriwal is extremely anti-women."

Bansuri Swaraj accuses Arvind Kejriwal of double standards

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

BJP MP Bansuri Swaraj on Saturday accused AAP national convener and former Delhi chief minister Arvind Kejriwal of "double standards", alleging that the proposed "luxurious interiors" of his government bungalow at 95, Lodhi Estate, are not in line with his claims of being a common man.



BJP MP Bansuri Swaraj addressing a press conference at party headquarters in New Delhi PANKAJ KUMAR

Addressing a press conference, the New Delhi MP said the issue is not about luxury but about "deception" and inconsistency between words and actions.

"Let me reiterate — the issue is not about living in luxury. The issue is double standards, falsehood, deception, and the gap between words and actions. It is about putting up a facade before the people of this country while practising something entirely different," she said.

Swaraj alleged that while Kejriwal projects himself as an "aam aadmi", the proposed designs of the bungalow indicate otherwise, which she described as "Sheesh Mahal 2.0".

"As is evident from these images, these are not the tastes of an 'aam aadmi' but

of a very elite person," she claimed while showing a PPT during the press conference.

She also disclosed the name of a private firm, which she claimed is providing the furniture.

Swaraj further claimed that a "Punjab minister is funding furniture and modifications at the Lodhi Estate bungalow", but did not provide specifics. "We have information about who is funding the furniture and the changes being made, including which Punjab minister is bearing the cost," she said.

She also alleged that Kejriwal had earlier said he would not accept a government bungalow or vehicle but had acted contrary to

those claims. "Kejriwal had said he would live in a flat and not take a government bungalow, but he went on to occupy an official residence and built what we call 'Sheesh Mahal' while he was chief minister," she said.

The BJP MP also accused him of misusing government funds during the Covid pandemic. "Even when Delhi was battling Covid, instead of focusing on the people, government funds were used for this project," she said, adding that Kejriwal continued to stay in government accommodation even after demitting office and later shifted to a Rajya Sabha MP's bungalow with Punjab Police security.

Raghav Chadha launches attack on Arvind Kejriwal over Sheesh Mahal 2

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A day after quitting the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) and joining the BJP, Rajya Sabha MP Raghav Chadha on Saturday launched a sharp attack on his former boss Arvind Kejriwal over the "Sheesh Mahal 2" controversy and wondered how the "few remaining good workers" of the party would respond when asked about it.

Referring to the 'Sheesh Mahal' row related to the official residence of Kejriwal when he was the Delhi chief minister, Chadha claimed it was one of the main reasons for AAP's defeat in the 2025 Delhi Assembly elections. He said that every true patriot who had nurtured the AAP with their blood and sweat with great hope has either already left the party or is in the process of leaving it.

Chadha said, "Today, Sheesh Mahal Part Two has come in Delhi. Some pictures of it have surfaced. If there was one major reason for the Aam Aadmi Party's loss in the Delhi elections, the Sheesh



Mahal was one of the main reasons for the party's defeat. But today, not even a year has passed since the Delhi elections ended, and Sheesh Mahal Part Two has come."

Chadha claimed every honest and hard-working person now feels that there is "no space left to work in AAP" and that the party is moving on a wrong path with which no one wants to remain associated. However, Chadha said the MPs are leaving the AAP together because they believe it has gone into "corrupt and compromised hands".

He said those in AAP claiming that leaders left out of fear were wrong, adding that they did not leave due to any fear but because they felt disappointed, disengaged and disgusted with the party.

Capital records hottest day of the year so far

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The national capital sweltered on Saturday, recording its highest maximum temperature of the year so far.

Several weather stations reported heatwave conditions across the city, even as the India Meteorological Department (IMD) has warned of heatwave conditions over northwest and central India during the next three days, including in parts of Delhi and northern states.

The weather department has forecast rain from Monday to Wednesday, bringing some hope of respite to Delhiites.

While a yellow alert had been issued for Saturday, a similar alert remains in place for Sunday as well, warning people of isolated heatwave conditions.

On Saturday, Safdarjung, representative of the city's weather, recorded a maximum temperature of 42.8 degrees Celsius, 5.1 degrees above normal and a 0.9-degree rise from the day



Women cover themselves on a hot day during the summer season in New Delhi PANKAJ KUMAR

before, thus fulfilling the criteria for a heatwave.

According to the India Meteorological Department, a heatwave is classified when the maximum temperature is 40 degrees Celsius or above, and it is 4.5 degrees to 6.4 degrees above normal.

This was also the highest maximum recorded in Delhi in the last four years since 2022, when the maximum had reached 43.5 degrees Celsius on April 28, 2022.

Safdarjung recorded a minimum temperature of 25.2 degrees Celsius, 2.5 degrees above normal and a

mere 0.7-degree rise from the day before.

Other weather stations also recorded isolated heatwave conditions. Lodhi Road recorded a maximum temperature of 42.6 degrees Celsius, 5.6 degrees above the normal; Ridge recorded a minimum of 44.5 degrees, 6.1 degrees above the normal; and Ay Nagar logged a minimum temperature of 43.2 degrees Celsius, 4.8 degrees above the normal.

While the IMD had initially classified Friday as the season's first isolated heat wave, the MeT department

later clarified on Saturday that it had been the third consecutive day of a heatwave.

IMD classifies a heatwave when at least two stations have met the required criteria. The IMD classifies a heatwave when the maximum temperature is at least 4.5° above normal and crosses 40°C; it is also declared if the maximum touches 45°C or more. Typically, at least two stations need to meet this criterion. Further, the IMD only declares a heatwave in Delhi if the base station at Safdarjung is among the two stations to meet the criteria.

An IMD official clarified that while Delhi had fulfilled the heatwave condition only in one station on Thursday, the two-step criteria are actually for the entire subdivision of Haryana-Chandigarh-Delhi. "On Thursday, one station, Rohatk to be specific, of Haryana and Ridge of Delhi, had satisfied heatwave criteria, thus making it the first day. Saturday was the third consecutive day of heat waves," an IMD official said.

Traffic police records sharp drop in congestion-related calls in Central Range

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Traffic Police has recorded a sharp drop in congestion-related calls in the Central Range during the first quarter of 2026, aided by focused enforcement and improved on-ground management, officials said on Saturday.

According to official data, congestion calls fell from 1,378 in January-March 2025 to 1,007 in the corresponding period this year, marking a reduction of around 27 per cent and offering relief to commuters across city stretches.

Officials said major improvements were seen in several traffic circles, with Kotwali and Daryaganj reporting a 49 per cent decline, while Civil Lines recorded the highest drop of 50 per cent, particularly around Tis Hazari and Rajpur Road. Other areas such as Paharganj, Timarpur and



Karol Bagh also registered an average decrease of about 25 per cent.

However, Kamla Market and Sadar Bazar witnessed a slight increase in congestion calls due to heavy market activity, commercial vehicle movement, metro construction and seasonal factors, they said, adding that targeted measures are being taken to address the issue.

The reduction has been attributed to optimised deployment of personnel, strict action against improper parking and encroachments, better signal management, and special drives against violations such as

wrong-side driving and lane indiscipline.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (Traffic), Central Range, Nishant Gupta, said continuous monitoring and interventions, including installation of iron grills on central verges and strategic diversions, have significantly improved traffic flow.

The traffic police said they will continue to rely on data-driven strategies and proactive enforcement to ensure smoother and safer movement for daily commuters.

In another key step, the department will upgrade existing bus stops on SP Marg into dedicated bus bays, enabling buses to halt without obstructing the main carriageway, ensuring smoother traffic movement along the busy corridor. The intervention is likely to curb erratic driving behaviour, reduce gridlocks, and enhance overall road safety," the senior police officer of the Traffic Police said.

CM Rekha mourns death of minor in Shalimar Bagh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta has expressed deep grief over the death of a minor, a resident of Ambedkar Nagar, Haiderpur, in a road accident that took place on Saturday evening in the Shalimar Bagh area.

According to Shalimar Bagh Police, on Saturday evening, two minors riding a motorcycle were passing through the area where illegal encroachments have been made along the drain and the roadside.

The Chief Minister said that if there had been no illegal encroachments along the roadside in this area, traffic would have moved smoothly, and the chances of such accidents and loss of life and property would have been reduced.

About two months ago, a five-year-old girl also lost her life after being hit by a speeding dumper in the same area.

Police recreate crime scene in IRS officer's daughter murder case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police on Saturday recreated the crime scene at the Amar Colony residence of a senior IRS officer, where the alleged rape and murder of his 22-year-old daughter took place on April 22. Recreation of the crime scene is important for piecing together the sequence of events that led to the grisly murder.

The Southeast District police has recovered the iPhone stolen from the victim from a park, while police have also conducted a potency test as part of the rape investigation. Police are

searching for the phone of the accused, which he had sold to someone.

Crime and forensic teams of Delhi Police carried out an in-depth study of the sequence of events inside the house, sources said.

Rahul Meena, the accused, who had been a domestic help at the IRS officer's residence, was brought to the scene of the crime for recording the sequence from his entry inside the house and the time of his escape.

The 22-year-old girl, an engineering graduate and UPSC aspirant, was raped and murdered at her residence in southeast Delhi's

Kailash Hills locality on Wednesday morning.

Investigation by the police has found that the accused, Rahul Meena, who had been a domestic help at the residence, used his familiarity with the house layout and access points to enter the flat. He knew the daily routine of the parents of the victim and had gained entry inside.

Meena allegedly went to the rooftop study room where the victim was studying. He attacked her with a heavy object, raped her and then dragged her downstairs to use her fingers to open a biometric locker and steal cash. The fingerprint could



not work, as the fingers of the victim were covered with blood.

The post-mortem examination has found deep ligature marks on the throat of the

victim as the cause of death. There were multiple injuries on her body, including a nasal bone fracture, indicating that he put up resistance.

The accused had fled the

scene and was seen rushing through the area's CCTV cameras. He was identified by the parents of the victim and was later arrested from a hotel room in Dwarka in southwest Delhi. Police have recovered more than ₹1 lakh in cash and stolen jewellery from his possession.

As part of the probe, police took the accused to Palam railway station, where he had first gone after the crime, and will also take him to the Dwarka hotel where he stayed briefly before being arrested, sources said.

Meena was known for aggressive behaviour in his native village in Rajasthan.

Delhi Police are planning a detailed psychological assessment of the accused to evaluate his mental state and behavioural patterns.

Psychoanalysis of the accused is critical to assess his psychopathic tendencies and whether there was a history of violent conduct.

Meena's psychological profiling will help understand his mental state and reconstruct events and also help the investigating officer in establishing whether the rape, murder and robbery were premeditated, an official said.

The accused has no remorse, as he has been behaving normally. His psychoanalysis

becomes more important to understand the motive of the crime, the official added.

The psychological analysis may involve clinical evaluation by experts to assess aggression levels, emotional responses and personality traits, including indicators linked to disorders such as antisocial personality disorder, sources said.

It has been found that Meena was addicted to online betting and card games such as "Teen Patti" and had lost over ₹7 lakh in the last few months, which drove him to frequently borrow money to sustain the habit.

IN FOCUS



Fishermen attempt to catch fish in a wooden canoe in the morning in Jagdalpur, Bastar district, Chhattisgarh on Saturday

PTI

Gujarat CM urges 100% voter turnout in local body polls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

Ahead of the local self-Government elections scheduled for April 26, Gujarat Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel has appealed to citizens across the State to participate enthusiastically and ensure 100 per cent voting.

In a message to voters, the Chief Minister emphasised that voting is not just a right but a sacred duty of every responsible citizen in a democracy. He urged people to celebrate the “festival of democracy” by actively exercising their franchise and strengthening democratic values.

Polling will be held on Sunday, April 26, from 7 am to 6 pm across various



Gujarat Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel

local self-Government bodies in Gujarat. The elections will cover 15 municipal corporations, 84 municipalities, 260 taluka panchayats, and 34 district panchayats.

The Chief Minister also encouraged voters to motivate their family members, friends, and neighbours to cast their votes, aiming to achieve

the goal of “100 per cent voting” across the State.

Following his appeal, the administration has intensified efforts to maximise voter turnout.

A total of 9,237 seats are going to polls, while more than 736 candidates from the Bharatiya Janata Party have already been elected unopposed after the withdrawal and scrutiny process. Major political parties, including the BJP, Indian National Congress, and Aam Aadmi Party, had campaigned extensively ahead of the elections.

The counting of votes will take place on April 28, with tight security arrangements already in place to ensure peaceful polling across the State.

Spillage to open reactor phase kicks off at Kudankulam nuclear plant



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Kudankulam Nuclear Power Project's unit three witnessed the commencement of the “spillage to open reactor” phase on Saturday, marking a significant development in the ongoing construction of the project, a statement said.

The spillage to open reactor phase involves flushing of the safety system and main coolant pipelines (MCP) using light water to ensure cleanliness of the systems for further commissioning activities.

Located in Tirunelveli district of Tamil Nadu, the project is currently being developed in technical cooperation with Russia under the framework of the inter-governmental agreement. In its statement, the Nuclear Power Corporation of India Limited (NPCIL) said, “The milestone signifies the start of individual functional testing of primary system equipment and piping in accordance with design requirements, marking a critical step towards commissioning of the plant.”

Currently, the plant's units one and two (2x1000 MW) are operating and unit four (1000 MW) is at an advanced stage of construction, it said.

Units five and six (2x1000 MW) are at different stages of construction and are planned to be commissioned progressively.

“Upon completion of these projects, the Kudankulam site will have a total installed capacity of 6000 MW,” the NPCIL said.

AAP holds protests against MPs in Punjab



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chandigarh

AAP workers on Saturday held protests outside the residences of Rajya Sabha MPs Harbhajan Singh, Ashok Mittal and Rajinder Gupta, who quit the party and joined the BJP. The workers wrote ‘Gaddar’ (traitor) on the boundary walls of their houses with spray paint in Ludhiana and Jalandhar.

On Friday, AAP Rajya Sabha members Raghav Chadha and Sandeep Pathak announced that they were quitting the party and joining the BJP along with five other MPs. Ashok Mittal, Harbhajan Singh, Rajinder Gupta, Swati Maliwal, and Vikramjit Sahney were the other AAP MPs they named.

The protesters raised slogans of “Punjab de Gaddar”, accusing them of betraying the people of Punjab.

In Jalandhar, AAP leader Pawan Kumar Tinu said, “The AAP government will return to power in Punjab in 2027, and the BJP will have no political ground left to stand on. Out of frustration, the BJP has resorted to poaching AAP's Rajya Sabha MPs by hook or crook. The Congress, BJP and Akali Dal have formed an unholy alliance against AAP, which is why their leaders are making similar statements about AAP MPs defecting to the BJP.”

AAP Punjab Youth Wing acting president Parminder Goldy led a protest outside the residence of MP Rajinder Gupta in Ludhiana, raising slogans against him.

Lady killer arrested in Ahmedabad for drugging elderly, one dead

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

In a shocking case from Ahmedabad, the city's Crime Branch has arrested a woman accused of targeting elderly residents, drugging them with spiked beverages, and robbing their homes. The accused, identified as Lataben Chauhan alias ‘Lakdi’, was apprehended following the death of an 81-year-old man.

The incident took place in the Dariyapur area, where the victim, Abdulbhai Ismailbhai Sipai (81), and his wife were approached by the accused under the pretext of offering help. Gaining their trust, she entered their home and served them *lassi* laced with a sedative.

After the couple lost consciousness, the accused fled with valuables from the



house. However, due to the excessive dosage of the intoxicant, Abdulbhai's condition deteriorated, and he later died during treatment, turning the case into a serious criminal offence.

Police investigations revealed that the accused had a history of similar crimes. Her modus operandi involved targeting vulnerable, elderly individuals living alone, winning their confi-

dence, and then drugging them through food or drinks before committing theft.

Officials also disclosed that multiple cases, including theft and gambling, have previously been registered against her. Her husband is reportedly serving a jail term in a murder case.

Police believe that her gambling addiction and financial distress drove her to commit such crimes.

Five killed as SUV returning from wedding collides with truck in Mau

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mau

Five people returning from a wedding in Jharkhand were killed when their SUV collided head-on with a trailer truck here, police said on Saturday. Among the dead were three members of a family.

The accident took place in the Doharighat police station area on the highway late Friday night when the SUV, bearing a Jharkhand registration number, went out of control, crossed its lane and crashed into an oncoming trailer, circle officer of the area Jitendra Kumar Singh said.

The impact was so severe that the vehicle was completely mangled. A pet dog travelling with the family also died in the accident.



The victims were returning to Ranidaha village in Gorakhpur district after attending a wedding in Ranchi, Jharkhand. Two people from Bihar's Gaya district were also travelling with them.

The deceased were identified as Vinay Srivastava (53), his wife Archana Srivastava (48), their son Kirtarh Srivastava (27), and Ravindra Yadav (20) and Purushottam Kumar (28), both residents of Gaya.

Police rushed to the spot

and launched a rescue operation. The bodies were extricated after considerable effort and sent to the district hospital mortuary for post-mortem. Both vehicles have been seized, and further investigation is underway to ascertain the exact cause of the accident, officials said.

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath expressed grief over the loss of lives and extended his condolences to the bereaved families, officials said.

Ghazipur death: SP, Congress seek justice, Akhilesh says pressure on victim's family

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Ghazipur

As Prime Minister Narendra Modi is scheduled to visit Uttar Pradesh for the inauguration of an expressway on April 29, Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav is set to visit the family of a Dalit girl whose death has triggered a political storm in the state.

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Saturday claimed that the victim, belonging to the Vishwakarma community, was raped and brutally killed and that her family was threatened to prevent the filing of an FIR. Congress general secretary Priyanka Gandhi Vadra said that atrocities against women were at their peak in UP.

SP president Akhilesh Yadav told reporters at the



party headquarters that BJP leaders met the girl's father.

“The BJP seeks to extract political mileage from every situation. However, I am heartened to see that society at large is becoming increas-

ingly aware and the ‘PDA’ (pichhda or backward classes, Dalit, alpsankhyak or minority) is even more vigilant,” he said.

Later, in a post on ‘X’, Yadav alleged a new “disturbing”

trend under the BJP Government: they commit or orchestrate atrocities and later exert pressure on the victims to recant their statements.

“Exploiting the helplessness of a poor person constitutes the most inhumane form of injustice. The BJP's governance and administrative machinery are currently passing through their most abysmal phase,” he said.

In the same post, Yadav demanded, “An inquiry must be conducted to identify these specific BJP people who, under the guise of offering counsel, are actually exerting pressure and doing so in the direct presence of the police.

He demanded that there should be another probe to identify the police personnel who are actively intimidating

the victim's family and are instead filing false charges against those who have come forward to support the victims. “This is a gross atrocity.” Earlier at the party headquarters, Yadav asserted that if his party members wish to visit Ghazipur, it is solely to ensure justice for the victim and to listen to her family's grievances. “We are going there to facilitate the delivery of justice. We all have faith in the judiciary.”

However, he added that “if the family, specifically the father, declines my visit, then I will not go.”

The Samajwadi Party on Friday announced that a delegation led by the party president will visit the village and meet the girl's family on April 29. The same day, Prime Minister Narendra Modi is scheduled to visit Uttar

Pradesh's Hardoi to inaugurate the Ganga Expressway.

A teenage girl's body was found in Karanda area of Ghazipur district on April 15, with her family alleging sexual assault and murder. While the police said they are investigating the case, relatives and locals have been demanding speedy justice.

The controversy intensified on April 22, when a Samajwadi Party delegation visiting the victim's family came under stone-pelting in the village, leaving several people, including police personnel, injured. Police have arrested 10 people in connection with the attack.

Earlier, Yadav alleged that the village head and others protected by the dominant forces were behind the assault, calling it an attack on the PDA.

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costs, improve connectivity for industries, and create new investment opportunities. This project is set to play a key role in establishing Uttar Pradesh as a strong industrial and logistics hub at the national level, the statement said.

₹95 crore flow: ED probes Evangelical...

Probe agencies say TTI is not registered under the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act (FCRA), thus making it illegal for the organisation to receive or utilise foreign funds directly. Its India-specific web portal currently displays “Country Blocked. Access to this page is forbidden.” TTI describes itself as an evangelical movement focused on gospel preaching, training children aged between 4 to 14 and multiplying disciple-making churches in unreached areas through local partners. The ED has warned that such activities risk creating a parallel cash-based economy in Naxalite-affected regions. It poses a serious threat to the security and financial integrity of India and is potentially facilitating illicit funds for unlawful activities. The concentration of withdrawals in sensitive LWE zones has alarmed the central agencies, as it involves national security.

The case underscores the ongoing Indian Government's efforts to enforce FCRA compliance and curb unregulated foreign inflows, especially in vulnerable tribal and insurgency-prone areas where Christian missions often operate among indigenous communities. Further probes into the full network, including overseas entities behind the accounting platform, are underway, sources added. “This development comes amid broader scrutiny of foreign-funded religious organisations in India, raising questions about transparency

in missionary funding while highlighting risks in conflict zones. The ED's action signals tighter oversight on cross-border financial flows bypassing official banking channels,” sources added.

Kejriwal's Sheesh Mahal sequel to haunt AAP...

Verma claimed that Kejriwal's new residence at 95 Lodhi Estate has five bedrooms and four drawing rooms.

He said it has amenities superior to any other bungalow in Lutyens' Delhi, including those of the leaders of other parties, such as the Congress and the DMK.

Hitting back, the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) accused the BJP of using “fake” pictures from the internet and projecting them as the residence of Kejriwal. “The visuals used to claim a so-called ‘Sheesh Mahal 2.0’ linked to the Central Govt allotted official residence of Arvind Kejriwal appear to be nothing more than stock images lifted from Pinterest.

A simple Google search is enough to verify that these images are not connected to any official residence and have been picked from publicly available sources,” the AAP said. The bungalow allotted to Kejriwal is next to the residence of Congress MP Shashi Tharoor.

The documents outlined a ‘contemporary transitional’ design concept and detailed spaces including a foyer, living room, bedrooms, lounge, and meeting room, along with customised furniture and décor elements.

“Verma alleged that the original ‘Sheesh Mahal’ in Delhi was built while the city was battling the COVID wave. He said, “...Kejriwal built the Sheesh Mahal in Delhi when Delhi was suffering from the COVID wave... The people of Delhi

were demanding COVID medicine and were dying. During that time, work on Delhi's Sheesh Mahal didn't stop for a single day, as per Kejriwal's orders...”

“The BJP leader further claimed that after electoral setbacks in Delhi, Kejriwal shifted his political focus to Punjab, creating pressure for Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann, he said, “...When our ‘Dhurandhar’ Delhi voters defeated Delhi's Rahman Dakait, he moved to Punjab, increasing Bhagwant Mann's problems. Of the four large Government houses surrounding Bhagwant Mann's house, one was occupied by Kejriwal, another by former Delhi Health Minister Satyendra Jain, a third by Rajya Sabha MP Sanjay Singh, and another by Manish Sisodia...” Verma also targeted Kejriwal over his recent residence at 95 Lodhi Estate and accused him of abandoning his earlier image of modest living.

He recalled Kejriwal's promise of leading a life of a common man without using government facilities, and said, “Now, when he got a new bungalow at 95 Lodhi Estate. When the pictures of it came out, we were astonished. The man who said he would live simply today lives in a luxurious manner. This is a government-allocated house, but the money invested in this house is not government funds. Last time he said that the PWD invested the money, but in this house, every penny invested is private money but in this house, every penny invested is private money. His own bedroom is looking like Goa's 7-star hotel room. There are a total of five bedrooms.”

The Type VII bungalow, the second largest category of government residential accommodation, spreading over approximately 5,000 square feet (sqft), comprises four bedrooms, a hall, a dining room, a waiting room, an office space and two lawns besides a garage, and three servant quarters.

Decided to act when his chair began to shake: Oppn on Mann’s President plea

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chandigarh

Opposition parties in Punjab on Saturday accused Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann of remaining silent on the State’s issues and acting only when his “chair began to shake”, as he sought time to meet the President over the exodus of AAP Rajya Sabha MPs.

They said the AAP had betrayed the people of Punjab by nominating those “outsiders” to the Rajya Sabha and the party was now reaping what it had sowed.

In a surprise move on Friday, seven Rajya Sabha MPs of the AAP, including six from Punjab, defected to the BJP. The seven MPs are Raghav Chadha, Sandeep Pathak, Ashok Mittal, Harbhajan Singh, Rajinder Gupta, Swati Maliwal and Vikramjit Sahney.

According to AAP sources,



Mann on Saturday sought time from President Droupadi Murmu for a meeting to present his party’s stand on the “recall” of the MPs.

Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) leader Bikram Singh Majithia accused Mann of keeping mum on Punjab’s issues.

“The moment his chair began to shake, he remembered the President. But on the issues of ‘bandi Singhs’

(Sikh prisoners), farmers and Punjab’s rights, there has always been silence. This is the real face of Bhagwant Mann,” Majithia said in a Statement.

Punjab’s resources were being “looted with both hands” by leaders from Delhi, but the chief minister had remained quiet, he charged.

Referring to the AAP’s claim that the defecting MPs had

betrayed Punjab, State Congress president Amrinder Singh Raja Warring said it was not true as Punjabis never had any expectations from them.

“The people of Punjab were actually betrayed the day you nominated all those people, some outsiders and some big billionaires, to the Rajya Sabha,” he said.

The AAP is reaping what it sowed, he added. The Congress leader said the defection of the MPs was in the interest of the people of Punjab.

“Whether it was the membership of Parliament or the power that these people enjoyed, it was all at the expense of the people of Punjab. Punjabi AAP workers were ignored to reward and accommodate the outsiders,” Warring said, adding that the people of the State would always remember this.

NIT Silchar prohibits religious activities in common areas

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

The National Institute of Technology (NIT) at Silchar has restrained its hostel boarders, workers and all individuals associated with it from religious activities in open or common areas of the hostel or institute premises.

The order was passed by the Dean, Students’ Welfare, on Friday, and came into immediate effect. It was not immediately known if there was any specific reason for passing the order.

“It is hereby instructed

that no hostel boarder(s), mess worker(s), or any other individual residing in or associated with the hostel shall conduct or participate in any form of prayer, religious gathering, or related activity in open spaces or common areas within the hostel or the institute premises,” the order said.

It said any violation of the order will be viewed seriously and may invite “appropriate disciplinary action”. “This has the approval of the competent authority, and this order comes into effect immediately,” the order added.



High passenger demand drove capacity expansion on J&K Vande Bharat: Jitendra Singh

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Jammu

Union Minister Jitendra Singh on Saturday said the Vande Bharat Express between Jammu and Srinagar will start from April 30 with additional coaches to meet the high demand.

He said the train was initially planned to run between Jammu and Srinagar but had to be launched from Katra in June last year due to renovation and upgrading work at the Jammu railway station.

“With the completion of the upgrade, the service will now operate from Jammu to Srinagar in both directions from April 30,” he told reporters on the side-



lines of a function here. According to northern Railway’s Jammu division, the premium train service, which has been running between Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Katra and Srinagar for over nine months, will now be extended up to Jammu Tawi with 20 coaches from

the present eight coaches.

The service was flagged off by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on June 6 last year following the inauguration of the Udhampur-Srinagar-Baramulla Rail Link, which provided the Valley all-weather rail connectivity. The Minister of State in the

Prime Minister’s Office said the rail link to Kashmir had remained stalled for years due to alignment issues, particularly in Reasi where the world’s highest railway bridge has now been constructed.

Expressing gratitude to Modi for prioritising infrastructure development in J-K, he said after Modi assumed office in 2014, it became possible to move the project forward.

“While the rail network had reached Jammu in 1962, renewed efforts in recent years have accelerated progress, resulting in improved connectivity and integration of the Kashmir with the rest of the country,” he said.

The tracks were extended beyond Jammu only after Modi came to power, eventually reaching from Katra to Srinagar, he said.

Highlighting the growing popularity of the service, the minister said tickets were being booked months in advance as passengers were keen to travel on the scenic route. To accommodate the surge in demand, the number of coaches has been increased, he added.

The development marks a significant step in strengthening connectivity and boosting tourism and economic activity in Jammu and Kashmir, Singh said.

Meanwhile, President of Jammu Chamber of

Commerce and Industry Arun Gupta also expressed gratitude to the prime minister and Union Railway Minister Ashwani Vaishnav for the start of the direct rail service between Jammu and Srinagar, saying it will boost connectivity and morale of both the regions.

Gupta, however, expressed grave concern for shifting the already surveyed alignment of Jammu-Rajouri-Poonch rail link to new rail alignment via Reasi to Poonch which is more difficult terrain and may not only escalate the project cost but will also neglect the established population centres who are awaiting since long for this connectivity.

AAP seeks ouster of seven Rajya Sabha MPs who joined BJP

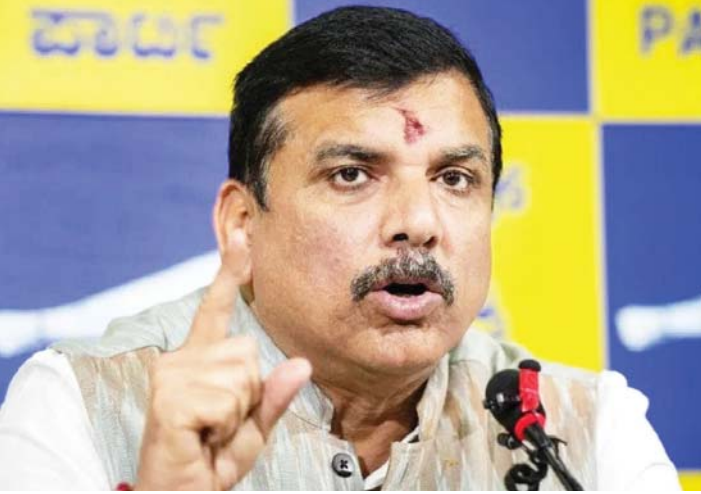
PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) on Saturday said it will seek the disqualification of its seven Rajya Sabha MPs who joined the BJP, calling the move unconstitutional and illegal. Senior AAP leader and MP Sanjay Singh said he will write to the Rajya Sabha Chairman and the Vice President, citing the Tenth Schedule and demanding termination of their membership, arguing that even a two-thirds split holds no legal validity under the anti-defection law.

Addressing a press conference at the AAP headquarters on Saturday, Singh said, “On Friday, seven indi-

viduals announced their decision to join the BJP in a manner that was unconstitutional, illegal, and against the rules.” He asserted that this is completely wrong in legal terms.

The AAP leader highlighted that the anti-defection law clearly States that no form of split is permissible in the Assembly, Rajya Sabha, or Lok Sabha, and said, “It has no legal recognition, and this has also been clearly established in the Shiv Sena case.” Sanjay Singh explained that the Tenth Schedule clearly provides that any kind of split, even if it involves a two-thirds majority or increases from seven to eight members, has no legal validity.



“Therefore, the defection of these seven Rajya Sabha MPs from the Aam Aadmi Party is entirely illegal, incorrect, unconstitutional, and against parliamentary rules,” he said, and added that he would submit a letter to the Rajya Sabha Chairman and the Vice President, citing all these rules and demanding the complete termination of the membership of all seven MPs.

He further said that three of these individuals, Raghav Chadha, Sandeep Pathak, and Ashok Mittal, had clearly gone to the BJP office on Friday. Regarding the remaining four individuals being claimed, he said that he would also write to the Rajya Sabha

Chairman and the Vice President seeking termination of their membership as well.

Taking a dig at PM Narendra Modi, AAP leader Saurabh Bharadwaj said people are asking Prime Minister Modi why, despite claims over 11 years that India’s stature has risen globally, leaders like Donald Trump make derogatory remarks about India and Indians when given the chance. “Donald Trump imposes tariffs on India at will, yet the Prime Minister remains silent. Indians are sent back to India in chains, and there is no response. Trump suggests a ceasefire with Pakistan and the Prime Minister accepts it without question,” he said.

J&K Police recover digital devices in Srinagar jail

MOHIT KANDHARI
■ Jammu

Close on the heels of the arrest of four Overground workers (OGWs), including a woman from the Hazratbal area of Srinagar, a counter-intelligence wing of Jammu and Kashmir Police, Saturday, swooped down on the premises of Central Jail, Srinagar and recovered various communication digital devices.

According to official sources, the searches were conducted inside the highly fortified central jail premises in connection with a terror-linked case. Before the searches were



launched, a search warrant was issued by a court designated under the NIA Act in connection with FIR No. 06/2023 registered at Police Station CI Kashmir under relevant sections of the IPC

and the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act.

The raids were conducted based on certain technical inputs indicating the presence of suspicious digital signatures within the Central

jail premises. The day-long searches were conducted across multiple barracks and blocks in coordination with central jail authorities.

“Incriminating material in the form of digital communication devices was recovered and seized during the operation,” an official said, adding that the devices will be sent for forensic examination to ascertain links, if any, with a larger terror network.

The latest security breach inside the central jail premises in Srinagar may prompt the prison authorities to initiate a fresh security audit across the Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir. The

prison authorities will conduct a thorough investigation to identify the individuals involved in smuggling digital devices inside the jail premises.

Officials said they will investigate the possible roles of facilitators or collaborators and take legal action if warranted.

They said the operation is part of ongoing efforts to curb terror activities and dismantle support networks operating from within jails. So far, the Union Territory administration has terminated the services of more than 90 Government employees with alleged terror links.

Memes flood social media as 7 AAP MPs join BJP

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

From “placement ho gayi” jokes to Hera Pheri-style confusion and dramatic “washing machine” memes, social media platforms turned into a comedy zone after Rajya Sabha MP Raghav Chadha announced on Friday that he and six other AAP MPs have quit the party and joined the BJP.

Users responded with humour, sarcasm and film-style punchlines, making the political development one of the day’s most



talked-about online trends.

One widely shared meme showed the famous classroom scene where a student proudly says his placement has happened, with users joking that the MPs had finally received their “dream package” in politics.

Mamata opposing Citizenship Amendment Act to protect *iftari* on streets: Yogi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Nadia/Purba Bardhaman/ North 24 Parganas

Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath launched a strong attack on the Trinamool Congress (TMC) from the soil of West Bengal on Saturday. He said clearly, Mamata didi opposed the Citizenship (Amendment) Act (CAA) because she is worried that if Hindus increase, how will “iftari” be held on the streets.

He said, “TMC does not believe in democracy. Everyone witnessed its hooliganism during the first phase of polling. But when the results come on May 4, TMC goons will have no place to hide. With the possibility of

a double-engine Government in Bengal, these goons have started searching for work. Some are thinking where to open a ‘puncture shop’, while others are worried about saving their lives by becoming road sweepers. However, wherever these attackers go, we will track them down.”

Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath was addressing public meetings in support of BJP candidates Shruti Shekhar Goswami from Nabadwip Assembly constituency, Krishna Ghosh from Katwa, and Soma Thakur from Bagda Assembly constituency. Even in the intense heat, there was no insufficiency in the enthusiasm of the people of Bengal towards CM Yogi.

Thousands present at the rallies continuously raised slogans of “Yogi-Yogi”.

He expressed gratitude to the voters for this affection. He said Bengal will no longer accept anarchy. The stigma of loot imposed on Bengal by Congress, Communists, and TMC must now end. The people of Bengal have decided to bring a double-engine Government, which will work at double speed. To settle accounts with TMC goons, a double-engine Government in Bengal is necessary.

CM Yogi congratulated voters for record voting on 152 seats in the first phase. He said every voter had the will to free Bengal from terror, mafia rule, and corruption and to re-



establish it as a symbol of India’s identity by bringing a BJP double-engine Government. The scenes on polling day indicated that when results come on May 4, saffron flags will be seen waving across Bengal.

CM Yogi said, 500 years ago, Chaitanya Mahaprabhu attracted the world through

the melodious chant of “Hare Krishna, Hare Rama” and established India’s Sanatan flag on the global stage, and today, ISKCON monks are doing the same. This land represents India’s spiritual heritage, pride, sacrifice, courage, and self-respect. It is the land of spirituality,

patriotism, art, and literature. This land once led India’s spiritual, cultural, and literary heritage. This is the same Bengal that was once known as the “cultural capital” of the country.

He informed, “Today, under TMC rule, Bengal is struggling for its identity. Industries are shutting down, farmers are not getting fair prices, youth are not getting jobs, and Government employees are not receiving full salaries. Law and order is alarming, and hooliganism is at its peak. In a TMC Government symbolising terror, mafia rule, and corruption, BJP worker Sanjay Bhowmik was brutally murdered, and TMC goons roam freely. Land, sand, and cattle

mafias dominate Bengal. The money sent by PM Modi for development is being looted by TMC goons, but Bengal has now awakened. The era of “cut money” and anarchy will end.”

CM told voters that the time has come to get rid of the TMC Government that allows infiltrators to rob their rights. Any work that benefits India and Bengal is opposed by the TMC. When the Prime Minister brought the CAA (Citizenship Amendment Act) in Parliament, the TMC opposed it. This Act guarantees that Hindus, Buddhists, Jains, and Sikhs persecuted in Pakistan, Bangladesh, and Afghanistan and living in India for more than five years will get Indian citizenship.



States Focus



AIADMK AGENTS MUST BE ALERT ON MAY 4: PALANISWAMI

AIADMK General Secretary Edappadi K Palaniswami on Saturday asked his party's counting agents to be alert when the counting of votes begins on May 4. Elections to the Tamil Nadu Assembly were held on April 23, and the votes will be counted on May 4, 2026. Palaniswami, in a statement, said that the appointed party counting agents should reach the counting station an hour earlier with the required identity card. The AIADMK leader said that the agents should also ensure that all the preparations in the counting centres are adequate. "The representative should take extra time when counting of ballot votes starts", he said, adding "they should also ensure that all EVMs were sealed properly before counting begins".



NO RE POLL ORDERED IN TAMIL NADU, BENGAL: ECI OFFICIALS

No repoll has been recommended in any of the polling stations in West Bengal and Tamil Nadu where Assembly elections were held on Thursday, the ECI officials said on Saturday. While all 234 Assembly seats in Tamil Nadu went to vote in a single phase, 152 seats in West Bengal voted in the first phase. The remaining 142 seats will go to the polls on April 29. Poll panel officials had earlier cited rules to point out that if webcasting in any of the polling stations is "deliberately" disrupted, a repoll will be ordered. In the 2021 Assembly polls in Tamil Nadu, a repoll at a polling station in Chennai was ordered as a defective paper trail machine was carried out on a two-wheeler, as the 'zonal party' of the area erroneously mistook it as an unused defective machine.

Amit Shah says BJP will win 110 seats in 1st phase of polling

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Kolkata

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Friday asserted the BJP had sealed its victory in the first phase of the West Bengal Assembly polls itself, claiming the party would win 110 seats in the polling held on April 23.

Addressing an election rally, he promised swift implementation of the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA), particularly for the Matua community, once the BJP came to power in the State.

"Voting for the first phase is over. In the very first phase itself, the BJP will win 110



Union Home Minister Amit Shah being felicitated during a public meeting as he campaigns in Jamalpur constituency ahead of second phase of the West Bengal Assembly elections in Purba Bardhaman district

seats, and Didi will be thrown out of power. Instead of TMC, the BJP will form a Government here," he said. Voting was held in 152 of

Every Indian has stake in West Bengal polls outcome: Himanta

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Kolkata

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Saturday said that every Indian has a stake in the ongoing West Bengal Assembly elections, as Bangladeshi infiltrators were not only causing demographic change in the State but also spilling over to adjoining States. Sarma said the BJP will win over 100 of the 126 seats in Assam, and will bag 110 of the 152 seats that went to polls in the first phase of polls in West Bengal.

"It would not be surprising if the BJP won over 200 seats in West Bengal. The around 93 per cent voter turnout in phase 1 showed that there is no atmosphere of fear which had earlier prevented people from openly backing the BJP," he said, while addressing a press conference in Kolkata. Sarma said the West Bengal Assembly election

was not a routine State poll but a contest with civilisational implications for the entire nation, particularly its eastern and northeastern States.

"Every Indian has a stake in this election. The impact of infiltration is not limited to West Bengal and Assam. It is spilling over to Jharkhand, Bihar and other States," he said, responding to the TMC's narrative of branding BJP leaders as outsiders.

He said that if the BJP was not voted to power in West Bengal, the State risked becoming an "extension of Bangladesh" due to unchecked infiltration.

"A demography once changed cannot be reversed," he said.

Sarma pointed to West Bengal's geography as the central factor, noting that the State shared 54 per cent of India's total border with Bangladesh, compared to Tripura's 21 per cent, Meghalaya's 11 per cent,



Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma addressing a press conference during the West Bengal Assembly elections in Kolkata on Saturday

Mizoram's 8 per cent and Assam's 6 per cent.

"You cannot see the West Bengal election in isolation from Assam, Tripura, Meghalaya and Mizoram. If even one border remains open, its impact will be felt across all other States," he said, adding that infiltrators entering through Malda and

Murshidabad districts were not staying confined to West Bengal but were using the State as a corridor to reach Assam and other parts of India.

On fencing of the international border, Sarma accused the Trinamool Congress Government of deliberate obstruction.

Assam polls: CEO conducts training for vote counting

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Guwahati

In a bid to ensure a seamless and transparent conclusion to the 2026 Assam Legislative Assembly elections, the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO), Assam, organised a comprehensive training programme for poll officials at a city hotel on Saturday.

The session, held at Radisson Blu, was specifically tailored for District Election Officers (DEOs), Returning Officers, and Election Officers to familiarise them with the rigorous protocols required for the counting of votes, scheduled for May 4.

Presiding over the programme, CEO Anurag Goel emphasised that the count-



ing process must be executed in strict adherence to the guidelines laid down by the Election Commission of India (ECI). He urged officials to maintain "special vigilance" during the handling of

Electronic Voting Machines (EVMs) and Voter Verifiable Paper Audit Trails (VVPATs).

The training covered the entire spectrum of post-poll procedures, including the opening of strong rooms,

the secure transportation of materials to counting halls, and the methodical counting of postal ballots and EVM votes. Detailed instructions were also provided regarding the deployment of count-

ing personnel, issuance of identity cards to agents, and the implementation of robust fire safety and media management protocols.

The programme also featured interactive sessions where officials clarified technical queries regarding the mandatory post-counting formalities to be completed within stipulated timeframes.

Senior poll officials, including the Additional and Joint Chief Electoral Officers, attended the session as resource persons. This administrative push comes as the State prepares for the final stage of the democratic exercise that saw voters across 126 constituencies exercise their franchise on April 9.

Omar questions claims of advantage for BJP in West Bengal polls



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Bengaluru

Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah on Saturday questioned claims of advantage for BJP in West Bengal, alleging manipulation in voter rolls and raising concerns over SIR.

Assembly elections are underway in West Bengal in two phases. While the first phase got over on April 23, the second will be conducted on April 29. The first phase recorded over 92 per cent polling.

Speaking to reporters here, Abdullah said the focus on voting percentage was misleading and did not reflect the ground reality of voter participation.

"Those saying advantage to the BJP quote either from the press notes sent by the saffron party or who have not gone deeply into the data," he claimed. He further claimed that the total number of voters in West Bengal had decreased compared to the previous election, even as the percentage turnout appeared higher.

"The percentage has increased because you (ECI) have reduced the number of voters. Due to the SIR (Special Intensive Revision of electoral roll), so many voters have been removed. Compared to the previous election, the total number of voters has gone down this time, even though the percentage has gone up," he said.

Alleging large-scale deletions from electoral rolls, Abdullah, who is also the National Conference leader, said, "In Mamata Banerjee's own constituency, 25 per cent of voters have been removed. In West Bengal, there are 70 seats where the number of voters removed from the list is more than the BJP's margin of defeat in the last election. That means in 70 seats, the margin itself has been wiped out. If this is not a weapon, then what is?"

Mamata to become West Bengal CM for fourth consecutive term: Tejashwi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Kolkata

RJD leader Tejashwi Yadav has exuded confidence that Mamata Banerjee would become West Bengal chief minister for the fourth consecutive term as he attended the ruling party's roadshows in North 24 Parganas district. Yadav, who arrived here on Friday and attended back-to-back roadshows in Jagaddal, Bhatpara and Khardaha Assembly constituencies.

In a post on X, he said, "A roadshow was held with enthusiasm and excitement in support of TMC candidate Amit Gupta from the Bhatpara Assembly constituency under the Barrackpore Lok Sabha area in North 24

Parganas district and TMC candidate from Jagaddal, Somnath Shyam."

After attending a rally at Kharadaha Assembly seat in support of TMC candidate Devdeep Purohit, the RJD leader said, "The unwavering love, firm trust, and overwhelming public support from the people clearly indicate that the people of Bengal have made up their minds to bless CM Mamata Banerjee with a resounding majority for a fourth consecutive term."

Upon arriving in Kolkata, Yadav was asked to comment on Raghav Chadha crossing over to the BJP from AAP. He replied, "Some people compromise. He must have joined the BJP out of fear or greed."



Entire Union Cabinet, 19 CMs would not help BJP win Bengal polls: Mamata



West Bengal CM and TMC candidate from Bhabanipur constituency Mamata Banerjee greeting supporters during a roadshow ahead of the second phase of State Assembly elections in Kolkata on Saturday

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Kolkata

TMC chief Mamata Banerjee on Saturday claimed that the BJP has deployed its entire machinery to defeat the regional party in the West Bengal Assembly elections as almost the entire Union cabinet and CMs of NDA-ruled States are camping in the poll-bound State.

Addressing an election rally at Uttarpara in Hooghly district, Banerjee accused the BJP of giving false promises to migrant workers from West Bengal employed outside the State. "The BJP is desperate, with 50 helicopters flying into West Bengal as almost the entire Union cabinet, from the PM to home, railway and defence ministers, as well as CMs of 19 NDA-ruled States camping in a single State — West Bengal," the

chief minister said.

Compare this with only three helicopters being used by the TMC to campaign across the State. But all this hype and sound and fury will end in a whimper on May 4, she said. "On top of this, we are seeing central forces wherever we are going. They are bringing in armoured vehicles which are not put to use where such vehicles are needed," Banerjee said.

On Union Home Minister Amit Shah's reported statement that "TMC-aided goons would be hung upside down after the results", she said, "As a Union minister and a responsible leader, you cannot utter such words. You are speaking in the language of terror. I know no action will be taken against you. But, I have asked our men to video-graph his speech and submit the same to the court."

CPI(M) misusing State machinery to attack BJP workers: Rajeev Chandrasekhar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Thiruvananthapuram

BJP Kerala president Rajeev Chandrasekhar on Saturday alleged that the CPI(M) was "misusing" the State machinery to attack the saffron party's workers and said it was not correct to do so.

Chandrasekhar claimed that the CPI(M) was frustrated over its impending defeat in the Assembly polls and the change in Government after May 4 and therefore, was attacking BJP workers with the help of some police officers.

He made the remarks after visiting the home of a party worker who was allegedly



assaulted by police recently. "I would like to say that what they are doing is not right. While in power, using the State machinery to attack our workers — this is a wrong move on the part of the CPI(M). We will not allow it.

"This has to stop and it will be stopped. We will take legal action against it. We are the largest party in India and attacks on our workers by anyone will not be accepted by us," he contended.

He further said that the politics of registering cases against BJP leaders like R Sreelekha will end after May 4. Addressing reporters here in the evening, he said, "There is a democratic system here. This is India and not Russia or China. There is no politics of violence here. If CPI(M) cannot understand that, we will make them understand."

Mamata helping rich, not poor in Bengal, Modi doing same across country: Rahul

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Serampore (WB)

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Saturday sought to put Prime Minister Narendra Modi and West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee in the same bracket, accusing both of helping the rich instead of the poor, while hankering for power.

Addressing an election rally at Serampore in Hooghly district, Gandhi said that Modi "claims to be a 'deshbhakt' (patriot), but is selling off the country".



Congress leader Rahul Gandhi addressing a public meeting in support of the party's West Bengal President and candidate from Srerampur constituency Subhankar Sarkar, ahead of the second phase of the State Assembly elections at Serampore in Hooghly district on Saturday

"While CM Mamata Banerjee is helping the rich, and not the poor in West Bengal, Modi is doing the same across the country... Both have nothing to do with creating job opportunities. They want power but don't work for people," he said.

"Wherever the PM goes, he spreads hatred and fear among people," the leader of the Opposition in Lok Sabha alleged.

He claimed that the country is witnessing a fight between two ideologies.

"It is the Congress' unity

and brotherhood against the BJP and RSS' hatred and violence," he added.

He accused the PM of harming small industries in the country through demonetisation and implementing GST in a "wrongful manner".

"West Bengal used to be the centre of industry in the country, but first the Left Front and then the TMC destroyed everything," he claimed.

Stating that only the Congress can fight the BJP on the basis of ideology, Gandhi, at another public meeting in Kolkata, said, "We cannot

compromise with them." Gandhi said he undertook the 'Bharat Jodo Yatra' in 2022 to promote brotherhood and love, claiming that "BJP spreads violence across the country and the TMC does the same in West Bengal".

The Congress leader accused the Narendra Modi Government of compromising the country's interests in the India-US trade deal, "selling out the country's agriculture sector, small and medium industries, energy security and also handing over India's data to the US".

PROSPECT

SC appoints its former judge Hrishikesh Roy as Bihar Cricket Association ombudsman



The Supreme Court has appointed its former judge Hrishikesh Roy to act as ombudsman of the Bihar Cricket Association. It noted that former apex court judge Abhay S Oka, who was appointed as the ombudsman of the association on March 20, has expressed his disinclination to act as the ombudsman considering that it involves some adjudicatory function. "In view of the aforesaid, we appoint Justice Hrishikesh Roy, former judge of this court to act as the Ombudsman of the Bihar Cricket Association," a bench of justices J B Pardiwala and K V Viswanathan said in its April 21 order.

The top court was hearing a matter related to the Bihar Cricket Association (BCA). In August last year, the top court had appointed its former judge L Nageswara Rao as the ombudsman of the BCA.

It had requested the ombudsman to have a formal meeting with the stakeholders and try to workout the modalities for smooth functioning of the association.

In its March 20 order, the bench had noted that Justice Rao had forwarded his exhaustive report along with a separate note. It had also noted that Justice Rao had made a request that he may be relieved from the assignment. The bench had then appointed Justice Oka to act as the ombudsman of the BCA. On April 21, the bench posted the matter for hearing on May 13 insofar as the report forwarded by Justice Rao is concerned.

VRIKSH The Theatre set to showcase *Ballavpur Ki Roopkatha* on May 3

VRIKSH The Theatre is presenting a stage performance of *Ballavpur Ki Roopkatha*, a delightful horror comedy drama by Badal Sircar on May 3 at LTG Auditorium, Mandi House, New Delhi at 6.30 pm.

Directed by Praveen Pithambaran. Tickets are available in Book my show. VRIKSH The Theatre is a dynamic theatre group established on August 16, 2015 at Kerala Club. The name "VRKSH" (meaning tree) symbolises growth, inclusivity, and artistic expression. Just like a tree rooted deeply in the earth while aspiring to reach the sky, VRIKSH nurtures creativity while striving for artistic excellence. With its open and welcoming canopy, VRIKSH aims to bring people together through the power of theatre-transcending barriers of religion, caste, and politics. It envisions itself as a collective platform for theatre artists in Delhi, fostering collaboration and celebrating the spirit of performing arts.



IRCTC offers exclusive discounts on its Buddhist Circuit Tourist train package

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Indian Railway Catering and Tourism Corporation (IRCTC), the country's leading Travel and Tourism Public Sector Enterprise, continues to strengthen its position in experiential tourism with its acclaimed flagship product- the Buddhist Circuit Special Tourist Train. This unique offering has earned wide-spread recognition in the global travel and tourism landscape for its seamless integration of spirituality, heritage, and luxury travel.

The all-inclusive 7 Nights / 8 Days Buddhist Circuit Tour departs from Safdarjung

Railway Station in New Delhi and takes passengers on a spiritually enriching journey through some of the most revered destinations associated with the life and teachings of Gautama Buddha. The itinerary includes visits to Bodh Gaya, Nalanda (via Rajgir), Varanasi (including Sarnath), Lumbini, Kushinagar, and Shravasti. The journey culminates with a visit to the iconic Taj Mahal, one of the Seven Wonders of the World, offering a blend of spiritual and cultural heritage.

The tour is conducted aboard a fully air-conditioned Deluxe Tourist Train featuring 12 state-of-the-art, ergonom-

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Saturday urged all entities in the financial sector to be 'exceptionally vigilant' on cybersecurity.

Without naming Mythos, the newly minted platform from leading AI company Anthropic, Sitharaman said artificial intelligence tools are making cyberattacks faster and more adaptive.

Such tools can also evade detection by deploying tactics like automated discovery of system vulnerabilities and malicious source-code interference, she added.

"... not just Sebi but all regulated entities will have to remain exceptionally vigilant. The tools of attack are evolving at high speed, and the tools of defence must evolve even faster," Sitharaman said, speaking at the 28th foundation day event of the capital markets regulator.

The comments come amid heightened fears over the capabilities of Mythos, which has sent regulators and policymakers scrambling around the world to understand the platform and ways to safeguard their systems.

The government had called a meeting of top bankers with ministers, including Sitharaman and IT minister Ashwini Vaishnav, in New Delhi on Thursday, where it announced the formation of a dedicated panel under SBI chairman C S Setty for the purpose.

On Saturday, Sitharaman warned that a single successful cyberattack on a major exchange, depository, or a large broker can disrupt markets on a national scale, erase wealth, and shake public confidence and urged Sebi to meet the emerging challenge of cybersecurity.

Sitharaman urged Sebi to institutionalise a system of periodic consultation with its peers across the world, making it clear that Indian regulations must not imitate other countries.

In comments made amid unease over foreign flows, Sitharaman said that such dialogue between regulators can give confidence to global capital.

"The more SEBI's frameworks are understood abroad, the greater the confidence of global capital in Indian markets," and the greater the weight SEBI carries in global rulemak-



Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman lights the ceremonial lamp during the 38th Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) Foundation Day at the Jio World Convention Centre in Mumbai, Maharashtra on Saturday. SEBI Chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey is also present

PTI

ing," she said. Sitharaman also exhorted the financial system to progress towards the goal of common know your customer (KYC) across all functions.

"It is the shared responsibility of all stakeholders to ensure that no citizen has to repeat the same verification journey across multiple financial products and platforms," she said, urging Sebi to help drive the pre-

scription of common KYC norms. On the regulations front, the FM pitched for a soft-touch, public consultation-based approach to form principles-based rules rather than "overly detailed rulebooks". There is a need for regulations to not be restrictive, and be more sophisticated and anticipatory rather than merely reactive, the FM said. Sitharaman said Sebi's recent actions

against unregistered 'fininfluencers' should be seen as the regulator's seriousness to crack down against unlicensed financial advice, and underlined the need for more efforts on financial education.

"... we should not tolerate the monetisation of uninforme retail investor trust for personal enrichment," she added. With progress in technology, there is an explosion of fake investment

AAI's electronics engineers body raises concern over proposed privatisation of ATC services

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mumbai

ATSEPA, an electronic engineers' body at Airports Authority of India (AAI), has raised concerns over the proposed privatisation of air traffic control services, saying that shifting control away from the Authority without establishing an autonomous regulatory entity could be perceived as a policy decision that weakens India's national strategic capabilities.

In a letter to Civil Aviation Minister K Rammoohan Naidu on April 23, Air Traffic Safety Electronic Personnel Association (India) General Secretary YP Gautam said the matter warrants urgent reconsideration at the highest policy level.

"The proposal to introduce private participation in Air Traffic Control services, without first operationalising an independent Air Navigation Services (ANS) structure, is viewed with grave concern," he said.

Stating that the matter is not exploratory, he said the carving out of ANS (ATC + CNS) from AAI has already been "deliberated, accepted in principle, and partially implemented" during the tenure of (late AAI Chairman) Guru Prasad Mohapatra.



Alleging that the rollback of that framework has resulted in the present structural inconsistency, he said, "Proceeding with privatisation in the absence of an autonomous ANS entity will be perceived as a policy decision that weakens an existing national capability rather than strengthening it".

Creating a system where ANS remains

a dependent internal unit while competing with private entities will be seen as institutional disadvantage by design, the association said.

Fragmentation of ATC services in a safety-critical domain raises serious questions of accountability, uniformity, and operational integrity, it added.

The association also warned that "ignoring an already available, trained, and proven ANS workforce in favour of external providers risks avoidable dilution of sovereign expertise".

Seeking immediate operationalisation of ANS as an independent entity with full functional, financial, and administrative autonomy, prior to going ahead with the privatisation, ATSEPA said the entity should be enabled to provide ATC and CNS services to all airports on a non-discriminatory and competitive basis.

"The role of AAI should be clearly redefined to avoid overlap and conflict of interest. It is necessary to state that any move to proceed otherwise will be viewed as structurally flawed and institutionally detrimental, and is unlikely to find acceptance among the professional community entrusted with maintaining the safety and efficiency of India's airspace" it said.

Haryana IDFC First Bank fraud: Development and panchayat dept official dismissed from service



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

The Haryana Government has dismissed an official of the Development and Panchayat Department from service in connection with the ₹590 crore IDFC First Bank fraud case.

"The Government has taken strict action in major financial case by dismissing Naresh Bhuwani, Superintendent in the Development & Panchayats Department, from service. The action has been taken under the provisions of Article 311(2)(b) of the Constitution after a detailed investigation into a criminal conspiracy and the emergence of substantial evidence," an official statement quoting a government spokesperson said on Friday.

This decision has been taken in line with the government's zero-tolerance policy towards corruption, it said.

The spokesperson said that Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini had issued strict directions that corruption at any level would not be tolerated and that strict action would be taken against anyone found guilty, regardless of their position.

As per the statement, the Government spokesperson said, "An inquiry committee constituted in February 2026

by the director, Development and Panchayats Department, had uncovered irregularities and discrepancies in accounts operated in IDFC First Bank and AU Small Finance Bank. Based on the committee's report and supporting documents, the case was referred to the State Vigilance and Anti-Corruption Bureau (SV&ACB) for criminal investigation".

Subsequently, on February 23, 2026, an FIR was registered at the SV&ACB police station in Panchkula under various sections of the Prevention of Corruption Act and the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita.

"During the investigation, it emerged that the case involved an organised, multi-layered financial fraud, in which government funds were transferred to 'shell companies' through fraudulent banking transactions," the spokesperson said.

The investigation further revealed that Naresh Bhuwani, in alleged collusion with private individuals and other accused persons, had created a fake firm used for siphoning off government funds. Crores of rupees were transferred from the firm's accounts to his personal accounts and were used to purchase private properties.

India autism center launches 'Sports For All' autism initiative

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

As part of World Autism Awareness Month, the India Autism Center (IAC)—which supports individuals with autism and related neurodevelopmental conditions—hosted the 'Sports for All: Building an Equitable Sporting Ecosystem for All' initiative. Held in collaboration with The Quantum Hub, Special Olympics Bharat, and The Accessibility Coalition, the event brought together policymakers, practitioners, para- and special athletes, and inclusion advocates to drive conversations on equitable access and participation in sports.

The program featured a felicitation ceremony honoring young neurodiverse athletes. It was led by Dr Mallika Nadda, President of Special Olympics Bharat; Geeta Mandaviya, Patron Member of Special Olympics Gujarat; Jaishankar Natarajan, Director and



Chief Executive Officer of India Autism Center; Sakhi Singhi, Governing Body Member and Head of Communications, Partnerships, Fundraising, and Talent Acquisition at India Autism Center; and Rohit Kumar, Founding Partner of The Quantum Hub.

The summit also included a multi-stakeholder panel discussion titled 'Building an Equitable Sporting

Ecosystem: Bridging Training, CSR, and Policy'. Moderated by Nipun Malhotra, Chief Executive Officer of Nipman Foundation and Director of Disability and Inclusion at The Quantum Hub, the panel featured Sonali Philip (Director of Operations, People & Culture, Go Sports), Suvarna Raj (Managing Director, Sugamya Accessibility & Inclusion), Damini Ghosh (Lead, Disability & Inclusion Access, Vidhi Centre for Legal Policy), and Aditya KV (Founder & CEO, Umoya Sports). They explored pathways for systemic change, accessibility, and inclusive participation in sports.

Additionally, a lightning talk moderated by Sakhi Singhi offered first-hand perspectives from the coaches of Yadhavi and the parents of the swimmers. Jaishankar Natarajan, CEO and Director of the India Autism Center, shared, "Sports have the power to transform lives by nurturing confidence, resilience, discipline, and a deep sense of belonging."

Assam chief secretary reviews rain readiness in Guwahati

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

With the India Meteorological Department (IMD) forecasting heavy rainfall over the next 48 hours, Chief Secretary Dr Ravi Kota on Saturday chaired a high-level review meeting to assess the city's preparedness for potential flooding and landslides.

The meeting focused on the operational readiness of pumping systems and the progress of desilting major drains across the city. Dr Kota issued strict directives to the Guwahati Municipal Corporation (GMC) and the Guwahati Metropolitan Development Authority (GMDA) to ensure the round-the-clock deployment of super suckers and machinery to tackle waterlogging.

Special attention was given to over 300 locations



Chief Secretary Ravi Kota

identified as landslide-prone zones. These areas are currently under close surveillance, and the administration has intensified public awareness initiatives to alert resi-

dents in vulnerable pockets.

The Chief Secretary further directed officials to secure open manholes and install barricades at high-risk locations to prevent accidents

during inundation. Key drainage systems, including the Bharalu, Bahini, and Silsaku channels, along with cross-drainage structures near the National Highway at Jalukbari and Maligaon, were also reviewed for blockages.

The Guwahati City Traffic Police have been placed on alert to activate alternative traffic management plans in the event of congestion. Citizens are advised to exercise extreme caution, avoid waterlogged areas, and stay away from open drains and landslide-vulnerable zones during the anticipated down-pour on April 26 and 27.

The meeting was attended by the Special Chief Secretary (DOHUA), Additional Chief Secretary (Revenue and Disaster Management), and the Commissioner of Police, among other senior representatives.

FROM THE

WORLD

US

Indian envoy

meets Chris

India's Ambassador to the US Vinay Mohan Kwatra on Friday met US Energy Secretary Chris Wright and discussed the energy partnership between the two countries. Kwatra received Wright and his wife Liz at the India House here. "Honoured to host @SecretaryWright and Wright at India House. Productive conversation on a range of subjects including the India-US energy partnership," Kwatra said in a post on X. The US is keen to cooperate with India on civil nuclear cooperation in addition to other areas, such as coal gasification and US LPG exports. India has increased its energy imports from the US over the past year amid trade pact negotiations with Washington. India is the largest buyer of US coal globally with coking coal contributing 40 per cent of the total 20 M tonnes of coal imported by Delhi from the US in FY25.

CANADA

OpenAI failed

to alert police

The head of OpenAI has written a letter apologising that his company didn't alert law enforcement about the online behaviour of a person who shot and killed eight people in Tumbler Ridge, British Columbia. Sam Altman expressed his deepest condolences to the entire community. "I am deeply sorry that we did not alert law enforcement to the account that was banned in June," Altman said. The letter, appeared on B.C. Premier David Eby's social media and also on the local news website Tumbler Ridgelines on Friday. On February 10, police say an 18-year-old alleged shooter, identified as Jesse Van Rootselaar, killed her 39-year-old mother, Jennifer Jacobs, and 11-year-old stepbrother, Emmett Jacobs, in their northern British Columbia home before heading to the nearby Tumbler Ridge Secondary School and opening fire, killing five children and an educator before killing herself.

US hunts explosive mines to reopen

Strait Of Hormuz

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Washington

President Donald Trump says the US Navy is clearing Iranian mines from the Strait of Hormuz, a vital sea route for oil shipments whose disruption is increasingly threatening the global economy.

Sweeping for underwater explosives could take months despite a tenuous ceasefire between the United States and Iran in the week-long war, experts say.

Any future claims that the US cleared the waterway where 20 per cent of the world's oil typically passes might fail to convince commercial freighters and their insurers that it is finally safe.

"You don't even have to have laid mines - you just have to make people believe that you've laid mines," said Emma Salisbury, a



scholar at the Foreign Policy Research Institute's National Security Program.

"And even if the US sweeps the strait and says everything's clear,

all the Iranians have to do is say, Well, actually, you haven't found them all yet," said Salisbury, who

is also a fellow at the Royal Navy Strategic Studies Centre. "There's only so much the US can do to give that confidence back to commercial shipping."

Seeking out mines is one of the latest tactics announced by the Trump administration to get traffic

moving again through the strait, as rising energy prices and wider economic effects pose a political risk. The US has also blockaded Iran's ports, seized ships tied to Tehran and planned to take part in a second round of ceasefire talks in Pakistan this weekend.

Hegseth doesn't deny that mine-clearing could take 6 months

Pentagon officials told lawmakers it would likely take six months to clear the mines that Iran has set in the strait, according to a person familiar with the situation who spoke on condition of anonymity to discuss the sensitive information. The information was delivered during a classified briefing at the House Armed Services Committee on Tuesday.

When asked about the estimate, Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth told reporters Friday that the mil-

itary would not speculate on a timeline, but he did not deny it.

"Allegedly, that was something that was said," Hegseth said at a Pentagon news conference. "But we feel confident in our ability, in the correct period of time, to clear any mines that we identify." Trump said he has ordered the Navy to attack any boat laying mines in the strait. "Additionally, our mine sweepers are clearing the Strait right now," the president said on social media Thursday. "I am hereby ordering that activity to continue, but at a tripled-up level!"

Adm. Brad Cooper, the top US commander in the Middle East, recently told reporters that the military would be working to clear mines from the strait. He did not offer details. There is no indication that the US military is using warships, its most visible mine-clear-

ing assets, in the strait now. But the Navy also has divers and small teams of explosive ordnance disposal technicians in the region that are capable of clearing mines. They are a less obvious target than a large warship.

Experts also say some mine-clearing equipment could be moved off ships and deployed from land. It is unclear whether a single mine has been deployed. Iran has mentioned only the "likelihood" of mines in the strait's prewar routes.

Estimates of Iran's mine stockpiles are in the low thousands, said Salisbury, of the Foreign Policy Research Institute.

Most of its underwater explosives are believed to be older Soviet models. Some of its newer ones may be from China or made domestically.

Senior Indian diplomat discusses global fight

against terrorism with UNGA president

YOSHITA SINGH
■ United Nations

A senior Indian diplomat held a "productive meeting" with UNGA President Annalena Baerbock here and discussed several issues, including reformed multilateralism and global fight against terrorism, the MEA said on Saturday.

Secretary (West) in the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) Ambassador Sibi George's meeting with Baerbock, President of the 80th session of the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) on Friday, came ahead of her visit to India



Secretary (West) Ambassador Sibi George with UN General Assembly President Annalena Baerbock during a meeting in New York

next week. George had a "productive meeting" with the top UN official "on diverse issues, including peace and security, development, reformed multilateralism and the global fight against terrorism," MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said.

Baerbock will undertake official duty travel to New Delhi and Beijing next week, spokesperson for the General Assembly President, La Neice Collins, said. While in India, Baerbock will hold "multiple bilateral meetings with various Government officials," as well as meet with the UN country team in India led by Stefan Priesner. (PTI)

Bill for 3-year pause on H-1B visa introduced in US Congress

SAGAR KULKARNI ■ Washington

A group of Republican lawmakers has introduced a bill in the US Congress for a three-year pause to the H-1B visa programme, contending that it has been hijacked to replace American workers with cheap foreign labour.

Congressman Eli Crane from Arizona introduced the End H-1B Visa Abuse Act of 2026, which was co-sponsored by seven other Republican lawmakers.

The bill proposes reforms to the H-1B programme that include reducing the annual cap from 65,000 to 25,000 with a minimum wage of \$2,00,000 per year and disallowing H-1B visa holders from bringing dependents to the US.

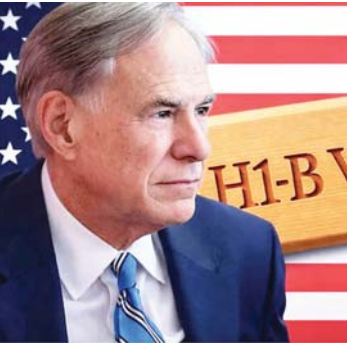
Congressmen Brian Babin, Brandon Gill, Wesley Hunt, Keith Self (all from Texas), Andy Ogles (Tennessee), Paul Gosar (Arizona)

and Tom McClintock (California) have signed on as original cosponsors of the bill.

The H-1B visa programme is used extensively by American technology companies to employ foreign workers. Indian professionals, including technology workers and physicians, form one of the largest groups of H-1B visa holders.

The bill seeks changes to the H-1B programme that include replacing the lottery system with a wage-based selection system; requiring employers to certify they cannot find a qualified worker and have not conducted layoffs; barring H-1B workers from holding multiple jobs; and prohibiting third-party staffing agencies from employing them.

The bill also seeks to prohibit federal agencies from sponsoring or employing nonimmigrant workers; end Optional Practical Training (OPT); and ensure nonimmigrant



visas remain temporary by prohibiting H-1B holders from adjusting status to permanent residency. The changes suggested also require nonimmigrants to depart the United States before changing to another nonimmigrant status.

"The federal Government should work for hardworking citizens, not the profit margins of massive cor-

porations. We owe it to the American people to prevent the broken H-1B system from boxing them out of jobs they are qualified to perform," Crane said.

He said the End H-1B Visa Abuse Act of 2026 would provide greater access to employment, strengthen protocols in the visa process, and prioritise the livelihoods of Americans. "I am proud to cosponsor Rep Eli Crane's efforts to reform and tighten our H-1B visa system, ensuring that our immigration system serves American workers first before foreigners," said Rep Brandon Gill.

Republican Paul Gosar alleged that the H-1B programme has been "hijacked to replace American workers with cheaper foreign labour - plain and simple". The bill, he said, slams the brakes on a system that's rigged against its own people and puts American jobs first again. (PTI)

Iran executes another man

over alleged ties to Mossad

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Dubai

Iran hanged a man Saturday over alleged ties to Israel's Mossad intelligence agency and his participation in anti-Government protests in January.

Erfan Kiani was the latest in a series of executions in Iran following the war and nationwide protests.

The Mizan news agency of Iran's judiciary announced Kiani was convicted of charges including attacks on security forces in the city of Afshar in January.

The agency claimed he was on a "mission for Mossad" without offering evidence. Human rights activists



long have said Iran convicts people in closed-door trials without allowing defendants to properly defend themselves. There recently have been multiple executions of alleged spies, as well as protesters and those affiliated with an Iranian exiled opposition group.

US sanctions

Chinese-based

refinery, 40-ship

company over

Iran oil



Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent

FATIMA HUSSEIN
■ Washington

The Trump administration is placing economic sanctions on a major China-based oil refinery and roughly 40 shipping companies and tankers involved in transporting Iranian oil.

The move, announced and first reported by The Associated Press, makes good on the Trump administration's threat to impose secondary sanctions on companies and countries that do business with Iran.

It's also part of the Republican administration's overall ramped-up campaign to cut off Iran's key source of revenue — its oil exports. Concurrently, the US this month imposed a physical blockade on the Strait of Hormuz, the Persian Gulf waterway that is crucial to global energy supplies.

These sanctions come just a few weeks before President Donald Trump and China's Xi Jinping are due to meet in China. Included in Friday's sanctions is Hengli Petrochemical's facility in the port city of Dalian, which has a processing capacity of roughly 400,000 barrels of crude oil per day, making it one of the biggest independent refineries in China.

The Treasury Department says Hengli has received Iranian crude oil shipments since 2023 and has generated hundreds of millions of dollars in revenue for the Iranian military. Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said that his agency "will continue to constrict the network of vessels, intermediaries and buyers Iran relies on to move its oil to global markets."

Bessent's department sent a letter to financial institutions in China, Hong Kong, the UAE and Oman threatening to levy secondary sanctions for doing business with Iran and accusing those countries of allowing Iranian illicit activities to flow through their financial institutions. (PTI)

Palestinians bury pregnant woman killed in strikes

MELANIE LIDMAN
■ Tel Aviv

Palestinians on Saturday buried a pregnant woman with twins and two of her children who were among at least 13 people killed in Israeli strikes in Gaza.

The toll on Friday included two men who were killed in Gaza City, and eight others killed in the southern city of Khan Younis, according to local hospitals. Officials at Nasser Hospital in Khan Younis said the eight people, including four police officers, were killed after Israel targeted a police vehicle.

Khalid Al-Tanani, of Beit Lahiya, recalled the series of strikes that killed his wife and two of his four children in the northern Gaza Strip. "With



Palestinians mourning over a mother and her children, killed in an Israeli airstrike during their funeral at Al-Shifa Hospital in Gaza City

the first shell, thank God we all survived and were calling out to each other. Then they fired the second, third, and fourth shells one after the other. Their voices fell silent. I went inside and found my wife, Islam Al-Tanani, martyred, and my son, Hamza,

and Naya in her mother's arms. I found them martyred." The children were 4 and 13 years old.

Hamza's 13-year-old twin survived, along with another of the couple's children. Al-Tanani said they had just started talking about gathering

baby items and clothes for the twins. Family members waited over the bodies on Saturday. "You took my soul with you, Hamza, you took me with you and broke me, Hamza," his grandmother sobbed.

Israel's military said several militants had threatened troops in the area and the military targeted them in an airstrike after warning civilians. Al-Tanani said the strikes came without prior notice.

Israel's military said it had targeted two militants who threatened its troops in Gaza City and did not comment on the third strike in Khan Younis that killed eight. While the heaviest fighting has mostly subsided, deadly Israeli strikes have repeatedly disrupted the truce since it took effect on October 10. (AP)

Afghanistan urges US-allied Afghans stranded in Qatar to return home

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Kabul

Afghanistan's foreign ministry says Afghans who helped America's war effort and have been stuck in Qatar in the hope of reaching the United States, can safely return to Afghanistan.

The statement Saturday by foreign ministry spokesman Abdul Qahar Balkhi comes after reports emerged that the Trump administration is in discussions to potentially send 1,100 Afghans who assisted the US during its war in Afghanistan and relatives of US service members to Congo. An organisation called #AfghanEvac that sup-



ports Afghan resettlement efforts said that US officials had informed the group of discussions between the

United States and Congo about taking the Afghan refugees who have been in limbo at Camp As-Sayliyah, a

US base in Doha, for the past year. The State Department said it is working to identify options to "voluntar-

ily" resettle the refugees in a third country, but did not confirm which nations were being discussed. An alternative provided to the refugees was to return to Afghanistan, #AfghanEvac said, where they fear reprisals or even death at the hands of the Taliban, who have been running the country since they seized power in the wake of the chaotic withdrawal of US-led forces in 2021, for working alongside the US during the two-decade war.

Afghanistan's foreign ministry "reiterates that Afghanistan constitutes the shared homeland of all Afghans and it invites all

those concerned, as well as others sharing a similar situation, (to) return to their homeland, whose doors remain open to them, to do so with full confidence & peace of mind," Balkhi wrote in his statement.

He added that "those intending to travel to another country may do so at an appropriate juncture through legal & dignified channels." Afghanistan's foreign ministry "stands ready to engage with all countries," Balkhi said, adding that the foreign ministry "underscores to all sides that there exist no security threats in Afghanistan, & none is compelled to leave the country

on account of security considerations." In a joint statement posted by the #AfghanEvac group on behalf of those in Camp As-Sayliyah, the Afghans said they had received no information from US officials about the talks to potentially relocate them, and had found out about it from the press. The state of limbo they have been living in is taking a severe toll on them, they said.

"Many of us are not well. The uncertainty has been more than some of us can carry. There is deep depression," the group said, adding that some were struggling with their mental health because of the situation.

Gunmen launch attacks across multiple sites in Mali

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Bamako (Mali)

Gunmen attacked several locations in Mali's capital and other cities early on Saturday in a possible coordinated assault, residents and authorities said.

Mali's army said in a statement, "unidentified armed terrorist groups targeted certain locations and barracks in the capital." It added that soldiers were "currently engaged in eliminating the attackers."

Mali has been plagued by insurgencies fought by affiliates of al-Qaida and the Islamic State group, as well as a separatist rebellion in the north. An Associated Press journalist in Bamako

heard sustained heavy weapons and automatic rifle gunfire coming from Modibo Keita International Airport, around 15 kilometres (9 miles) from the city centre, and saw a helicopter over nearby neighbourhoods. The airport is adjacent to an air base used by Mali's air force. A resident living near the airport also reported gunfire and three helicopters patrolling overhead.

Residents in other cities in Mali reported gunfire and blasts on Saturday morning, suggesting a possible coordinated attack by armed groups. Gunmen entered the northeastern city of Kidal, taking control of some neighbourhoods and leading to gunfire exchanges with the



army, a former mayor of Kidal told AP over the phone. He spoke on condition of anonymity out of fear for his safety. The Azawad separatist movement has been fighting for years to create the state of Azawad in northern Mali. They once drove

security forces from the region, before a 2015 peace deal that has since collapsed, paved the way for some ex-rebels to be integrated into the Malian military.

Mohamed Elmaouloud Ramadane, a spokesperson for the Azawad Liberation

Front, said on Facebook that its forces had taken control of several areas of Kidal and Gao, another northeastern city. The AP could not independently verify his claim.

A resident of Gao said gunfire and explosions started in the early hours of Saturday and could still be heard in the late morning.

"The force of the explosions is making the doors and windows of my house shake. I'm scared out of my wits," the resident told AP by phone. He spoke on condition of anonymity because of concerns for his safety. The resident said the gunfire came from the army camp and the airport, which are right next to each other.

A resident of Kati, a town

near Bamako that is home to Mali's main military base, also said he was woken up early in the morning by the sounds of gunfire and explosions. In 2024, an al-Qaida-linked group claimed an attack on Bamako's airport and a military training camp in the capital, killing scores of people. Mali, alongside neighbouring Niger and Burkina Faso, has long been battling armed groups affiliated with al-Qaida and the Islamic State group, a fight that has escalated over the past decade.

Following military coups, the juntas in the three countries have turned from Western allies to Russia for help in combating Islamic militants.

Colombian President meets Venezuela's Delcy for key talks



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Caracas (Venezuela)

Venezuela's acting president, Delcy Rodriguez welcomed Colombian President Gustavo Petro at the Miraflores presidential palace in Caracas, their first meeting since the US military seized former Venezuelan President Nicolas Maduro and his wife from their home in January.

The leaders were expected to discuss an extensive bilateral agenda, including migration, defence, border security, industrial cooperation and trade.

Petro and Rodriguez were expected to meet last month at their shared border, but their respective Governments abruptly cancelled the meeting citing "force majeure," which they did not explain, and simply said it would take place at a later

time. Ahead of Friday's meeting, Petro announced that his delegation, which includes top military and police officials, will tackle border security with Rodriguez. The focus remains on the Catatumbo region, where rival armed groups fight for territorial control and Petro stressed the necessity of "close collaboration on intelligence," warning that without it, "bombs land in the wrong places ... and end up killing civilians."

Colombia-Venezuela ties have long been on the rocks. Petro did not recognise Maduro as Venezuela's legitimate president in the wake of the contested July 2024 elections that triggered protests, which sparked widespread repression. Still, he maintained diplomatic ties with Caracas.

Russian attacks kill 4, wound 21 in Ukraine's Dnipro

ELISE MORTON/ SAMYA KULLAB
■ Kyiv

Russian drone and missile strikes on the Ukrainian city of Dnipro killed at least four people and wounded 21, local authorities said on Saturday.

The bodies of the four were found in the ruins of a house destroyed in the overnight attacks, Dnipropetrovsk regional head Oleksandr Ganzha said.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Saturday that there were "11 people in hospitals in Dnipro after the Russian attack on the city."

"The Russians have been hitting Dnipro and other cities and communities prac-



tically all night," Ganzha wrote on Telegram of the attacks, which caused fires to break out across Dnipro and partially destroyed several apartment buildings, businesses and a private house.

To the southwest, two people were wounded in overnight drone attacks on the Odesa region. Residential buildings, port infrastructure and cars were damaged in the south of the region, regional head Oleh Kiper said on Saturday.

In Russia, a woman was killed, and a man was seriously wounded by a drone strike in the border region of Belgorod, local officials said. Following the overnight attacks, Romania's defence ministry said Saturday that drone fragments were found

in a residential area of the southeastern city of Galati, near the NATO member's border with Ukraine. No casualties were reported. Romania has confirmed drone fragments on its territory on multiple occasions.

The overnight attacks followed a prisoner swap on Friday, in which Russia and Ukraine exchanged 193 service members. Periodic prisoner exchanges have been one of the few positive outcomes of otherwise fruitless monthslong US-brokered negotiations between Moscow and Kyiv.

The talks have delivered no progress on key issues preventing an end to Russia's invasion of its neighbour, now in its fifth year. (AP)

One arrested after deadly Louisiana mall shooting



SARA CLINE
■ Baton Rouge (US)

Louisiana authorities have charged a 17-year-old with murder, and they are searching for another suspect after bystanders were caught in the cross-fire of a shooting at a mall in Baton Rouge on Thursday that killed one teenage girl.

During a news conference, Louisiana Governor vowed to crack down on gang violence that has plagued the Capital city.

The tough-on-crime governor, who said he spoke with FBI Director Kash Patel, promised to utilise state, local and federal resources to address the issue and that consequences "are going to start being felt immediately." Landry said he is asking all levels and sectors of law enforcement — including the National Guard, FBI, US Department of Justice to "prepare for a targeted warrant sweep" for anyone connected to the mall shooting and focus on the "neighbourhoods that these individuals came out of." (AP)

Nine injured in attack by unknown assailants in Pakistan's KPK



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Peshawar

Nine people were injured when unknown armed assailants opened fire on a police vehicle and an ambulance in Pakistan's north-western Khyber Pakhtunkhwa (KPK) province on Saturday, local police said.

The gunmen ambushed the police vehicle in the Rashkai area of Khar tehsil, Bajaur district, injuring five police personnel, according to a spokesperson for the local police.

A rescue ambulance that arrived at the scene to take the injured to hospital also came under fire from the attackers, further escalating the situation, he said.

The ambulance driver and three civilians were also injured in the attack.

Security forces have cordoned off the area and launched a search operation to apprehend those responsible. The incident has triggered panic and fear among residents in Rashkai and the surrounding localities.

Bangladesh issues nationwide security alert over possible militant attacks

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dhaka

Bangladesh Police issued a nationwide security alert over possible militant attacks on key installations, including the parliament complex, officials and media reports said on Saturday.

"The alert has been issued based on intelligence reports," a police headquarters (PHQ) official said, requesting anonymity.

The official described the alert as "urgent and confidential". A PHQ letter warned of possible coordinated attacks targeting the



parliament complex, places of worship, entertainment facilities, and military and police installations, with armouries seen as potential targets, Bengali daily Prothom Alo reported.

The Daily Star and other newspapers said the alert was issued after the recent

arrest of a banned militant outfit operative, Istiak Ahmed Sami alias Abu Bakkar, who was allegedly in contact with two dismissed military personnel. According to reports, the letter also included profiles of two alleged key planners behind the potential attacks, but did not

name any organisation.

It described the suspected perpetrators as "extremely dangerous for the overall security of the country".

Quoting law enforcement officials, news portal *tbsnews.net* said the militant group could adopt multiple methods to carry out attacks. The PHQ directed specialised police units, including the Criminal Investigation Department, Special Branch, and Counter Terrorism and Transnational Crimes unit, to heighten vigilance, while regular police across the country have been asked to remain on high alert.

Another wave of public outcry tests Putin's rule in wartime Russia

DASHA LITVINOVA
■ Moscow

Some Russian influencers recently released public appeals to President Vladimir Putin, criticising his Government and policies, and a number of his loyalists even threatened a revolt — the latest wave of public outcry over the country's strained wartime economy and mounting internet restrictions.

While none of this dissent indicates an imminent threat to Putin's rule, analysts say it presents a new and growing challenge for the Kremlin. "Greater and greater effort needs to be



spent on maintaining the status quo," Mark Galeotti, an expert on Russian politics who heads the Mayak Intelligence consultancy, wrote in an analysis.

A 19-minute video by popular Russian blogger Victoria Bonya has received 31 million views on Instagram since it was pub-

lished 10 days ago. In the video, Bonya, who has 13.6 million followers on the platform, complained to Putin that he was probably misinformed about some things — local authorities' poor handling of recent floods in the southern province of Dagestan, the culling of livestock in Siberia that prompted protests from farmers, crippling internet restrictions and strains on small businesses.

Bonya, a popular Russian TV host who now lives abroad, emphasised that she supports Putin, but she said ordinary Russians and his own officials are too scared to tell him the truth. (AP)

US military strike on alleged drug boat kills 2 in eastern Pacific Ocean

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Washington

The US military said it launched another strike on a boat accused of ferrying drugs in the eastern Pacific Ocean, killing two people.

The Trump administration's campaign of blowing up alleged drug-trafficking vessels in Latin American waters has persisted since early September and killed at least 183 people in total. Other strikes have taken place in the Caribbean Sea.

The military has not provided evidence that any of the vessels were carrying drugs. The attacks began as



the US built up its largest military presence in the region in generations and came months ahead of the raid in January that captured then-Venezuelan President Nicolas Maduro.

He was brought to New York to face drug trafficking charges and has pleaded not guilty. In the latest

attack Friday, US Southern Command repeated previous statements by saying it had targeted the alleged drug traffickers along known smuggling routes. It posted a video on X showing a boat floating in the water before an explosion left it in flames.

President Donald Trump has said the US is in "armed conflict" with cartels in Latin America and has justified the attacks as a necessary escalation to stem the flow of drugs into the United States.

Critics, meanwhile, have questioned the overall legality of the boat strikes.

Australia, New Zealand gather in Turkiye to commemorate WWI battle



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Istanbul

Officials and visitors from Australia, New Zealand and Turkiye gathered in north-west Turkiye on Saturday to commemorate the 111th anniversary of the Battle of Gallipoli. The solemn ceremony began at 5:30 am local time near a beach where the Australian and New Zealand Army Corps, or Anzacs, first landed at Gallipoli at dawn on April 25, 1915.

The hour-long event included mournful hymns, prayers and the laying of wreaths by the participants, which included representatives from many countries around the world.

The Gallipoli campaign, part of a British-led effort to defeat the Ottoman Empire, ultimately failed, resulting in tens of thousands of deaths on both sides during the eight-month conflict. It aimed to secure a naval route from the Mediterranean Sea to Istanbul through the Dardanelles and knock the Ottomans out of the war.

Maharani Gayatri Devi's historic astronomical computer to be auctioned in UK

ADITI KHANNA ■ London

A rare 17th century brass astrolabe, a hand-held astronomical super computer, from Maharani Gayatri Devi of Jaipur's collection is set to fetch millions at a Sotheby's auction in London next week.

The astrolabe, which forms the centrepiece of the auction house's 'Arts of the Islamic World and India' sale on Wednesday, went on display this weekend and is estimated to fetch between 1.5 and 2.5 million pounds.

Dating back to 1612, it is believed to be the largest of its kind and was created by two brothers for a powerful Mughal nobleman in Lahore.

The intricate device was part of the royal collection of

Maharaja Sawai Man Singh II and by descent his wife Gayatri Devi, Rajmata of Jaipur, before passing on into private collection.

"It was commissioned by Aqa Afzal, a really powerful Mughal nobleman who at the time was overseeing the administration of Lahore under Emperor Jahangir, and the object was clearly conceived as something befitting a man of his considerable standing," the auction notes revealed.

"The craftsmanship is quite staggering: 94 cities catalogued inside with their longitudes and latitudes, 38 star pointers connected by floral tracery, five precision-calibrated plates, and degree divisions so fine they are



subdivided down to a third of a degree.

"The inscription describes it as an 'asturlab-e tam', a complete astrolabe referring to the fact that its plates carry a full 90 altitude circles," it added. The astro-

labe is inscribed with the Persian names of the stars and the Sanskrit names in Devanagari script with plates including the locations for Mecca, Bijapur, Ajmer, Kashmir and Lahore.

From a single brass disc,

the ancient device could be used to tell the time, map the stars, calculate the position of the sun, find the direction of Mecca, and navigate. This rare historic nod to astronomy lands on the auction circuit soon after the recent

Artemis II space mission.

These astrolabes are works of artistry as much as instruments of science and many now describe them as olden day smartphones, Sotheby's reflected. According to the official literature referenced, Lahore in the early 17th century was the epicentre of astrolabe-making in the Mughal world. Known as the "Lahore School", the craft was kept within a single family and passed down from father to son across four generations.

The two brothers who made this particular instrument, Qa'im Muhammad and Muhammad Muqim, were among the most celebrated makers the school ever produced. Between them they

made a number of astrolabes that survive, but they only ever worked together on two and the one on display in London now is one of them.

The only other astrolabe they collaborated on, now in the National Museum of Iraq, has a diameter of just 12 centimeters. The one coming up for the auction next week is at a different scale, at 29.5 cm diameter and nearly 50 cm in height.

Other key highlights of the auction include a Mughal painting of Jahangir estimated to fetch between 150,000 and 200,000 pounds and 19th century paintings from India expected to go under the hammer for around 80,000 pounds. (PTI)

BRIEFLY

Olympic medallist Gurbax Singh Grewal dies at 84



Olympic hockey medallist Gurbax Singh Grewal has died following a heart attack in Zirakpur near Chandigarh. He was 84. Grewal, who was part of the Indian team that secured a bronze medal at the 1968 Mexico City Olympics, died on Friday. In a rare distinction, he represented India at the same Olympics alongside his brother Balbir Singh Grewal, marking one of the few instances of siblings featuring together in the national hockey side at the Games. Beyond his playing career, Grewal served as a senior sports officer with Western Railways, where he played a key role in identifying and inducting talent, including several players from Rajasthan, into the Railways hockey setup. After retiring from service in Mumbai, he remained actively involved in the sport's administration, serving as honorary secretary of the Mumbai Hockey Association.

Vanshika, Chirag win 10m air pistol mixed team gold



Vanshika Chaudhary and Chirag Sharma won the 10m air pistol mixed team event at the ISSF Junior World Cup on Saturday, taking India's gold tally to five. With one more day of competitions left, India continued to lead the medal table with five gold, five silver and four bronze. The duo shot 484.3 to shrug off the challenge of Aliaksandra Piatrova and Mikita Daubash (467.6) representing the Individual Neutral Athletes (AIN). The second Indian pair of Mohini Singh and Himanshu Rana tallied 407.4 to clinch bronze in the four-team final. Vanshika and Chirag had earlier shot a combined 582 on Saturday morning at the Olympic International City Shooting range to top the 14-team qualifiers, while Mohini and Himanshu finished third as well with a 568. It was a second gold in the tournament for Vanshika, having earlier won the individual women's 10m air pistol title. It was also a second medal for Chirag, who had earlier won bronze in the junior men's air pistol. The Trap men's and women's competitions also concluded on the day when India had one finalist each. Both Zuhair Khan and Bhavya Tripathi claimed the sixth qualifying spot in their respective qualifiers. While Zuhair shot 115, Bhavya recorded 108 after five rounds.

Millwall fumes after anti-racism booklet shows club's logo

KEN MAGUIRE ■ London

An English soccer team's attempts to shake off its rowdy reputation have been damaged by, of all things, a children's anti-racism booklet.

Millwall was blindsided by the educational pamphlet that featured the southeast London club's badge edited onto an illustration of a Ku Klux Klan robe. The Westminster City Council has since apologised.

A British lawmaker told The Associated Press that the misuse of Millwall branding is an "insult," and the team's leading fan group said it was "outraged" at the portrayal. The second-division club said it is considering legal action because the imagery

creates "a false and damaging image of the club."

The incident comes at a time when Millwall has a strong chance to secure its first-ever promotion to the Premier League. The team was last in the top flight in the 1989-90 season.

Millwall's imageThe checked reputation of fan behavior dates to the days of England's worst episodes of hooliganism in the 1970s and 80s. Hardcore Millwall fans proudly chanted, "No one likes us, we don't care."

But the club has worked to change its perception. The anti-discrimination body, which was created in 1994, was "the first organisation of its kind at an English football club." Millwall also boasts of its working relationship with

Sarah, Harbert eye top honours at TCS World 10K

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Bengaluru

Defending champion Sarah Chelangat and Harbert Kibet aim to make an Ugandan double by winning the women's and men's titles respectively in the 18th edition of the TCS World 10K, a World Athletics Gold Label Road Race, on Sunday.

Sarah was not fully fit when she won the title last year, but she is without any injury this time, looking to better her 2025 winning time of 31 minutes 7 seconds.

"I am feeling fully fit when compared to last year. I won the 2025 title despite a back injury. I recovered fast and am ready to clock a better time to retain my crown," Sarah said

at the customary pre-race press conference.

The 24-year-old Sarah is a double gold medalist in the 2018 Youth Olympics and a 2024 Paris Olympics finalist in the 10,000m.

Kenyan Brenda Jepchirchir and Ethiopian Fantaye Belayneh would be the main challengers to Sarah in the women's race.

Brenda had two fantastic 10K wins earlier this year, including a career-best 29:25 in Valencia in January.

"Yeah, it is (10K) my favourite distance, I am training in Nakuru currently and pleased with my shape coming into the race. After this race, I want to focus on the 5K Road as well. I am not sure if I will run on track over the



summer. However, I might aim for the Commonwealth Games," said Brenda.

The 25-year-old Belayneh, a 5000m World Championships finalist in Tokyo, had been focusing on the half-marathon

for quite some time. She has a 10K personal best of 30 minutes and hopes to run faster if the weather is pleasant on Sunday.

For Kibet, running is a part of his daily life. He had to haul

Bhullar stays in top-5 despite tough third round

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Singapore

Battling tough conditions, India's Gaganjeet Bhullar shot one-over 72 in the third round but remained inside the top-5 at the Singapore Open on Saturday.

Sitting at the top of the leaderboard at the \$2 million International Series event is Korea's Jeongwoo Ham, who, after shooting a 68, has been in the lead across all three days.

In energy-sapping conditions with the formidable Serapong course at the Sentosa Golf Club to boot, Bhullar hung on gamely to shoot 1-over 72 on a moving day in a round that was all about minimising the damage and staying in the mix.

Bhullar currently lies in tied fifth place at 6-under 207, a position he shared



with Thai Jazz Janewattananond (68-66-73) and Pakistan's Ahmad Baig (69-71-67), who, with an eagle and two birdies, was one of the standout performers of the day.

Bhullar encountered a nasty double bogey early on the third hole, which threat-

ened to derail his progress.

"That was unfortunate. I hit a good drive; it was in the first cut, and the lie was fine. I had about 210 yards with a five-iron, but made a poor swing and pulled it left.

"From there, I ended up in a tricky spot near the bunker with no proper

stance for my fourth shot. I managed to get it to about 10 feet but missed the putt," Bhullar said.

He got back a stroke immediately on the fourth and then went on to birdie the ninth as well. He would have hoped to go low in the back nine to make a charge up the leaderboard, but ended up making 8 pars and a bogey after the turn.

Bhullar currently lies seven shots off the pace from leader Ham, yet remains hopeful.

"Overall, with 18 holes to go, I'll keep my head down, get some lunch, and spend some time working on my putting."

Young Pukhraj Singh Gill (71-70-72), playing on an International Series invite, played steady once again.

The Ludhiana player is at level-par and at the Tied-45 place.

Abhay Singh loses to former world No 1 Gawad in Zurich thriller

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

India's Abhay Singh lost to Egyptian former world number 1 and world champion Karim Gawad in a thriller in the men's quarterfinals of the Grasshopper Cup squash, a PSA Gold-level event, in Zurich.

World number 24 Singh recovered from 6-0 down to force the opening game into a tie-break, and went toe-to-toe with world number 4 Gawad in the second, before the Egyptian second seed clinched the contest 12-10, 11-9.

"The pace was really fast. We've only played twice, but I feel like we've played more than that. In Qatar (2025),



he (Singh) beat me in four, and today I got on court and thought I didn't want to lose again," Gawad said in a release. "In best of three with one of the smartest and most talented players on Tour, you can never see what he's thinking with the next shot or the next rally.

"He can come back with crazy points as you saw in the first game when I was 7-0 up and he came back out of nowhere (and) in less than three minutes we were tied," the Egyptian added.

In the tournament earlier, Singh had registered a win over Egyptian world number 13 Aly Abou Eleinen to enter his maiden PSA Gold-level event quarterfinals.

Betis equalises in stoppage time; blow to Madrid's slim title hopes

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Seville

Real Madrid's already slim hopes of winning La Liga were dealt another blow when Real Betis scored a stoppage-time equaliser in a pulsating 1-1 result.

Madrid was left trailing league leader Barcelona by eight points with only five games to play. Barcelona has a game in hand at Getafe on Saturday.

The match started well for visiting Madrid as Vinicius Junior scored for the second time in four days. Betis goalkeeper Alvaro Valles could only parry Federico Valverde's long-range shot, and the Brazilian striker followed



up to slot in the rebound.

Betis, though, was not overawed, and Andriy Lunin, in goal for the injured Thibaut Courtois, made at least two world-class saves

to keep his side in the game.

At the other end, Kylian Mbappe had a goal chalked off for offside, annulling a superb assist from Trent Alexander-Arnold.

Carlos Alcaraz out of French Open due to wrist injury

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Madrid

Carlos Alcaraz won't play for a third successive French Open title due to a right wrist injury.

Alcaraz posted on X on Friday that neither would he appear in the preceding Italian Open in Rome, where he also won last year.

No. 2-ranked Alcaraz was injured at the Barcelona Open this month during his first-round win and withdrew the day after.

He pulled out of this week's Madrid Open and attended the Laureus World Sports Awards in the Spanish capital



on Monday with his wrist immobilised. Alcaraz was named world sportsman of the year at the gala.

Alcaraz confirmed he was

a no-go for Paris after undergoing more medical tests on Friday.

"After the results of the tests carried out today, we have decided that the most prudent thing is to be cautious and not participate in Rome and Roland Garros," he wrote on X. "It's a complicated moment for me, but I'm sure we'll come out stronger from here."

Alcaraz started the year in sensational form, beating Novak Djokovic in the Australian Open final. That made him the youngest man ever to win all four major titles in tennis.

Jim Furyk is returning as US Ryder Cup captain for 2027

DOUG FERGUSON ■ Houston

Jim Furyk is returning as US Ryder Cup captain for the 2027 matches in Ireland as the Americans try to get back on track against a European team that has dominated the last three decades.

The PGA of America on Friday afternoon confirmed an Associated Press report on Furyk's selection, which makes him the fourth US captain to get a second chance dating to 1979, considered the modern era of the Ryder Cup when continental Europe became part of it. The Ryder Cup committee chose Furyk once Tiger Woods removed

himself from competition after his March 27 arrest on suspicion of DUI.

"My passion for the Ryder Cup and dedication to the US team have never been stronger," Furyk said in a statement. "Having previously captained the team, I understand the responsibilities and immense pride that come with this role. I look forward to drawing on that experience while incorporating some new ideas as we prepare for 2027.

"I am committed to putting our players in the best position to succeed as we work to reclaim the cup on European soil."

Furyk was the 2018 captain in Paris, a 17 1/2-10 1/2 win by



Europe. That week was marked by the four US captains' picks going 2-10-0 at Le Golf National and Patrick Reed blaming Jordan Spieth for them not playing together and Furyk for benching

him twice. Furyk led the Americans to victory as Presidents Cup captain in 2024, and he was said to be a reliable voice as an assistant to US captain Keegan Bradley in the last Ryder

Cup. Europe built a record seven-point lead after two days last year at Bethpage Black and held on for its second straight victory under captain Luke Donald, who returns for a third stint in Ireland.

Bradley was a surprise choice for the 2025 matches after the PGA of America waited until the summer of 2024 to see if Woods wanted the job.

This time around, the PGA of America set a soft deadline for the end of March for Woods to decide, and its backup plan was to have a list of candidates for the Ryder Cup committee to consider if Woods chose not to be captain. (AP)

Sooryavanshi's century in vain as SRH beat RR by 5 wickets

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Jaipur

Vaibhav Sooryavanshi's century went in vain as Sunrisers Hyderabad beat Rajasthan Royals by five wickets in their IPL match on Saturday.

Sooryavanshi hammered his second hundred in the IPL — a 37-ball 103 — as Rajasthan Royals put on board a strong 228 for six after they were put in to bat first. Sooryavanshi got plenty of support from Dhruv Jurel, who made a 35-ball 51 and helped the teenager milk 112 runs for the second wicket. In the death overs, Donovan Ferreira (33) played some big shots as RR went past the 200-run mark.

But, SRH chased down the target of 229 with nine balls to spare, with Ishan Kishan top-scoring with a 74 off 31 balls. Abhishek Sharma chipped in with 57 off 29 deliveries as SRH reached 229 for 5 in 18.3 overs.

The 15-year-old once again displayed his rich repertoire of strokes executed with brute force and timing, as Rajasthan played their first match of the season here at the Sawai Mansingh Stadium. He used the long handle to maximum effect to clobber 12 sixes as against five fours in his 37-ball 103.

He brought up his ton with a six off Sakib Hussain (1/62) on his 36th delivery, recording the third fastest century

in the IPL after his own 35-ball hundred last year and Chris Gayle's 30-ball ton for Royal Challengers Bengaluru in April 2013.

Sooryavanshi was off the blocks quickly when he smacked Praful Hinge (1/49) for two sixes on the on side and two down the wicket on the final four balls of the opening over, making a rapid start and didn't look back.

An on-song Sooryavanshi rarely missed a freebie to punish as he garnered runs on both the sides of the wicket while putting on two robust stands at the top to continue RR's charge.

His rapid start helped in adding 40 runs off only 14 balls for the opening wicket while



he consolidated for RR with a 112-run stand for the second wicket with Dhruv Jurel, who chipped in with a 35-ball 51 with eight fours and two sixes.

Sooryavanshi's charge ended immediately after completing his ton when he missed a scoop off Hussain and was pinned in front of the stumps for a leg-before.

Meanwhile, Jurel was also lucky twice as Hussain could not hold on to two tough return chances in his follow-through. Even as SRH managed to get the rid of the dangerous Yashasvi Jaiswal (10) early, they erred when the opportunity was created by Eshan Malinga (2/38) in the fifth over to remove Sooryavanshi. On a length ball, Sooryavanshi

looked to heave it to the on-side but mistimed it. Aniket Reddy covered some distance at deep midwicket on his right but the ball popped out of his hands for a costly drop.

Sooryavanshi went on to complete his fifty off 15 balls with a six in the sixth over from Hussain.

RR's innings was also spruced up by Donovan Ferreira's late 16-ball 33, studded with three sixes and as many fours.

Amid the charge from RR batters, SRH had their regular skipper Pat Cummins returning with impressive numbers of 4-0-27-1 with his solitary wicket being that of his counterpart Riyan Parag (7).

Lungi Ngidi stable after being taken to hospital for head injury

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Delhi Capitals pacer Lungi Ngidi is "stable" and will be "discharged shortly" from a local hospital where he underwent medical examination after he hurt himself during his side's IPL match against Punjab Kings in New Delhi on Saturday.

The South African was taken off the ground in an ambulance after he nastily banged his head into the ground while attempting a catch. He was rushed to Max Hospital, Pusa Road for medical examination.

The IPL said that the 30-year-old right-arm pacer



Lungi Ngidi reacts to an injury during the IPL T20 cricket match between Delhi Capitals and Punjab Kings in New Delhi on Saturday

complained of headache and neck pain, but he is currently "stable".

"Lungi Ngidi of Delhi Capitals hit his head on the ground while attempting to take a catch during

his team's match against Punjab Kings. He was shifted to the hospital in an ambulance as he complained of a headache and neck pain," IPL said on social media platform X.

Punjab Kings script record chase against DC to stay unbeaten

APARAJITA UPADHYAY
■ New Delhi

Punjab Kings rewrote the T20 record books with a breathtaking batting blitz, pulling off the highest-ever successful chase in the format's history by overhauling a daunting 265-run target to outgun Delhi Capitals by six wickets in an IPL run-fest in New Delhi on Saturday.

KL Rahul blended grace with power to script a stroke-filled 152, the third-highest individual IPL score, while Nitish Rana (91) batted with authority as the duo powered hosts Delhi Capitals to a mammoth 264 for 2 after opting to bat first.

Chasing the target, Punjab's dynamic opening



Shreyas Iyer plays a shot during the IPL T20 cricket match between Delhi Capitals and Punjab Kings in New Delhi on Saturday

pair of Prabhsimran Singh (76) and Priyansh Arya (43) came out all guns blazing, adding 126 runs in just 42 balls to lay a formidable foundation for the chase and set the tone for their sixth win of the season.

Skipper Shreyas Iyer, who was dropped by Karun Nair

Rahane, Pant under scrutiny as KKR, LSG fight to stay alive

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lucknow

The adage that a captain is only as good as his team holds a grim truth for Rishabh Pant and Ajinkya Rahane. As Lucknow Super Giants and Kolkata Knight Riders prepare to meet this Sunday in the IPL, both find their leadership under fire, mirroring the fading fortunes of their respective franchises.

KKR's bold call to persist with Rahane at the helm after a woeful IPL 2025 campaign was debated even before the tournament began. The concerns have only deepened as results failed to follow.

It took them seven matches to register their first win — a narrow escape powered by individual brilliance from Rinku Singh rather than a collective resurgence.

It's true that Rahane has

shown a transformative approach with flashes of positive intent — a 67 off 40 against the Mumbai Indians and a brisk 41 off 24 against LSG.

But, in a format on the fast lane, those starts have rarely translated into match-shaping contributions.

At a time when he is nearly 38, persisting with him as a long-term T20 leader looks increasingly out of step with the demands of the format.

Rahane hasn't been helped by a depleted pace attack and a quiet start from spin spearhead Varun Chakravarthi.

Yet, along with head coach Abhishek Nayar, who had an equally uninspiring campaign with UP Warriorz at this seasons' Women's Premier League, Rahane has been found wanting in key areas — team selection and resource utilisation.

Rachin Ravindra continues to warm the bench,



while Finn Allen and Tim Seifert have played musical chairs without clarity.

Rahane's calls at the toss have also been baffling, like choosing to bat on a two-paced, moisture-laden surface against the Gujarat Titans led to a collapse to 32/3, while a similar decision under overcast conditions against the Punjab Kings had them reeling at 25/2 in two overs before rain intervened.

Even as he has adopted a

more aggressive approach with the bat, Rahane's decision-making has lacked conviction.

His recent returns reflect that disconnect, including consecutive ducks, the latest coming when the situation demanded composure against the Rajasthan Royals. Instead, he fell to an expansive stroke, leaving KKR in deeper trouble before Rinku's unbeaten 53 salvaged the chase.

KKR may carry some

momentum into the Ekana Stadium, but with just three points, they now need at least six wins from their remaining seven matches, which seems an improbable task. LSG's campaign too has unravelled. Placed ninth with just two wins at the halfway mark, the Pant-led side is also staring at an early exit, compounded by four straight defeats and a string of questionable on-field decisions from their captain. Pant's struggles have been particularly stark.

Since a match-winning, unbeaten 67 against Sunrisers Hyderabad, he has managed only 72 runs in five innings, including a three-ball duck against Rajasthan Royals. That dismissal summed up his current State.

Chasing 160 on a challenging pitch in Lucknow, Pant walked in after an early run-out and responded recklessly. The situation demanded patience and awareness, and

Pant offered neither.

Against a disciplined Rajasthan attack featuring Jofra Archer and Nandre Burger, preserving wickets in the power play was crucial, but Pant's approach showed little regard for match conditions.

LSG's struggles are compounded by a poor home record.

The Ekana Stadium has hardly been a fortress for the Sanjiv Goenka-owned side: six losses in eight matches here last season, including five in a row, and three consecutive defeats this year already.

Overall, they have just nine wins from 24 games at the venue.

Their batting has lacked consistency, with frequent top-order collapses exposing a misfiring middle order.

Overseas mainstays Nicholas Pooran (73 runs) and Aiden Markram (162 runs) have failed to deliver.



Cricket fans to be allowed to attend PSL final on May 3

RIZWAN ALI ■ Islamabad

Spectators will be allowed to attend the Pakistan Super League final after Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif approved a request from franchise owners, a top official of the Pakistan Cricket Board said on Saturday.

PCB chairman Mohsin Naqvi, who is also interior minister in the Government, wrote on social media that Sharif has "graciously approved" the presence of fans at the May 3 final in Lahore.

Pakistan's biggest sports spectacle of the year started behind closed doors late last month, with fans asked to stay home because of soaring fuel prices related to the Iran war.

Pakistan's Government had urged people to restrict travel and to work from home because of rising fuel prices, and Naqvi had said it wouldn't be right to have 30,000

fans attending cricket matches every day while the Government is asking the public to stay home.

The PCB also reduced the number of PSL venues from six to two as part of austerity measures, but barred spectators from PSL games at Lahore and Karachi.

Naqvi said while Sharif was inclined to permit fans, the prime minister emphasised that austerity measures are currently in place across Pakistan, with efforts underway to minimise fuel consumption.

Peshawar Zalmi, led by Babar Azam, Multan Sultans and three-time champions Islamabad United have already qualified for next week's playoffs ahead of the final.

Defending champions Lahore Qalandars, first-timers Hyderabad Kingmen, and Karachi Kings are still in the running to secure the fourth playoff spot. (AP)

Kohli's mindset sets him apart, says Dahiya after GT loss to RCB

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bengaluru

Gujarat Titans assistant coach Vijay Dahiya heaped rich praise on Virat Kohli, saying the former India captain's relentless drive and hunger to improve continue to set him apart.

Kohli won the Man of the Match award for his match-defining 44-ball 81 in RCB's five-wicket win against GT in the Indian Premier League in Bengaluru on Friday.

Dahiya revealed that Kohli was disappointed despite his strong innings, reflecting the batter's high standards.

"After the game, he was saying he could have converted it into a hundred. That tells you about his mindset," Dahiya said at the post-match press conference.

Highlighting what makes Kohli special, Dahiya pointed to his energy, awareness and ability to control the game. "When you are commanding the situation, you make bowlers bowl where you want. He made the wicket look easy, but it wasn't," Dahiya noted, adding that the knock came against "world-class bowlers". "I think it's



amazing. If you look at his energy... his awareness, his energy and his willingness. "That willingness to do well... his mindset sets him

apart from a lot of other people."

"He is still one of the best runners and keeps pushing youngsters for extra runs.

That willingness to do well — that 'zid (relentless drive)' — is what stands out," Dahiya said.

The GT assistant coach stressed that Kohli's motivation is internal rather than driven by external expectations. "He is not playing to prove a point to anyone. It's about the man in the mirror — trying to be better than yesterday," he explained.

On the match, Dahiya admitted GT may have fallen short by some more runs with the bat, having been restricted to 205 after looking good for more than 220 at

one stage. "We probably could have had a few more runs on the board," he said, while maintaining that the team's aggressive template remains unchanged.

"The approach has been driven by fearless cricket, especially from youngsters," he added.

Dahiya also dismissed suggestions that experienced batters need to take cues from the younger generation. "It's not about young or experienced. Everyone has a role. Experienced players know how to adapt, and they are self-inspired," he said.

Chennai Super Kings look to build momentum; GT seek course correction

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

Riding a resurgent run, Chennai Super Kings will look to consolidate their position in the top half, while Gujarat Titans aim to arrest a slide when the two sides face off in a crucial mid-season IPL clash in Chennai on Sunday.

After a sluggish start, CSK have turned things around, winning three of their last four matches, including a commanding 103-run victory over the Mumbai Indians that was powered by Sanju Samson's second century of the season.

Led by Ruturaj Gaikwad, CSK are placed just outside the top four with six points

and will be keen to avoid further slip-ups as they chase a playoff berth.

At the moment, things are looking up for CSK. Samson's brilliance with the bat, complemented by a clinical bowling effort led by Akeal Hosein, scripted their emphatic win over Mumbai.

Notably, they achieved it without talisman MS Dhoni (calf injury) and local talent Ayush Mhatre (hamstring), who has contributed 201 runs this season.

However, a few concerns remain. While the top order has delivered consistently, the middle order has struggled to show intent and build partnerships. Against Sunrisers Hyderabad, CSK

should have comfortably chased down 130 from 90 balls with eight wickets in hand, but a middle-order collapse derailed the effort.

Gaikwad himself is enduring a lean run, much like Riyan Parag for Rajasthan Royals, while the likes of Sarfaraz Khan, Shivam Dube and Dewald Brevis have failed to convert starts into substantial scores.

The bowling unit, though, has been a major positive. Anshul Kamboj has been rewarded for his consistency with 14 wickets to lead the charts, while Jamie Overton has chipped in with nine, including a four-wicket haul earlier in the tournament. Noor Ahmad has maintained



control, and Hosein showcased his impact with a four-wicket spell in the previous

outing. For the Gujarat Titans, the story has been one of missed opportunities. After a

strong start, they have lost their last two matches — a 99-run defeat to MI and a five-

wicket loss to Royal Challengers Bengaluru on Friday. Despite being level on six points with CSK, GT are languishing in seventh place due to a poor net run rate (-0.790), which has hurt their campaign. Their conservative approach has not always worked in a format that increasingly rewards aggression. The middle order, in particular, has underperformed, often failing to capitalise on strong starts.

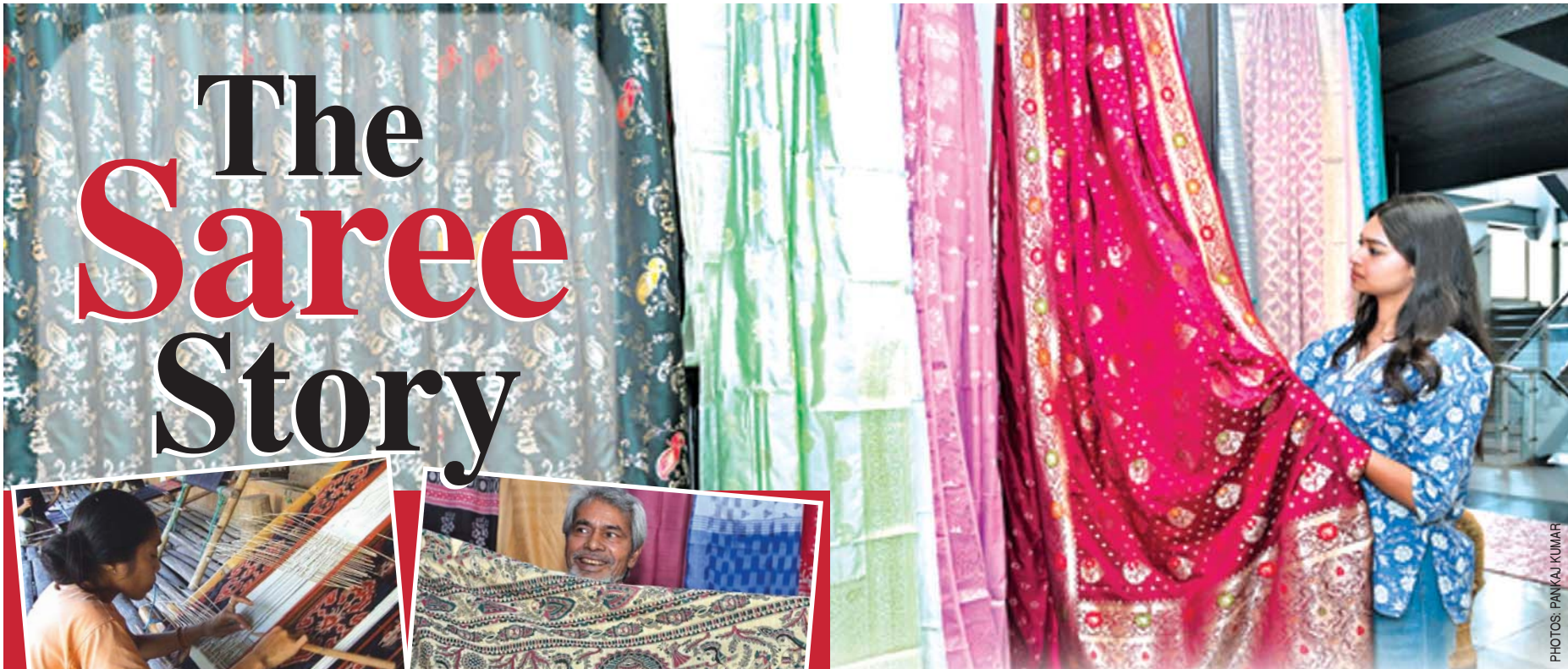
Even in their last outing against RCB, GT looked set for a 230-plus total but failed to accelerate between the 16th and 19th overs, a phase that proved decisive. Sloppy fielding has compounded their problems, including a costly

drop of Virat Kohli.

"We didn't get as many runs as we would have liked. Those three overs were very crucial for us," skipper Shubman Gill said.

GT possess a pace-heavy attack featuring Prasidh Krishna, Kagiso Rabada and Mohammed Siraj, with young Ashok Sharma also contributing with six wickets. However, they have lacked consistency in hitting the right lengths, particularly in the middle overs.

Also, Rashid Khan remains the lone reliable option in the spin department, with Manav Suthar featuring in just one match so far, and Washington Sundar didn't have much impact either.



PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR



SAKSHI PRIYA

For over five thousand years, a simple, unstitched length of fabric has managed to capture the imagination of an entire subcontinent. The saree is an extraordinary garment that completely ignores the fleeting trends of global fashion. Long before power looms dominated the textile industry, early Indian civilisations recognised the sheer practicality of draping. Tracing its roots back to the Indus Valley Civilisation, the saree finds its earliest linguistic connection in the

ancient Sanskrit word 'Sati,' translating directly to a strip of cloth. Our ancestors believed that unstitched fabric possessed a specific spiritual purity, a sacred quality that tailored seams would pierce and ruin.

Over centuries, this strip kept changing shape. Every region grew its own weaving language, turning six yards into a record of monsoon rains, good harvests, and green river valleys. The handloom is where this lives. Thousands of threads lock by hand-moving in a rhythm weavers spend lifetimes learning.

Where do you even begin with all of this? Right now, Handloom Haat on Janpath has an answer. The Special Handloom Expo, "Vastra Sanskrit: The Timeless Weaves," is open — organised by the Development Commissioner of Handlooms. How many weaving traditions

can one country hold? Walk the aisles and start counting.

The saree has always been a conversation — between the weaver and the cloth, between tradition and whoever buys it next. At one stall, Siraj Hinzadi from Mumbai makes that conversation loud. His cotton sarees, priced between ₹3,289 and ₹4,000, carry cheetah prints on soft fabric — bold, city-facing, made for women who want their everyday wear to say something. A few steps away, the conversation gets quieter and older. A master weaver from Gujarat, stands beside his family's Patola sarees. The Patola goes back over 900 years — once worn only by royalty, each saree a geometry problem solved in silk. He explains what that means in practice: every single thread tied with precision before it touches the loom. One mistake and the pattern breaks. There are no mistakes here.

The exhibition reads like a physical map of India written in thread. The heavy gold borders of Kanchivaram silks demand attention from afar, sitting in sharp contrast to the earthy feel of Bhagalpur Tussar silks brought from Bihar. Madhya Pradesh offers a brilliant contrast of its own, hanging the sheer beauty of

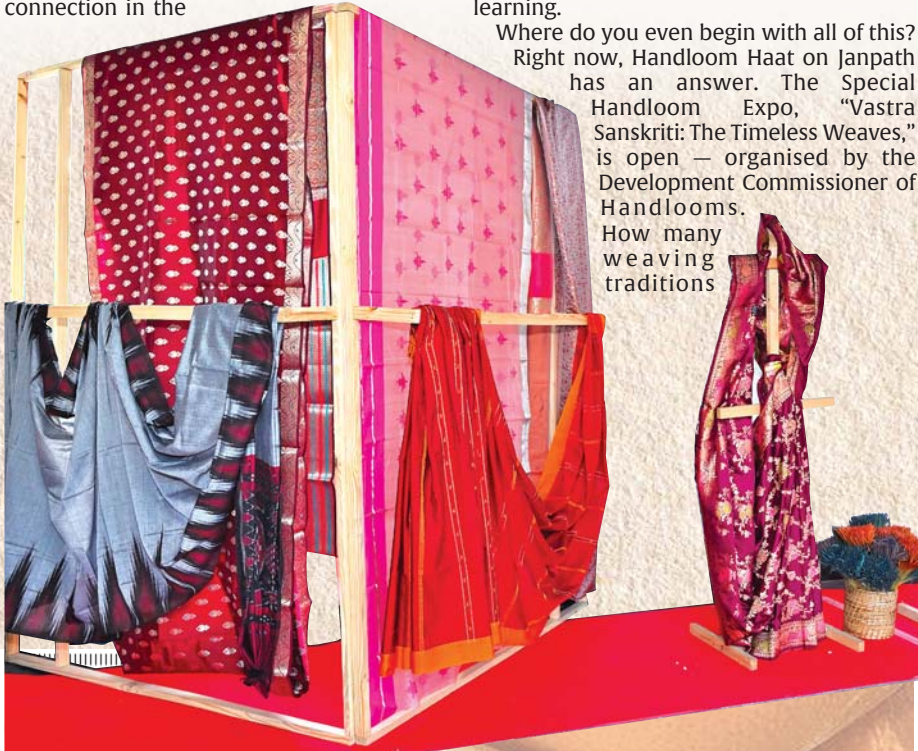
Chanderi weaves right beside bold hand-block painted sarees. West Bengal brings the Shanti Pura saree, proving why elegant simplicity endures. Moving further in, the northern states bring warmth and colour. Bright suit fabrics from Punjab catch the eye, leading toward the patterned stoles carried down from Jammu and Kashmir. Artisans from Uttarakhand have stacked heavy winter shawls and thick traditional Lohi blankets next to classic handloom kurta pajamas.

A drape feels unfinished without jewellery. Amidst a sea of fabric, one Kolkata stall breaks the pattern. Here, steady hands transform everyday copper into bright blue and red Meenakari pieces. The makers shape vivid enamels into sharp lines or fragile motifs like butterfly wings and tiny boats. Chunky peacock brooches sit quietly, catching the dusty afternoon sun. This market keeps village looms running, putting cash directly into the makers' hands. When you leave with a crisp silk and a copper pin, you walk away holding a surviving piece of history. Which six-yard story will you wear next?



AN ARCHIVE YOU CAN WEAR

For five thousand years, the handloom has been India's quietest historian. The expo is where that history becomes something you can touch — six yards at a time. Mathematically perfect Patola silks. Bold, city-facing prints. Hand-painted copper Meenakari pins that take weeks to finish. Every artisan here came directly from their village, which means the money goes back the same way. You are not buying a garment. You are buying the continued existence of the craft.



Hydrate inside, switch to lightweight layers, and seal it all with SPF — summer skin sorted

TEAM VIVA

Summer heat is brutal, and your skin feels the shock instantly. You can never fake a fresh face if you are bone-dry on the inside. The real work actually starts in the kitchen. Stop forcing down tap water. Get a massive jug of ice water, chuck in some bashed-up mint, lime wedges, and cucumber, and honestly, just eat your weight in whatever juicy summer fruit you can get your hands on. Flood your system first, giving your face a fighting chance before you even open your vanity.

Once the inside is sorted you have to look hard at what you are putting on your face, because those thick winter creams will choke your pores the second you step into the heat. Ditch them for something entirely breathable.

Tapping a watery essence or a totally weightless serum into your cheeks feels like splashing cold water on hot stone. These thin, sheer layers act like tiny sponges. They grab whatever moisture is hanging in the thick summer air and trap it right where your face desperately needs it.

The ultimate catch? Every single step you just did is a complete waste of time without sunscreen. Think of SPF as the final seal, or the ultimate bouncer for your face. It stands strict guard, locking all your morning hydration safely inside while bouncing the harsh afternoon rays away. If you skip the basics, the heat will just melt your entire routine by lunchtime. But slather on a decent layer of SPF, and you get to keep that plump, gorgeous glow intact right until the sun finally sets.

BLEND A TALL GLASS OF GREEN JUICE PACKED WITH SPINACH, CUCUMBER, CELERY, AND FRESH GINGER, SLAM IT BACK EVERY SINGLE MORNING



PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR

Where unspoken pain finally blooms

SAKSHI PRIYA

Freedom blooms fiercely in Mari Ito's *Origin of Desire*, a mesmerising solo exhibition at Bikaner House that completely shatters the quiet obedience traditionally expected of botanical painting. Presented by GEEK/ART, the gallery transforms into a breathing nervous system where flora refuses to sit passively on the canvas. Instead, it stares right back at the viewer. Ito operates on a frequency of absolute biological extravagance, layering mineral pigments and sumi ink over delicate Oguniwashi paper. By anchoring ancient Japanese Nihonga craftsmanship within the sun-drenched, dimensional palette of her Barcelona studio, she creates a staggering visual collision. We are met with swelling seed pods, pulsating cellular rhythms, and lush, surreal petals embedded with human faces.

INSIDE FLORECER CONTRA LA BOMBA, SURREAL BLOSSOMS AGGRESSIVELY SWALLOW A RED BOMB UPON THE DELICATE OGUNI WASHI



This body of work stands as a masterpiece in biopoliticalfabulism and a beautiful, unapologetic refusal of historical narratives that often prescribed normative domesticity for women. Ito's anatomies choose to mutate sideways. Her hybrid creatures reclaim the floral and the decorative-tropes long used to soften or minimise feminist art-and arm them with sharp, psychic teeth. Under her brush, the physical form becomes an act of rebellion.

You see this defiance vividly in pieces where the destructive violence implied by a bomb is entirely swallowed and repurposed by explosive, unstoppable floral growth. Artist gives our mundane longings a chaotic, massive voice in *Origin of desire — The "strawberry chocolate love" that I had been holding back for so long popped.* (2024). She takes a passing craving and blows it up into a sweeping, biological event. The titles alone read as diary entries stripped bare. When standing before *How different would my future be if I wanted to go right and I wanted to go left?* (2025), the artwork stops being a quiet question and transforms into a heavy, sprawling vine desperately hunting for room to breathe. Add the magnificent, overwhelming scale of *Joy can last forever, depending on how you perceive it.* (2025), pulling you into a surreal ecosystem where every single petal vibrates with life.

Look closely enough at the scatter of tiny dots and grains across her canvases and something shifts, you realise she has been mapping the weight of human emotion all along, the kind that lives below the surface and rarely gets named. She catches that exact microscopic shudder our cells experience during a flash of pure joy, deep anger, or silent yearning. She borrows from old myths and strange

dreams to build a space where leaves, spirits, and human skin tangle up in one messy, beating rhythm. Ito pushes us to see longing for what it truly is—a fierce, stubborn force that bleeds out and takes root completely out of our hands.

The second you leave, the whole thing hits you. That heavy mix of fear and pain you kept locked down—the things you wanted to speak so badly, but your soul would never allow—finally gets a moment to exhale. This art genuinely understands. It catches that silence, the sharp specific drop of it, the kind that falls the moment someone turns and walks away mid-sentence. By the time you step back outside there is just one question sitting in the middle of your chest, what are you supposed to grow in ground that empty.



Sip inside a fashion sketch



TEAM VIVA

Have you ever wondered what happens when a renowned fashion house translates its signature handbag into a fully curated culinary destination? Born from the classic aesthetic Tory Burch established in New York back in 2004, the brand's latest venture transforms the Roastery Coffee House in Sarvodaya Enclave into The Romy Café. Operating until the 10th of May, this immersive pop-up takes the exquisite detailing of the Romy collection and weaves it directly into the environment. The supple curves and refined structure of the iconic Romy bucket bag are brilliantly reimagined as functional everyday objects where bespoke dessert packaging and custom coffee sleeves become

miniature fashion statements you can actually hold.

The signature shape and structured leather of the Romy bucket bag translate directly into functional everyday items. Bespoke dessert boxes and custom coffee sleeves act as miniature fashion statements guests can hold and carry. Stepping inside reveals a room bathed in soft neutrals and matte finishes mirroring the elegant bags sitting on display. This careful attention to high-end craftsmanship spills right over onto the menu where cafe culture meets couture. Visitors order delicate croissants alongside the standout Romy bucket bag acting as an edible tribute to the handbag itself.

The layout pulls everyone right into the designer's aesthetic. Mirrored installations sit perfectly around the space to capture personal style while live artist's sketch illustrated portraits to take home. It shows exactly how modern luxury is stepping out of the wardrobe and straight into the coffee house elevating a daily ritual into an event meant to be fully tasted and experienced.



ART CORNER

FOR SUGGESTIONS, FEEDBACK OR ADDITIONAL INFORMATION, PLEASE WRITE TO US AT FEATURES@DAILYPIONEER.COM

The Pioneer AGENDA



THE GREAT ASSET SQUEEZE

For decades, India's middle class followed a script—steady jobs, a home, gold as a safety net, and investing to secure the future. In 2026, that script is unravelling. Property prices are racing ahead of incomes, gold is swinging, and markets are falling. Households are being forced to rethink how they define financial security itself

Rethinking wealth in an age of volatility

For decades, the Indian middle class believed in a simple formula: work hard, buy a home, save in gold, and let compounding do the rest. That formula is now cracking. The year 2026 has delivered a blunt message—the old pathways to wealth creation no longer guarantee stability. What looked like a booming market just months ago has turned into a landscape of sharp corrections, unpredictable swings, and shrinking safety nets.

The housing ladder is pulling away

Nowhere is this shift more visible than in India's urban housing markets. In Noida and Gurugram—two bellwether cities for aspirational India—home



AJIT SINHA
Investor and Finance Professional, based in Delhi

prices surged between 10 per cent and 24 per cent in just one year. The Developers have stopped launching projects for middle classes now. For many families, the dream of homeownership has moved from "difficult" to "nearly impossible."

Even the broader market is showing signs of strain. The Nifty Realty Index has fallen sharply this year, reflecting a slowdown in luxury and mid-premium housing demand amid geopolitical tensions and market volatility. Analysts estimate that 25-30 per cent of planned purchases have been deferred, as buyers adopt a wait and watch stance. The traditional belief that "property never fails" is being tested in real time.

Gold: The steady anchor now sways

Gold, long considered India's emotional and financial insurance policy, is no longer the calm harbour it once was. Prices shot up to nearly ₹1,50,000 per 10 grams earlier this year before tumbling unpredictably. For households that relied on gold as a hedge against uncertainty, this volatility has been unsettling. When both real estate and gold—the two pillars of Indian savings—start shaking, the middle class feels the tremors first.

Retirement planning

The biggest rethink is happening in retirement planning. For years, investors were told to chase growth—equities for long-term returns, real estate for appreciation, gold for safety. But in 2026, correlations between asset classes have risen, meaning everything tends to move together. When markets fall, they fall in unison.

This is why a new approach—Laddered Liquidity—is gaining ground. Instead of hunting for the next big winner, households are being advised to secure predictable cash flows first. The logic is simple:

- Over essential monthly expenses through stable, low volatility assets.
- Only then allocate surplus funds to higher risk, higher return opportunities.

In other words, retirement planning is shifting from "maximising returns" to "minimising shocks."

Is diversification dead?

Diversification still matters, but the old version—owning a mix of mutual funds and fixed deposits—is outdated. In 2026, diversification must be functional.

Functional diversification means shifting part of the portfolio toward essential service sectors—water, waste management, energy distribution—industries that remain profitable even in downturns.

The rise of alternative assets

With traditional assets wobbling, investors are exploring new avenues:



VOLATILITY IN GOLD PRICES EXISTS BECAUSE OF GLOBAL UNCERTAINTY, SHOWS INVESTORS DO NOT HAVE CONFIDENCE IN ANY PARTICULAR CURRENCY

NIRMALA SITHARAMAN,
FINANCE MINISTER

THE GOLD RUSH

APRIL 2025 (THE BREAKOUT)
Gold started the period in April 2025 already trading high, around ₹90,000-₹95,000 per 10 grams (24K).

MAY - JULY 2025 (STRONG RALLY):
Despite some minor fluctuations, the trend was consistently upward, moving closer to the ₹1 lakh mark.

AUGUST - SEPTEMBER 2025:
Gold prices breached the historic ₹1 lakh per 10 grams (24K), driven by increased geopolitical volatility.

OCTOBER - DECEMBER 2025:
Fueled by strong demand prices escalated further, with some markets seeing 24K gold trading near ₹1.3 lakh per 10 grams by year-end.

JANUARY - FEBRUARY 2026:
The rally continued into 2026, with gold setting new records. Prices peaked near ₹1.69 lakh per 10 grams on March 2, 2026.

Beyond equities, Gold and real Estate: What does retirement look like



KAPISH SANGA
Investment Banking Analyst

Traditional investment options are under stress. Equity markets are witnessing sharp declines. Real estate prices have surged beyond the reach of many. Gold, long considered a safe haven, has turned erratic, offering neither stability nor clear direction.

Individuals planning for retirement find themselves navigating a landscape marked by uncertainty. The question naturally arises: where should one invest to ensure financial

capital requirements.

The transition from a domestic-only portfolio to a globally diversified one requires a profound behavioral shift. Viewing international exposure as a structural necessity rather than a speculative play is becoming the new standard. In institutional frameworks, a 15-20 per cent allocation to

global assets is a baseline requirement.

This behavioral shift is not merely about asset allocation; it is about redefining risk. For decades, Indian investors have equated familiarity with safety. Investing in a local property or domestic blue-chip stocks felt secure because the assets were visible and the companies were household names. In an interconnected global economy, this familiarity is an illusion of safety. True risk management requires acknowledging that domestic macroeconomic cycles—inflation spikes, currency depreciation, or regulatory shifts—can devastate a concentrated portfolio.

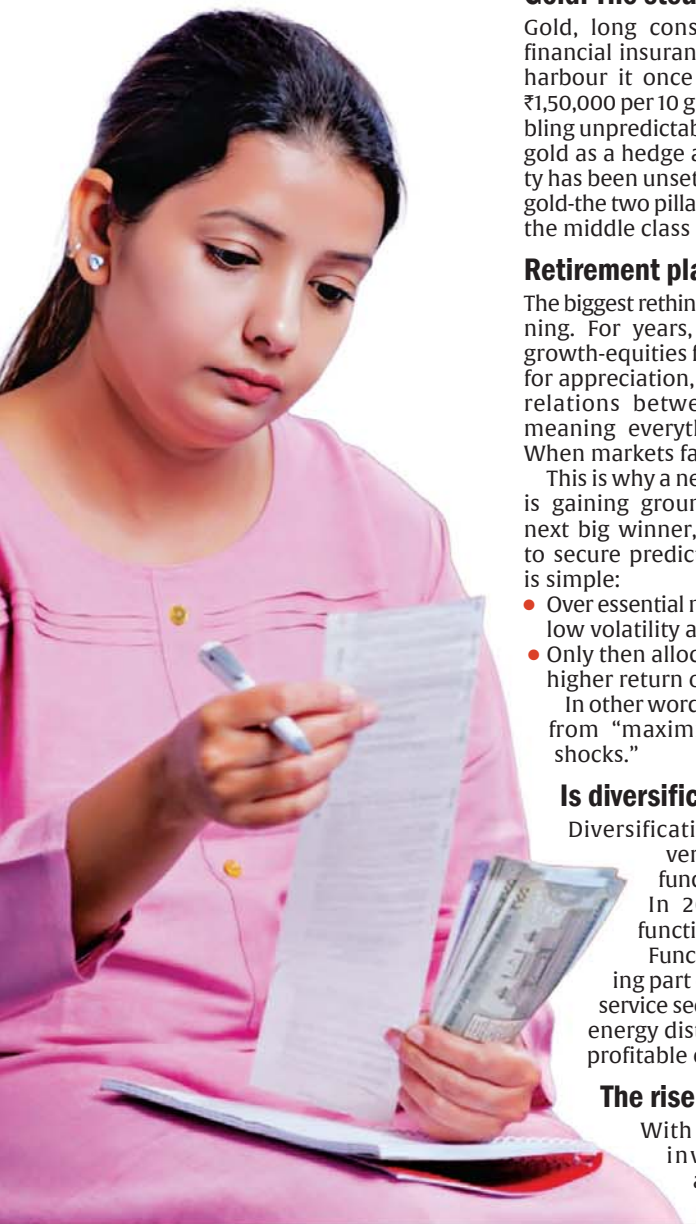
INDIA REPRESENTS APPROXIMATELY 4.5 PER CENT OF THE GLOBAL EQUITY MARKET

By embracing global diversification, investors are not taking on more risk; they are actively mitigating the concentrated risk of their home market. This requires a disciplined, long-term perspective, recognizing that while global markets may experience short-term volatility, their long-term trajectory provides the necessary counterbalance to domestic fluctuations. The goal is not to time the market, but to build a portfolio robust enough to withstand it.

The era of relying solely on domestic equities, physical gold, and local real estate is over. The macroeconomic environment has changed, and retirement planning must change with it. The cost of ignoring global diversification is no longer just a missed opportunity—it is the direct erosion of financial security in old age.

Recognising this shift is the very first step toward building a portfolio capable of withstanding the next cycle of domestic volatility.

The writer is an Investment Banking Analyst at Barco and a Cornell University alumnus



Where is gold headed...
Following the March high, gold saw a mild correction, with 24K prices trading around ₹1.5 lakh to ₹1.55 lakh per 10 grams in mid-to-late April 2026, supported by peak seasonal demand (Akshaya Tritiya) and continued safe-haven buying, though lower than the peak.

Residential prices have experienced unprecedented appreciation. Luxury properties are coming up, while affordable housing supply has significantly contracted. This rapid escalation, outpacing salary growth, has shifted the market from an 'affordability' model to an 'aspiration' model, forcing first-time buyers out of the market.



“DIPLOMACY IS THE ART OF TELLING
SOMEBODY TO GO TO HELL IN SUCH A
WAY THAT THEY LOOK FORWARD TO
THE TRIP”

— WINSTON CHURCHILL

The bloom of the tulip diplomacy

From spice-laden ships of the 17th century to modern collaborations in climate resilience and technology, the journey of Indo-Dutch relations reflects continuity amid change, writes **GYANESHWAR DAYAL**



Did you know there is a tulip variety called "Aishwarya"? That's right, tulips are often named after celebrities, and they have an Indian name too! In 2005, the Dutch government named the red tulip variety after actress Aishwarya Rai at the renowned Keukenhof Gardens, the world's largest tulip garden. And it was not just a random decision. It is testimony to the importance the Netherlands attached to India. The relations between the two countries have been cordial and based on mutual respect and cooperation.

Think of tulips, and you cannot help thinking about the Netherlands — the land of tulips. Tulips are more than just flowers in the Netherlands—they are a national symbol, tied to history, economy, and identity. The Netherlands is home to Tulips and has several varieties that make it the tulip capital of the world. In a way, the Netherlands' economy is linked with Tulips. But the Netherlands is much more than Tulips alone. And it has a strong connection to India, which began way back in 1605 when the Dutch landed on Indian shores for Indian spices. Unlike the British, French and Portuguese, the Dutch were essentially traders and remained that way.

Since then, it has been a long, uninterrupted cordial relationship that both countries value and nurture. Dutch presence in India started with commerce, survived colonial competition, and has matured into a multidimensional partnership, but has remained low-key, though it spans diplomacy, technology, water management, and culture. Their settlements in places like Cochin, Pulicat, and Nagapattinam were designed to secure spices, textiles, and maritime routes. However, the Dutch influence in India, though significant in trade, remained relatively limited in political scope.

After India's independence in 1947, relations with the Netherlands entered a more formal diplomatic phase. The initial decades were cautious, shaped by Cold War alignments and differing global priorities. However, unlike more ideologically charged bilateral relationships, Indo-Dutch ties evolved without major friction.

The Netherlands has emerged as a dependable

partner. Dutch expertise in agriculture, water management, and infrastructure found resonance in India's nation-building efforts. Over time, this cooperation transitioned from aid to partnership—a subtle but important shift reflecting India's growing economic stature.

Today, the Netherlands is one of India's largest trading partners within the European Union and a major source of foreign direct investment. The economic relationship is no longer confined to traditional sectors. It now includes clean energy and climate resilience, water technology and flood management, agriculture innovation and food processing, and logistics and port development.

The strategic importance of the Port of Rotterdam-Europe's largest port — has positioned the Netherlands as a gateway for Indian goods entering the European market. Conversely, Dutch companies see India as a dynamic hub for manufacturing and innovation. Yet another interest-

ing and important aspect of Indo-Dutch relations is water management. With sea levels rising and erratic monsoons becoming the norm, India needs technology and expertise to safeguard its cities and coastal areas from storms and rising sea levels. The Netherlands too has many of its areas below sea level. Over the years, it has developed expertise in managing water flows and finding solutions to this problem, and the best part is that it is sharing it with India.

Soft Power, Strong Bonds

The Netherlands has a strong presence in New Delhi. It is always buzzing with activity, cultural and social, offering a treat to connoisseurs. The Netherlands embassy has been regularly organising cultural exchanges, academic collaborations, and people-to-people interactions.

Recently, the Embassy of the Kingdom of the Netherlands in New Delhi hosted King's Day, celebrating the 59th birthday of King Willem-Alexander. Held at the Netherlands Residence, it hosted Union Minister of State (Independent Charge) Jitendra Singh as the chief guest, welcomed by Ambassador Marisa Gerards and Peter Knoop. The venue itself became a canvas of Dutch identity, echoing Van Gogh's Starry Night and Sunflowers. The event was not just a national celebration, but a tribute to the spirit of inclusivity, innovation, and community. It mirrored the trajectory of Indo-Dutch relations—diverse, collaborative, and forward-looking. It is a partnership built not on spectacle, but on substance—where shared challenges are met with shared solutions.

WHEN PARTITION GAVE WAY TO TULIPS...

The story of Dutch ambassador's residence that spans two nations

The residence of the Dutch Ambassador is a prime location in Lutyen's Delhi, the European-style white building with sprawling lawns is indeed a property worth having. Besides its lawns blooming with Tulips in the winter season to maintained gardens, to the European architecture, the residence has a history beneath that shaped the destiny of the sub-continent. Long before it became the residence of the Dutch Ambassador, its nameplate read "Jinnah House" and belonged to Muhammad Ali Jinnah, the founder of Pakistan.

The house belongs to the British Raj era - wide avenues, deep verandas, and architecture designed for both prestige and climate. These homes often changed hands in the turbulent years surrounding Partition in 1947. Jinnah had his residence in Mumbai, but owned this property, which, after Partition, fell into a category of "evacuee property," eventually reassigned, and transferred by the Indian government. Subsequently, the Netherlands acquired the residence and it was made its ambassador's official residence. So here is a house once tied to the subcontinent's most consequential political rupture that found a new identity as a site of international engagement.

Today, the residence stands not as a relic of division, but as a functioning space of diplomacy—quietly hosting dialogues, receptions, and cultural exchanges. It is indeed ironic as it has a certain poetic symmetry in its evolution. A house once linked—directly or indirectly—to the politics of separation now hosts celebrations of connection. Where history once drew borders, diplomacy now builds bridges, though it still preserves the spot where the partition was contemplated. Events at the residence, whether it is



King's Day or a tulip showcase, carry this layered meaning. They are reminders that places, like nations, are not frozen in time. They change hands, change meanings, and sometimes, quietly, change purpose. What was once a place where partition was discussed has now become a place of shared presence. And in that transformation lies the quiet strength of diplomacy—not in rewriting history, but in giving it new meaning.

A personal journey through Iran's past



Iran is a nation where the strength of its people continues to endure despite the weight of history and circumstances

My relationship with Iran is not political; it is personal and layered across generations. My family's connection with Iran goes back to 1907. My grandfather was a trader who lived near Rawalpindi in undivided India. Long before Partition reshaped the subcontinent, he had already begun travelling to Iran for business. Like my father, I too was born in Iran. As Sikhs, we never faced any issues either before or after the Islamic Revolution. On the contrary, Sikhs and Indians have always been respected at every level of society. The Sikh community has preserved its identity and way of life, even after such a major shift in the country.

My childhood in Iran remains the most beautiful phase of my life. Tehran, to me, was a city full of life and calm at the same time. Snow-covered mountains stood quietly in the distance, while the city moved with warmth below. I remember markets filled with colour, the smell of fresh bread, and long walks with my family. I grew up understanding Persian very well, which made every interaction deeper and more personal. There was a quiet sense of belonging.

Those were simple and happy years. As a child, I did not see politics. I saw people, kindness, and a life that felt complete.

Then came a turning point. The Islamic Revolution reshaped Iran in a powerful way. The country moved from an ultra-westernised society to a deeply Islamic system. It was not just a change of leadership; it was a shift in identity.

Soon after, the seizure of the United States embassy became a defining moment. It was dramatic and intense. Young revolutionaries took control and held American diplomats hostage for over a year. The world watched closely. The new regime came to be seen as undiplomatic. That moment changed Iran's global image and marked the beginning of long-standing tension with the United States.

Before stability could return, the country was pushed into war. The Iran-Iraq war lasted eight long years. It was a painful phase in Iran's history. For a newly formed regime and an isolated nation, it was a severe test. Resources were stretched. Lives were lost. Fear became part of daily life. The country was still finding its footing while fighting for survival. Isolation followed. Iran found itself cut off from much of the world. This shaped not just its politics but also its economy. As I grew into my teenage years, I began to see Iran more clearly. The warmth of the people remained unchanged.

Imagine a Sikh boy wearing a turban and keeping a beard, at times resembling the Islamic clergy, yet dressed in denims and a T-shirt. In many places, this could create distance. But in Iran, it did not. I never faced discomfort or strange reactions. Instead, there was respectful curiosity. People would ask simple questions, like why my turban was not white or black, but in bright colours. These moments reflected a society that was respectful and open in its own way.

At the same time, I could sense the pressure of a system under strain. Sanctions became a part of everyday life. They were not distant policies; they were real. Prices rose. Access became limited. The burden was carried by ordinary citizens.

And yet, even in such conditions, Iran continued to move forward. There has been steady progress in infrastructure. Rural areas saw roads, electricity, and basic services reach far corners. Iran also reflects strong on-ground systems, such as road safety standards and organised facilities. In many ways, development in several areas has been faster than during the Shah's period. Healthcare has been robust and of a high standard. It has reached deep into



MANJOT'S BHASIN
An Entrepreneur who lived in Iran.
He writes on his lived experience

society and improved access. But this strength has been affected by sanctions. Shortage of critical medicines and rising costs have created serious challenges. Even a strong system struggles when access to essential supplies is restricted.

When I moved to India for higher education, it was a shift in experience. It made me realise how differently systems function across countries. It also made me reflect on how well certain aspects of life in Iran were managed despite challenges.

Education became a strong pillar of growth. The emphasis on women's education has been remarkable. Iranian women today have one of the highest literacy rates in the world. Their role is visible across different walks of life. They study, they work, and they contribute actively to society.

These are achievements that deserve recognition. But this is where the contrast becomes difficult to ignore.

Iran is one of the top oil-producing countries in the world. A nation with such wealth should provide strong economic stability. Yet, a large part of the population lives under financial pressure. The economy does not reflect the country's natural strength.

This raises questions about direction. Recent tensions involving the United States have added further pressure. Any assault that leads to destruction cannot be justified. It

SANCTIONS BECAME A PART OF EVERYDAY LIFE. THEY WERE NOT DISTANT POLICIES; THEY WERE REAL

increases the burden on ordinary people. At the same time, Iran's resilience against the United States is undeniable. Standing firm against a global superpower requires strength. This resistance is commendable.

But it also reveals an imbalance. It shows the level of weaponisation and strategic capability that Iran has built. At the same time, it highlights the gap in economic progress. A significant focus has remained on geopolitics. Issues related to Israel, nuclear capability, and strategic positioning continue to dominate. While national security is important, this focus often comes at the cost of everyday development. The result is visible. A country rich in resources continues to struggle economically. A capable population operates within limits. The youth are skilled and aware, yet constrained.

When compared to other countries in the region, the difference becomes clear. Nations with fewer advantages have built strong economies and modern systems. They have become global destinations. In many ways, Iran had a stronger foundation. Its culture, geography, and human capital gave it a natural advantage. It had the potential to lead the region and create a global impact. That potential still exists, but it remains underused. Today, my work takes me to the United States. I see a system that offers structure and opportunity. And every time I travel there, I find myself thinking of Iran, not in comparison alone, but in possibility. Because I have seen Iran beyond headlines, I have lived its warmth. The most beautiful years of my life were spent there. And that is what makes this reflection emotional. Because Iran is not lacking in strength, it is a country that has everything. And its people deserve a life that reflects that truth.

Manjot Singh Bhasin is an Indian citizen who spent most of his life in Iran before settling in Delhi. He is an entrepreneur. His writing comes from lived experience and reflects on culture, identity and change

Rethinking Wealth...

Fractional Ownership of Physical Assets:

Warehouses, data centres, and commercial logistics hubs—once accessible only to large investors—are now available in fractional formats. This allows individuals to gain real estate exposure even with smaller amounts. Listed REITs are available to invest in commercial projects.

Private Credit Funds: As banks tighten lending,

private credit funds have stepped in, offering loans to mid-sized companies. These instruments often yield 2-3% more than standard savings products, with structured safeguards. They are not risk-free, but they offer a middle path between equity volatility and low yield deposits.

The Mindset Shift

Perhaps the most profound change is psychological. Wealth creation in 2026 is less about

picking the right asset and more about thinking differently.

Focus on goals, not greed: If your retirement plan needs a 7% return, why gamble for 15% and risk losing capital?

Your skills are your real safety net: In an age of automation and economic churn, the only asset that cannot crash is your ability to earn. Retirement will increasingly mean part-time consulting, freelancing, or advisory work.

Stay calm, stay consistent: Panic selling is rising as markets swing. The strongest defence is a disciplined plan that runs on schedule—not emotion.

The Quiet Opportunity

The year 2026 has exposed a difficult reality: easy, predictable financial growth is over. The "Great Asset Squeeze" has made wealth harder to build and easier to lose.

Financial freedom at retirement may feel

further away, but it is still achievable—not through chasing extraordinary returns, but through building ordinary stability.

In an age of volatility, the new blueprint for wealth is simple: Aim not for more, but for enough.

The writer is an active investor and finance professional, based in Delhi. He is skilled in portfolio management, Investment Banking and Financial Planning

FROM AGENDA COVER

“OUR BODIES ARE OUR GARDENS;
OUR WILLS ARE OUR GARDENERS”
— WILLIAM SHAKESPEARE

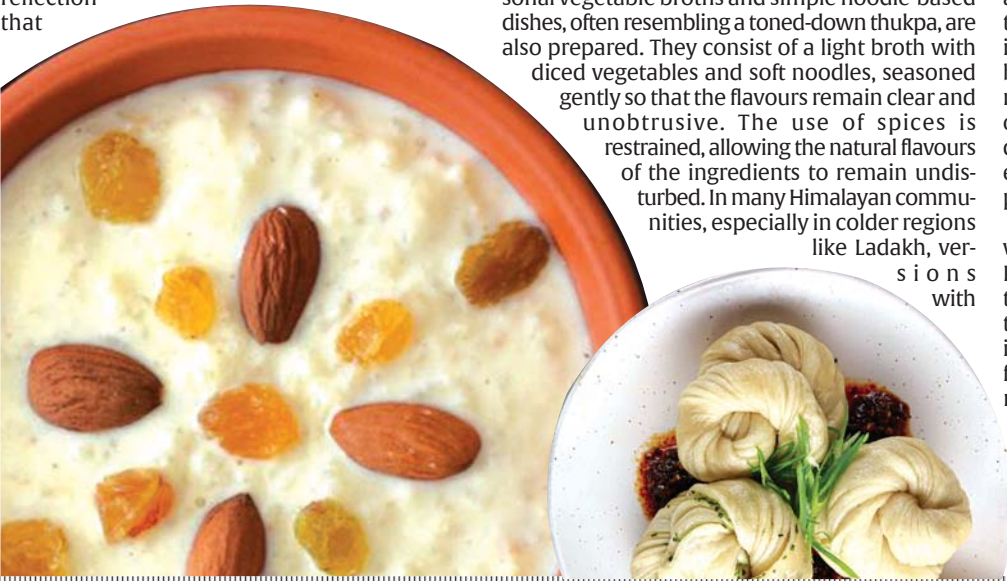
Buddha Purnima: The cuisine of compassion, restraint, and shared nourishment



ANIL
RAJPUT

Buddha Purnima, commemorating the birth, enlightenment, and Mahaparinirvana of Gautama Buddha, is observed across India with a quiet reverence that reflects the spirit of his teachings. Unlike many festive occasions marked by grandeur and indulgence, this day is distinguished by simplicity, restraint, and a conscious return to purity, in thought as much as in food. The cuisine associated with Buddha Purnima is therefore not merely about nourishment, but about embodying the ideals of moderation, compassion, and mindfulness. From monasteries in Bodh Gaya to households across diverse regions, the day is marked by offerings and meals that are sattvic, unpretentious, and deeply symbolic. In its culinary expression, Buddha Purnima becomes a lived reminder that sustenance, when approached with awareness, can itself be an act of devotion.

Gautama Buddha's life gives this observance its deepest meaning. Born as Siddhartha in Lumbini and raised amid princely comfort, he was nevertheless moved by the realities of suffering, illness, old age, and death. Renouncing privilege in search of truth, he passed through years of severe austerity before realising that neither indulgence nor extreme self denial could lead to lasting wisdom. That insight guided him towards the Middle Path, and under the Bodhi tree at Bodh Gaya he attained enlightenment. Over time, the day commemorating this sacred journey came to be observed through rituals and customs that reflect the essence of his teachings. Devotees visit monasteries, recite scriptures, perform acts of dana, and offer flowers, incense, and lamps before his images. Monasteries and temples reverberate with chants and hymns, lamps are lit by devotees often dressed in white to symbolise the purity of their purpose, monks are offered food and alms, the needy are fed and offered refreshments, and animals are treated with compassion in recognition of the equality of creation. The mood is one of humility, restraint, and generosity. It is within this framework of reflection that



the cuisine of Buddha Purnima emerges, not as a celebration of abundance, but as an expression of balance, purity, and simple sustenance.

In the sacred geography stretching from Bodh Gaya to Kushinagar, the cuisine of Buddha Purnima finds its most direct and symbolic expression. At the heart of this culinary tradition lies kheer, associated with Sujata, a village woman who encountered Gautama Buddha during his period of severe austerities near Bodh Gaya. Seeing his weakened state, she offered him a bowl of milk-rice, prepared as a simple, nourishing repast. This act is regarded as deeply significant, for it marked a turning point, prompting the Buddha to move away from extreme asceticism and embrace the Middle Path. Prepared by slowly simmering rice in milk until the grains soften and the mixture thickens into a creamy consistency, it is then lightly sweetened with sugar or jaggery, with cardamom added for a gentle aroma. The dish is cooked over a low flame with continuous stirring, allowing the flavours to develop gradually without becoming heavy or overly rich. Alongside it, dishes such as lapsi, made from broken wheat and jaggery, offer a coarse, grounding texture, emphasizing substance over refinement. Boiled gram, soaked and cooked until tender, is shared as prasad. Khichdi, a soft blend of rice and lentils, further reflects this ethos, cooked with minimal seasoning to ensure digestibility and balance. Seasonal vegetables, lightly steamed or boiled, and fresh fruits consumed in their natural form complete the meal. Taken together, these preparations form a culinary language that is quiet yet profound, where food aligns with a discipline of moderation and mindful living.

In the Himalayan regions, where Buddhist monastic traditions continue to shape daily life, the cuisine of Buddha Purnima takes on a distinctly functional and climate-responsive character. In places like Ladakh, the Buddhist pockets of Himachal Pradesh and Sikkim, food is closely tied to sustenance in a demanding environment, and this practicality aligns naturally with the philosophical emphasis of the day. The preparations here are simple, but carry a quiet robustness, shaped by both geography and monastic discipline. Barley, a staple grain of the region, forms the basis of many preparations. Tsampa, made from roasted barley flour, is consumed in its most basic form, mixed with water (or sometimes tea) and kneaded into a soft dough-like consistency. It may be shaped into small portions and eaten directly. Light seasonal vegetable broths and simple noodle-based dishes, often resembling a toned-down thukpa, are also prepared. They consist of a light broth with diced vegetables and soft noodles, seasoned gently so that the flavours remain clear and unobtrusive. The use of spices is restrained, allowing the natural flavours of the ingredients to remain undisturbed. In many Himalayan communities, especially in colder regions like Ladakh, versions with

meat, such as chicken, mutton, or yak, are quite common, as they provide greater warmth and sustenance. However, on occasions like Buddha Purnima, the preparation is typically kept vegetarian, aligning with the day's emphasis on compassion, restraint, and sattvic simplicity.

The wider food culture of these regions also includes preparations such as tingmo, the soft steamed bread that pairs easily with simple vegetables and soups. In some areas, momos may also be prepared, especially vegetable filled versions whose communal preparation carries its own sense of togetherness. None of these foods are considered specific to the festival but assume a special place during this austere period. Their warmth suits the climate, their simplicity suits the occasion, and their textures suit a mode of eating that is meant to sustain rather than stimulate. Fresh fruit also has a meaningful place, both as an offering and as food that preserves purity in its simplest form. Taken together, these foods form a culinary language of quiet strength. They do not seek to impress. They seek to align eating with mindfulness.

Western India presents a different but equally revealing expression. In Maharashtra and Gujarat, the cuisine associated with Buddha Purnima is less tied to a distinct Buddhist ceremonial tradition and more to an already familiar culture of dietary restraint. In these regions, the day resonates easily with the logic of light fasting foods and measured eating. That is why dishes such as sabudana khichdi are suitable on this occasion. Soft tapioca pearls, peanuts, and mild seasoning create a preparation that is both filling and gentle. It gives energy without heaviness and satisfaction without indulgence. Similarly, simple boiled potatoes, lightly roasted potato preparations, and small peanut based dishes can form part of the meal because they preserve the principle of control rather than abundance. Simple preparations like batata bhaji (lightly sauteed potatoes) and shengdana chi amti (a mild peanut-based curry) often find a place in meals. Batata bhaji is made by boiling or parboiling potatoes, then lightly sauteing them with minimal seasoning like cumin and a touch of turmeric, taking care to keep the flavours gentle and unobtrusive. Shengdana-based preparations, whether as a thin curry or a dry paste, use ground roasted peanuts mixed with water and mild spices, cooked briefly to form a light, nutty accompaniment that is both sustaining and easy to digest. Rich in protein, healthy fats, and antioxidants, shengdana is known to support heart health by managing cholesterol. Together, these dishes reflect a balance of simplicity and nourishment, offering substance without departing from the day's ethos of moderation. These foods are not elaborate, but are thoughtfully composed to provide energy without heaviness.

What matters in this western expression is not whether a dish is uniquely marked as Buddha Purnima food, but whether it fits the contemplative discipline of the day. The cuisine here tends toward the practical. Even when there is variety, it remains within an ambit of simplicity. Seasonal fresh fruit, light yogurt based accompaniments, or mild preparations made from ingredients already familiar to fasting traditions are also used. The result is a table that neither imitates the symbolic centre of Bodh Gaya nor the monastic austerity of the Himalayas. Instead, it reveals how Buddha Purnima can enter an existing regional habit of disciplined eating and give it a more



reflective and ethical emphasis. In eastern India, particularly in West Bengal and Odisha, the cuisine of Buddha Purnima carries a quieter refinement. The underlying values remain the same, but the region's long familiarity with rice based sweets, devotional offerings, and temple linked food traditions gives the observance a distinct tone. Here, the milk and rice grammar associated with the Buddha's story naturally takes the form of payesh, the eastern variation of kheer. Delicately sweetened and often perfumed with cardamom or bay leaf, payesh carries the same symbolic gentleness, but with a regional flavour of its own. Alongside it, chuda or flattened rice preparations fit the day beautifully because they are light, easy to prepare, and suitable for both offering and consumption.

In parts of West Bengal, mishti chaler payesh, made from aromatic small-grain rice, is sometimes preferred. Doodh-chire, flattened rice soaked in milk with a hint of jaggery, is also served as a softer, cooling preparation suited to the season. In Odisha, temple-influenced traditions occasionally include very simple forms of manda pitha or kakara pitha, prepared without elaborate fillings or richness, keeping them aligned with the day's sattvic discipline. Another quiet inclusion is gopal ballabh style offerings, a combination of fruits, lightly sweetened dairy, and simple grains thus reflecting the broader temple culture of offering unadorned, balanced foods.

Southern India offers another important variation. In Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh, and neighbouring regions, the cuisine associated with Buddha Purnima aligns closely with established traditions of sattvic and temple style cooking. The festival may not occupy the same historical place in the south that it does in the Buddhist heartland, yet its observance fits comfortably within culinary habits that already honour purity, digestibility, and balance. Pongal, the soft combination of rice and lentils, is especially apt in this context. It is wholesome, satisfying, and gentle on the body. Around it, one may find lightly cooked vegetable dishes, modest lentil accompaniments, and simple rice preparations seasoned just enough to preserve flavour without pushing toward heaviness. Coconut may appear, but sparingly, as part of the region's natural culinary vocabulary rather than as ornament. The meal supports prayer, calm, and continuity. In that sense,

Buddha Purnima in the south is not marked by culinary exceptions, but by a deepened return to principles that temple and household kitchens have long known well. Across all these regions, beverages continue the same logic as the food. Since Buddha Purnima falls in the heat of late spring, drinks tend to be cooling, simple, and restorative. In the north, sattv based drinks fit naturally into the season, offering steadiness and nourishment without weight. Elsewhere, one may find chaas, mild lemon based refreshments, and lightly sweetened summer drinks that calm the body rather than excite it. Plain water distributed to pilgrims and visitors may appear simple, yet on a day defined by dana and compassion it carries its own significance.

When one looks at Buddha Purnima region by region, its cuisine reveals unity not through uniformity, but through moral continuity. The Gangetic heartland gives the day its most direct symbolic food memory in kheer and its ethic of nourishing balance. The Himalayan belt expresses Buddhist restraint through tsampa, broths, and warming, practical foods such as thukpa and tingmo. Western India brings the discipline of moderated eating into conversation with the observance through dishes like sabudana khichdi and light potato preparations. Eastern India refines simplicity into offering through payesh, chuda, and delicately handled rice and vegetable foods. Southern India absorbs the day into long standing traditions of sattvic harmony through pongal, gentle vegetables, and restrained lentil based preparations. The dishes vary, but the principle remains uniform.

In an age when celebration is too often measured by display, Buddha Purnima offers a different civilisational lesson. It reminds us that a meal need not be excessive to be meaningful, and that regional culinary traditions can carry civilisational memory as powerfully as rituals or texts. To preserve such food cultures is not merely to preserve inherited recipes. It is to carry forward a way of thinking rooted in the philosophical depth and moral clarity of the Buddha's teachings. This is a legacy that we, as inheritors of a living civilisation, are duty bound to honour and transmit to future generations. Across regions, mindful eating is not a denial of life, but an affirmation of moderation, balance, and inner discipline. In that balance, the kitchen continues the work of memory, devotion, and civilisational continuity.

(The writer is Secretary, Cuisine India Society)

Learning to let go: The forgotten side of mental well-being

What truly determines the quality of a human life-external success or internal emotional balance?

PRATIKSHA VATS

In today's fast-moving world, people are constantly expected to function, perform, and adapt. Yet very little attention is given to one of the most basic psychological needs: the need to process and release emotions on a regular basis. Every individual experiences frustration, disappointment, jealousy, anger, regret, and failure at different points in life. These emotions are natural. The real issue begins when they are not processed and instead accumulate silently over time.

Psychology refers to emotional release as catharsis-the process of expressing strong or suppressed emotions in a way that brings relief, clarity, and emotional balance. While the concept has existed since ancient philosophical traditions, modern psychology views it in a more practical and structured way: emotional expression is not just about "feeling better" but about preventing long-term psychological overload.

Scientific studies in behavioural medicine and psychology suggest that chronic emotional suppression is associated with increased stress, anxiety symptoms, and reduced cognitive flexibility. When emotions are continuously suppressed, the body remains in an activated state of stress response. This is closely linked to the stress response, where prolonged emotional pressure affects sleep quality, immune function, attention span, and even decision-making capacity. In simple terms, what the mind does not release, the body often carries.

This is why emotional hygiene is as important as physical hygiene. Just as we eat, sleep, and maintain physical cleanliness daily, the mind also requires regular "clearing" of emotional load. Without this, emotions do not disappear-they accumulate, influence thought patterns, and gradually shape



personality and perception.

Everyone, therefore, needs to develop a personal "venting system". This does not mean uncontrolled emotional outbursts. It means building healthy, consistent ways to release internal pressure before it becomes overwhelming.

For one person, this may be music-listening to songs that resonate with their emotional state and allow expression without words. For another, it may be writing thoughts in a journal, walking alone, exercising, talking to a trusted person, or simply sitting in silence and allowing feelings to surface without judgement. Even simple comforts such as food, rest, or engaging in hobbies can act as emotional release channels when used consciously.

The key idea is not the method but consistency. Emotional release is most effective when it becomes a daily or regular practice, not an occasional reaction during a crisis. A few minutes of honest reflection each day can

prevent emotional accumulation that later manifests as burnout or internal dissatisfaction.

One important misconception in society is that strong people do not need emotional release. In reality, strength without processing becomes a burden. Many individuals continue functioning efficiently on the outside while gradually losing emotional energy within. Over time, unresolved feelings such as regret, jealousy, anger, or repeated failure do not remain isolated experiences-they begin to shape one's outlook on life itself.

Research in positive psychology also highlights that emotional awareness and expression contribute significantly to life satisfaction. When individuals actively process emotions, they are more likely to experience psychological resilience, better relationships, and improved motivation. On the other hand, suppressed emotional patterns are associated with reduced interest in

life activities, decreased engagement, and emotional exhaustion.

This is where the danger lies. A life without emotional release does not collapse suddenly; it declines slowly. Interests fade, enthusiasm reduces, and life begins to feel like a burden rather than an experience. People often misinterpret this state as external failure, when in reality it is often internal emotional overload that has never been addressed.

For example, a student repeatedly facing academic pressure may not express disappointment after setbacks, choosing instead to immediately move on. A working professional may suppress frustration after workplace challenges in the name of professionalism. A homemaker may constantly prioritise others while ignoring personal emotional needs. In all these cases, the emotional experience is not absent-it is simply unprocessed.

Over time, this creates a psycholog-

ical backlog. The mind, instead of being refreshed, becomes cluttered with unresolved emotional experiences. This is why developing a daily emotional release practice is not optional-it is essential for maintaining mental clarity and long-term well-being.

The goal of emotional venting is not to eliminate negative emotions completely-that is neither possible nor healthy. The goal is to prevent emotional stagnation. Emotions are meant to move, not remain stuck. When they are acknowledged, expressed, and released in healthy ways, they lose their weight and allow space for new experiences.

It is also important to understand that emotional release does not mean a loss of control. It is actually a form of psychological self-regulation. When individuals consciously process emotions, they are less likely to react impulsively or carry emotional residue into unrelated areas of life. This leads to better decision-making, improved focus, and more stable relationships.

Therefore, building a personal emotional release routine is not just a wellness suggestion-it is a life skill. Just as we are taught discipline in education and work, we must also be taught emotional maintenance. This includes identifying feelings, acknowledging them without denial, and creating safe outlets for expression.

In conclusion, every individual should learn and practise their own way of emotional venting on a regular basis. Whether through communication, creativity, reflection, movement, or rest, the important factor is consistency. A few minutes each day dedicated to emotional processing can significantly improve mental stability and life satisfaction.

Otherwise, unprocessed emotions-regret, jealousy, anger, and repeated disappointment-do not remain passive. They slowly reduce enthusiasm for life, distort perception, and transform



existence into a burden.

Life becomes lighter when emotions are allowed to move. And perhaps true well-being is not about avoiding emotional weight, but about learning how to release it regularly, consciously, and wisely-so that we can continue living with clarity, interest, and inner balance.

In the end, life does not ask us to carry everything-it only asks us to stay aware of what we are carrying. Perhaps wisdom lies not in enduring more, but in knowing when to pause, when to feel, and when to gently let go. Emotions are not meant to be stored-they are meant to be lived, understood, and released. Because a mind that releases is not weaker; it is simply free enough to live again. And if we can learn this simple discipline of emotional clearing, then life does not remain a burden to survive, but becomes an experience to participate in fully, with clarity, balance, and renewed interest.

(The writer is a Nutritionist, Health Writer, and Wellness Coach)

It’s good that you’re confused

The more decisions you make, the more confused you are, and as a result, you swing between pain and pleasure. The more the witness grows in you, the more playful and untouched you are. Trust, faith, love, and joy all manifest in and around you



GURUDEV SRI SRI RAVI SHANKAR

A couple went to a Guru. They said, “We have two questions to ask.” Usually, in those days, questions weren’t answered immediately. The Guru said, “Then you have to do *seva* (service) here, for two years.” Each answer comes at a price. Two answers equal two years of *seva*. The husband and wife did *seva*, bringing water from the well, carrying it up the hill, tending the plants in the ashram, doing all the work, cooking, and looking after the cows, sheep, and buffalo. At the end of the second year, they went to the Guru. “Today, we have completed two years of service. We have two questions.” The Guru said, “What are your questions?” The couple said: Our first question is, ‘What is God?’, and the second one is, ‘What is life?’ The Guru said, “God is confused, and life is a problem.” They said, “This is where we were two years ago!”

Confusion arises when a concept breaks down. The question was, “What is God?” The answer the couple got was, “God is confused.” The ‘answer’ suggests that the problem lies in the expectation of a neat definition from the Guru, particularly after serving the Guru for 2 years. Know that expectations are a part of life; it is natural to expect. But when they come up, you should simply become aware that by expecting, you are only closing new avenues of growth. Expectations are based on set concepts. When a concept breaks down, it opens a new avenue of growth.

The third chapter in the ‘Bhagavad Gita’ begins with confusion. When Arjuna was already thoroughly confused, God confused him even more. Arjuna said, “Oh, my dear Krishna, you said, ‘Drop everything, don’t do anything,’ and at the same time you are saying ‘Do it!’ Tell me one thing, one definite thing. Don’t keep me in limbo. What should I do? You said, ‘You should act’, and then you say, ‘No, like a turtle, you take everything inside, and focus on yourself and meditate, be silent, be quiet. Take refuge in yoga, be equanimous.’ Then, the next moment, you say, ‘Come on, what would people think about you? They will think you are such a coward for running away from a battlefield. You aren’t doing your duty. Come on, wake up! Do your duty.’ Another time, you say, ‘Relax. You have no control over the action; it is all cause and effect. Everything happens by itself.” Arjuna says, “I am so confused! Please tell me one thing that I should do. When you say that you are satisfied, in your depth, is all joy, then why are you asking me to fight this war? Why are you putting me up for this horrible fight?”

“NOTHING IS PREDICTABLE IN THIS WORLD, ESPECIALLY THE MINDS OF PEOPLE. YOU DON’T KNOW WHO IS THINKING WHAT AND WHAT IS GOING TO HAPPEN THE VERY NEXT MOMENT”

— GURUDEV



WHEN YOU FACE
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SURRENDER HELPS RELAX
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YOUR MIND IS TOO BUSY.
RELAXATION HELPS
REKINDLE YOUR INTUITION,
AND INTUITION NEVER
GOES WRONG

Why are you putting me in this complicated world? I am ready to leave everything today and go to the Himalayas and sit there and meditate. I don’t want anything. I can eat fruits from the trees. I want nothing, but you are saying completely opposite things. I am already confused; you are confusing me even more. I have come to you not to get more confused. I want some clarity, but you are leading me into even more confusion. Tell me one thing that is good for me, which is beneficial for me, not that which pleases me. Help me evolve and uplift myself. Tell me that one thing.”

The need to make a decision comes only when there is confusion. When there is no confusion, then there is no decision. For example, if there is a

piece of wood and a biscuit on your desk, you don’t decide which one to eat, isn’t that right? A decision is always about choice, and choice is always confusing. Action is spontaneous when there is no actor. In you, there is an actor, and there is a witness. An actor is either confused or decisive, but the witness realises that the action is spontaneous and smiles.

The more decisions you make, the more confused you are, and as a result, you swing between pain and pleasure. The more the witness grows in you, the more playful and untouched you are. Trust, faith, love, and joy all manifest in and around you.

Your concept that things should be in a certain way causes pain in your mind. Set concepts in the mind are the causes of distress. And nature loves to give you surprises. God loves fun! He always gives you surprises; sometimes pleasant, sometimes unpleasant. You grow through both of them in life. In fact, you grow much more because of unpleasant surprises than from pleasant ones. Hence, behind each surprise there is a big message for you. When you know that all types of joy and sorrow are the result of concepts, you can see the reality as it is, without making concepts out of it again.

Nothing is predictable in this world, especially the minds of people. You don’t know who is thinking what and what is going to happen the very next moment.

Arjuna continued asking questions till the end. Finally, Krishna himself got fed up. He said, “I have already said whatever I could say. Now, Arjuna, you can do whatever you think is the best way forward.” And only then did Arjuna become aware of the value of surrender. He told Krishna that he would do whatever Krishna said.

When there is too much confusion, you need to find solace in surrender. Surrender to your Guru or the Divine and know that you aren’t alone. ‘Sharanagati’ is complete surrender with this deep feeling of devotion. In utterly confusing moments, if you surrender to divinity, your mind relaxes, and a relaxed mind is the harbinger of intuition. When you face conflicting choices, just relax. The state of surrender helps relax the mind. In relaxation, your intuition works, which you can rely on. Your intuitive abilities remain hidden when your mind is too busy. Relaxation helps rekindle your intuition, and intuition never goes wrong.

Tiny Voices, Timeless Echoes: How Children Are Carrying Indian Culture in the Modern Era

In an age where roots are fading, these young minds quietly hold on to them. Not only learning the Sanskrit language, but also reviving an entire culture. With verses on their lips and values in their lives, BAPS children are quietly taking India’s timeless wisdom to the world. In Vadodara, these young voices rose in unison and quietly entered the annals of the Guinness World Records. Through an extraordinary display of Sanskrit recitation and memorisation, these children transformed devotion into distinction. What echoed that day was not merely sound, but civilisation itself—ancient wisdom flowing through disciplined minds, turning a sacred tradition into a moment of global recognition



GYANANANDDAS SWAMI

In recent years, a subtle yet significant shift away from traditional learning has begun to reshape the educational landscape. The Vice-Chancellor of LBS Central University, Murli Manohar Pathak, says, “With increasing focus on global careers and digital lifestyles, traditional Sanskrit studies and value-based sanskar education are often sidelined. This shift is not sudden, but visible in reduced familiarity with basic prayers, scriptures, and cultural practices.”

In earlier times, recitation and memorisation (kanthpath) formed the backbone of learning within the gurukul tradition. Knowledge was absorbed through listening, repetition, and daily immersion. However, Sanskrit kanthpath, the disciplined memorisation of scriptures, was never meant to be a mere intellectual exercise; rather, it marked only the first step, with equal emphasis placed on living and embodying those teachings in daily life. The values embedded in these verses—truth, restraint, non-violence, compassion, and devotion—were meant to shape daily conduct.

In moments of confusion or hardship, these remembered words naturally resurface, offering direction without external dependence. In this way, kanthpath becomes a lifelong guide. It anchors an individual to cultural roots while providing an inner compass, ensuring that tradition is not just preserved, but actively lived.

Observing this reality, Mahant Swami Maharaj (Head and Guru, BAPS) has emphasised a practical and structured revival of Sanskrit and Sanskriti. On October 25, 2024, Swamiji expressed: “By next Diwali [2025], 10,000 children shall memorise this scripture [Satsang Diksha] in the Sanskrit language.”

The Satsang Diksha, written by Mahant Swami Maharaj himself, is not merely a Sanskrit scripture, but a daily guide to refined living. It gently nurtures values like love, peace, harmony, non-violence, and right behaviour, seamlessly guiding their application in daily life. Rooted in faith and devotion, this scripture beautifully weaves these ideals into a practical code of conduct, inspiring a life of meaningful co-existence and inner refinement.

To fulfil this resolve, the ‘Mission Rajipo’ (to please God) campaign was launched, in which 103 swamis and more than 17,000 volunteers worked with unwavering dedication to make the Guru’s resolve a reality.

The children were eager to accept this guru agya, yet they were scattered across the world, spanning America, Europe, Africa, Australia, and many parts of Asia. Even within India, many studied in English-medium schools and felt more comfortable in English than in Gujarati or Hindi. One can then imagine the challenge for those whose families had lived abroad for generations. Sanskrit, for them, seemed far beyond reach. Its reading, pronunciation, and memorisation appeared almost impossible.

Time posed another test: Swamiji had given just one year. Adding to this was the tender age of the participants; over 4,500 children between three and seven years old. Many were still learning to read, speak clearly, or manage simple daily tasks. Yet, within these challenges, determination, faith, and grace quietly began to grow.

Structured classes soon began, offering clear Sanskrit explanation, guided recitation, and practical support, enriched by personal encouragement and meaningful interaction. Equal care was given to the children’s academic lives. Many centres thoughtful-

ly provided study support alongside memorisation sessions without harming their leisure time. Throughout this journey, Mahant Swami Maharaj offered constant encouragement, while BAPS swamis and dedicated volunteers worked tirelessly to transform this noble vision into a living reality.

As a result, within just one year, a total of 15,666 children, aged 3 to 13 years, memorised all 315 Sanskrit verses of the Satsang Diksha text as a devotional tribute to Guru Mahant Swami Maharaj.

As if history itself sought to mark the occasion splendidly, the sun rose on February 2, 2026 with quiet grandeur. On the sacred 92nd birth anniversary of Mahant Swami Maharaj, 12,723 young scholars gathered in Vadodara and, in one unified voice, recited Sanskrit verses from memory, creating a Guinness World Records for the largest simultaneous Hindu text recital.

In the esteemed presence of adjudicator Swapnil Dangarikar, along with three university vice-chancellors and distinguished dignitaries, the achievement was carefully verified and formally recognised. The moment stood as a historic milestone, not only for BAPS but for the revival and global celebration of Sanskrit and Sanskriti.

This unique initiative has sparked a cultural revival, awakening deep appreciation for Sanskrit among the younger generation while strengthening their memory, focus, and academic growth. It has also nurtured character, instilling values like honesty, non-violence, respect, and patience in thousands of children.

(The writer Swami Gyanananddas is a dedicated follower of the Swaminarayan tradition and has earned a PhD from MS University)

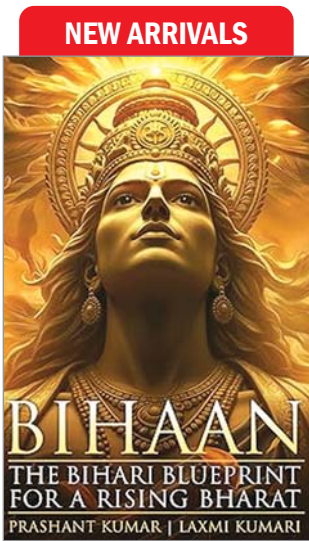


Rise of Bihar, rise of Bharat

TEAM AGENDA

Bihaan: The Bihari Blueprint for a Rising Bharat presents a compelling vision of India’s future rooted in the resurgence of Bihar. It argues that India’s rise as a global power is inseparable from the revival of its historic heartland. Far from being peripheral, Bihar is positioned as the civilisational core whose progress is essential to national transformation. The book weaves together themes of identity, governance, entrepreneurship, education, technology, and diaspora engagement to outline a practical roadmap for growth. It highlights Bihar’s deep cultural legacy, from ancient republics to intellectual traditions, as a foundation for renewed confidence and leadership in modern India. At its heart, *Bihaan* is both a reflection and a call to action. It urges builders, educators, policymakers, and creators to reconnect with Bihar’s strengths and

contribute to shaping resilient communities and sustainable opportunities. The authors emphasise discipline, pride, and collective responsibility as drivers of this transformation. The book frames the “Bihar Question” as central to India’s destiny. It envisions a future where the spirit of Magadh converges with innovation and enterprise, making Bihar not just a participant but a leader in India’s journey, marking the dawn of a confident, self-assured Bharat.

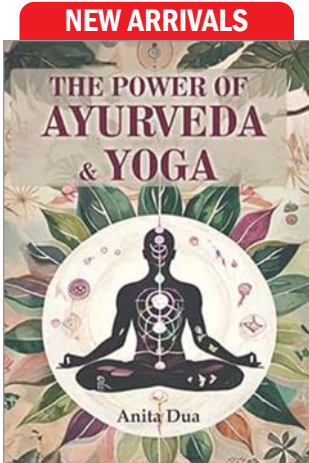


Title: Bihaan
Author: Prashant Kumar and Laxmi Kumari
MRP: ₹599
Publisher: BLUONE INK

TEAM AGENDA

In an age of fast-paced living and rising lifestyle diseases, *The Power of Ayurveda & Yoga* arrives as both a reminder and a guide. It bridges ancient Vedic wisdom with modern scientific sensibility, offering readers a grounded pathway to balance, clarity, and well-being. The book brings together two deeply interconnected systems—Ayurveda and Yoga—and presents them not as abstract philosophies, but as practical tools for everyday living.

At its core, the book views health as a natural state of balance, while illness is described as a condition



Title: The Power of Ayurveda & Yoga
Author: Anita Dua
MRP: ₹1295
Publisher: Shubhi Publications

of being “not at ease,” arising when individuals drift away from nature’s rhythms.

Dua explains key Ayurvedic principles such as the three doshas—Vata, Pitta, and Kapha—which determine an individual’s constitution. Through this lens, the book guides readers to understand their body and mind, restoring balance through simple, mindful practices.

Beyond being a yoga expert and author, Anita Dua brings academic depth and social commitment to her work, with a postgraduate degree in Economics and experience across institutions and international development organisations. She also contributes to social service through the Subhash Dua Memorial Trust and writes on nutrition and health. The book’s strength lies in its

practical approach, offering step-by-step guidance on yogic asanas, pranayama, Ayurvedic therapies like Panchakarma, and lifestyle alignment with natural cycles. Its central message is clear: wellness is not achieved externally but restored through harmony with oneself and nature.

A discussion on *The Power of Ayurveda & Yoga* was held at the India International Centre, where experts like Devendra Triguna and Ananthram Sharma PV highlighted Ayurveda’s relevance today. The conversation emphasised disciplined living, the role of Ayurveda in lifestyle disorders, and the need to reintegrate ancient wisdom into modern life.

More than a one-time read, the book is a guide to conscious living and lasting well-being.

A journey into holistic living